

A woman with long dark hair is lying down, her eyes closed. A single red rose is balanced on her nose. She is wearing a red lace-trimmed top. Her arms are raised above her head, holding the stem of the rose. The background is a soft, out-of-focus white.

KENNY WRIGHT
ROSE
BLOOMS

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ANDY

Andy heard his wife come home just as he was about to turn off the light and go to bed. He darkened his phone and glanced at the clock—almost eleven—and wondered how it got so late. He'd intended to go to bed an hour ago.

The Internet, of course, and a search that began, embarrassingly, with the Googled question: "*Am I having a midlife crisis?*" He set his phone on the nightstand and vowed one more time to store the thing downstairs from now on.

The searching and browsing and reading had put an interesting question in his head, though. One he blurted as soon as Rose stepped through the bedroom door.

"So honey, would you think it would be crazy if I started going by 'Drew'?"

Rose stopped in the doorway, staring at him with a vague, contemplative look, like he'd just asked her a riddle in a language that she barely understood.

Saying it outloud sounded much sillier than he'd imagined. He said, "Um, I know, it's kind of... it's different. But, I was reading... and sometimes, I've read that..." He took a deep breath, withering under his wife's silence. "You know how I signed up for that conference next month? I was thinking of changing my badge name to 'Drew' just to try it—"

"Jordan and Louis are separated," she blurted.

"—try it out..." He stopped. "I'm sorry, what?"

For the first time, he actually looked at his wife and realized that her puzzled state of mind had nothing to do with his name-change idea. She wandered into the room, as if blown by an invisible wind, going to the dresser, where her nighttime ritual usually began. Only instead of taking her earrings off, she just stood there.

Facing away from Andy, she said, "He's not been living there for the last month."

"I thought he'd just been traveling." Jordan and Louis were their neighbors, living in the town home two doors down from them.

Rose turned around, leaning on the dresser. She was still lost in thought. "Yeah, me too."

"That's..." Andy raked his hand through his hair. "I never suspected anything. I mean, they just seemed so..."

"Normal?" Rose helped out. She gave a laugh without any mirth. "From what I learned tonight, they're definitely not normal."

Jordan had asked Rose to come over for a glass of wine after everyone's kids were in bed. It wasn't unusual. The two were friendly, if not friends, and Andy was just happy that his wife was getting out and socializing.

"What did you learn? Did Louis cheat on her?"

Rose slowly shook her head. "No," she said, drawing out the single syllable.

Andy's jaw fell. "*She* cheated on *him*?"

Rose shook her head, quicker this time, snapping out of her daze. "No, it wasn't that. Not exactly."

Andy groaned. "What then? Come on, Rose, you're killing me."

"Sorry, sorry." She put her hands on her forehead and rubbed her temples with her thumbs. "I'm still trying to wrap my head around it, and I think I've had too much wine."

She floated over to Andy's side of the bed, her slender body making the barest impression on the mattress as she sat. He ran a hand up her leg, smooth and shapely. She'd gone over wearing a casual pair of jean shorts—mom shorts, she called them—but they left enough of her legs bare that he should have noticed.

"So whose idea was it? To separate?"

"Jordan's. Louis is pretty devastated."

"What... why?"

Rose fixed him with a very meaningful stare. Reaching back, she tugged on her auburn ponytail—a nervous tell of hers. “You can’t tell *anyone* about this.” Then, with a nervous sigh, added, “I know you wouldn’t. Just... promise me, okay?”

Andy’s gut began to tighten, like she was about to deliver some bad news about the two of *them*, not a couple of neighbors that they only kind of, sort of knew.

“She said that he wanted her to...” Color sprung into Rose’s cheeks, bright red against her fair complexion. She averted her eyes, realized she did it, and seemed to force herself to look at him. Lowering her voice, she finished. “He wanted her to have sex with other men.”

Andy blinked. He understood each individual word, but all together, they didn’t make sense. “What?”

Rose already had large, golden-brown eyes. They grew wider as she stared down at him. “He told her that he wants to see her, you know... *with* another guy?”

Andy sank back into his pillows, blowing a loud breath through his lips. “He’s got to be cheating on her. Or trying to find some excuse to cheat, right?”

“That’s what we think, too.”

“That’s so...it’s nuts. Jordan’s great!”

Rose rolled her eyes. “Mmm, hmm.”

His crush on their neighbor was no secret to her. With her dark blonde hair and curvy body, he’d always thought that she was hot, and Rose never begrudged him. So she always maintained, anyway.

“I just mean, you know...she’s given up so much for him.” Like moving here for his job, away from her law practice back home and her family.

“I’m sure that’s exactly what you mean,” Rose said, patting his hand sarcastically. “You men...”

“Hey, don’t lump me in with him. You know that I only have eyes for you, babe.”

Andy walked those eyes up her body now. Aside from her jean shorts, she wore a sleeveless, checked blouse that didn’t quite hide the black straps of her bra.

She laughed at him softly, reaching down to caress his face. “It’s okay, I know she’s pretty.”

“Not as pretty as you.” It was the truth, but also something he’d started taking for granted lately.

Rose snorted. “She said things haven’t been great between them for a while. They hadn’t been connecting.”

We haven’t been connecting, Andy thought he heard. Or maybe he was just being sensitive. “That can happen. Life can just sort of fill everything up if you’re not careful.”

Rose nodded, looking down at him. Focusing on him.

He felt self-conscious under that stare. “What?”

She shook her head, as if she was going to let it go, but then decided not to. Or maybe she just changed the thing she was going to say. “I love you, sweetheart.”

“I love you, too,” he said automatically. Then he realized that it had been automatic and took a deep breath to re-center himself. He tried again, “I love you, Rose. I’m still *in love* with you.”

Her smile was the sheepish one that he’d fallen in love with. The one that made him risk everything to ask her on a date, even though he was her T.A. and would definitely be fired if anyone found out.

Her hand was still on his cheek, and Andy turned to kiss it. Taking it into his own hand, he caressed the soft skin as he pulled her wrist to his lips, kissing her there, too. Like her namesake, she smelled like roses, her perfume subtle but ever present.

Andy reached up, pulling her down to him. She smiled as their lips meet, too tight to kiss. At first. Then, she tilted her head and slipped a tongue into his mouth, and they were *kissing*. Andy couldn’t remember the last time they’d kissed like this. He couldn’t remember the last time they’d have sex, either, he thought with a huge amount of guilt.

He’d fix that tonight.

Rose seemed seized with the same determination. They stripped quickly, with the efficiency of a couple used to doing this thing in a hurry. He pulled his shirt off as Rose opened her blouse.

“That new?” he asked, staring at the black bra, with its lacy edges and the way it lifted her creamy breasts to his eyes.

She laughed. “I got it two years ago.” She wiggled her hips as she slipped her jean shorts down. Beneath was a pair of boy-short panties. “These are, though.”

“Cute.” Maybe it was the color, or the way her plush ass filled out her panties. Maybe it’s the guilt that he was feeling for not paying attention to his wife recently. Whatever it was, she looked amazing, and there was nothing actually cute about her.

Unlike most fair-skinned women, Rose could actually tan. A little, anyway. Enough that he could see the criss-crossing lines of her bathing suit, which reminded him how good she looked in a bathing suit, which made him want her more.

He pulled off his boxers and like that, Andy was completely naked in front of his wife. She climbed up over him, her lean body hot as he ran his hands across it. He made quick work of her bra, untwisting it with one hand as they kissed.

“You’ve still got it,” she said, smiling down at him.

“Like riding a bike.”

Reaching down, she ran her fingers across his flaccid cock. He wished he was harder and sensed a little disappointment in his wife. To his surprise, Rose pushed him back into the pillows and climbed under the sheets and between his legs. He pulled those sheets away just in time to watch her take him into her mouth.

“Oh, honey.” He groaned as her tongue bathed him. He began to harden—not just because of how good it felt, but because of how hot it looked. She hadn’t given him an actual blowjob in years. Now, watching her cheeks hollow out and hearing the loud slurp ring out through their bedroom, he wanted more.

But she didn’t pull off when he got hard. She kept sucking, bobbing along his length and getting her hands into the fellatio. Her gags burned in his ears. He felt bad for her, but he loved it. Loved how dirty it sounded. Loved it as he felt his cockhead flirt with the back of her throat. He wanted to grab her, push her down, get her to take him to the root. He didn’t, because he was afraid he’d ruin the mood. Even without it, though, he felt his orgasm approach.

“Rose,” he said. She didn’t stop. If anything, she redoubled her efforts, pulling her ponytail to the side so he could watch her unobstructed. She had her eyes closed, but in that moment, as he said her name, they opened, locking on to his. He saw passion in those brilliant brown irises—need, desire, pride. “Rose, I need to feel you...”

She let him go, couching a little as she did so, then laughing that she had. “I’m out of practice,” she said, her voice husky.

“I’m always available to help with the rust.”

She slid up his body, kicking her panties off as she did. “I’m sorry I don’t do it more often.”

It was a weird thing to say, but before he could ask why she said it, her hips were over his and his cock was in her hand. He looked down, watching as she positioned him against her wet pussy. She was smooth down there, shaved down to a dark auburn wedge for the summer. Like she always did. That used to turn him on so much—the fact that she groomed it so neatly. Even that he now took for granted.

She sighed softly as she took him inside of her, her eyes fluttering shut. He reached up, cupping her tits. He followed her tan lines again, where her suit cut along her chest. Her stomach was pale, and he thumbed her navel, where the dimple of her piercing still remained, evidence of her pre-children belly ring.

“You should get this redone,” he said.

“I’m a little old for that, don’t you think?”

“You’re 33. That’s definitely not ‘old.’”

They’d had this conversation before. She knew he liked the piercing, but she maintained that she was past that point in her life now. She had two children, now both in elementary school—an eight and a six-year-old. She was working again, a professional. She was no longer the type of woman who wore navel jewelry.

To his surprise, though, she didn’t shut him down with those usual arguments. Instead, she placed her hands on his shoulders, looked him in the eyes, and said, “I’ll think about it.”

“Really?”

“Sure, why not. If you think it’s sexy.”

He wasn’t sure what to make of this new found openness. “In that case, you should also wear a bikini.”

Rose snorted a laugh. “Anything else? Want me to shave my bush off, too?”

His cock swelled inside of her. He’d been riding on an edge since her blowjob. The mere thought of Rose going bare was hot enough to trigger him—that she offered it herself was too much. His balls tightened as he

started to crest. From there, nothing could stop him. The power of his orgasm reared up and dumped him into the abyss.

Somewhere, vaguely, he was aware that his wife was moaning—loud, unrestrained cries of “*Andy, come! Oh, please come!*” He reached down, grabbing her hips. He pulled her into him, thrusting up, deep, as deep as he could. Everything froze. Everything was still in that long, pregnant moment.

And he was coming. *They* were coming. Her eyes were shut, and he watched her writhe over him like he’d been knocked out of his body. Then, with a snap, he was whole again, collecting her into his arms, pulling her in for a long, lingering kiss.

Their bodies were slick with sweat. He was breathing hard, even though he’d barely done any of the work. Rose relaxed into him, resting her head on his shoulder as he stroked her silky, damp hair.

“Mmm... that was fun,” she whispered.

“Agreed. Why don’t we do that all the time?”

Rose shifted until she was propped up on an elbow. She looked serious. “We used to.”

“We did.”

“Remember ‘office hours’?” she asked.

Office hours, when she used to come visit him when she was his student, and they’d fuck on his desk.

“How could I forget? I still can’t believe I didn’t get fired.”

“Yeah,” she said, wistfulness in her voice. Like he’d said the wrong thing. Or maybe she was just tired. “I can’t believe Jordan and Louis.”

“Is it over? Or you think they’ll work it out?”

“I hope they work it out. I don’t know. I really don’t.”

“Think I should call Louis? See if he wants to talk?”

“Hmm...” Sleep was slowly taking Rose. He stroked her hair as he thought about how that meeting would go.

“*So I heard your wife kicked you out because you told her you wanted to watch her have sex with other men.*”

Rose must have been thinking the same thing. She said, “I don’t know. Might be weird.” She dragged herself up off of him and stood, grinning back at him. “But maybe you should. You two could exchange midlife crisis stories.”

Her ponytail was half-undone, so she ended up just pulling it free and shaking out the burnished, dark red locks. Scratching her hair, she yawned. “He can tell you about this strange wife-watching fantasy of his, and you can run the name ‘Drew’ by him.”

She laughed, pleased with her joke as she wandered naked into the bathroom, distracting him with her jiggling, heart-shaped butt.

He lay there, thinking about Louis and what may or may not have been a real fantasy. It was so odd. So unbelievable. Just the thought of Rose *flirting* with another man sent an uncomfortable tightness through him, the chilly fingers of jealousy stirring in his gut.

He watched her there, at the sink, comfortable enough around him that she brushed her teeth naked, with the door open. Imagining that she could behave like that with someone else was crazy.

Yet once upon a time, before they were a couple, there must have been other guys. She was far from a virgin when they met, and when they were fucking during that illicit semester, she definitely had other guys.

And you hated those guys, too, he reminded himself.

That should have settled it. He thought it did as sleep came and took him.

Except that deep down, the seed had been planted.

ROSE

“**A**ndy wants me to get a bikini.”

Jordan laughed and gave her friend a once over. They were at the pool of their townhome complex, watching their kids splash and play.

“You should do it, Rose. I would if I had your body.”

“You’re wearing a bikini right now,” Rose said with a chuckle.

“I would with my body, too.”

Rose had a beach volleyball player’s body. Jordan just has a beach body. Her cleavage attracted even Rose’s eyes to it, a deep, tight crevasse held together by her black bikini top. She was thankful for her sunglasses so she didn’t appear like some kind of letch.

“So how are you doing?” Rose asked, changing the subject. “You talk to Louis?”

“He came by yesterday because I had book club.” Jordan unfastened her hair and shook it out. Rose wondered if her blonde highlights were natural or not as she watched the woman reform her ponytail. “He’s so good with the kids. We talked some, but not about—”

“Mommy, come!” Lillian, Jordan’s four-year-old, was shouting from the edge of the pool, where she’d paddled over in her floaties. “Come, Mommy!”

Jordan sighed and turned to Rose. “You want to get a drink some time? Like, out somewhere? Where other adults go to also drink?”

Rose laughed. “Sure.”

“Mom—*my!* ”

Jordan took a deep breath, held it for a moment, and released it loudly. “Let’s do it sooner rather than later.”

Rose watched her go, and she wasn’t alone. Guys were openly checking Jordan out as she padded over to her daughter and hopped into the pool. Some of the other moms looked on in envy, and Rose had to check herself not to be one of them.

Women like Jordan made her feel like the awkward, lanky girl she was in high school. She felt her shoulders slump into the bad, tall-girl habit she’d thought that she’d kicked in college. Jordan appeared comfortable in her own skin, neither shy nor showy. If others wanted to look, she seemed to say, let them look.

Not that there was anything particularly risqué about her bikini, other than that it was a bikini. While the top was a halter, fastening behind her neck, the straps were wide and the bottom covered as much of her butt as Rose’s. Maybe Rose could pull off a bikini.

She shifted her thoughts to the conversation she had with Andy a few nights back—thoughts of complacency and marital ruts. She’d been having those thoughts a lot, recently. Even before the Jordan-Louis bombshell. That only brought the stakes into vivid relief.

She’d read about couples getting separated and divorced all the time, but it took one happening to someone so close for Rose to be shocked by it. It made her think about her own marriage.

She loved Andy, and couldn’t imagine sharing a life with anyone else. She looked around. The pool was teeming with kids screaming and splashing and having a good time. Along the perimeter, the parents with older kids socialized in small groups. Someone was grilling hot dogs.

This was Chesterbrook in a nutshell—its cul-de-sacs and roundabouts, parks and playgrounds, filled with young families because it was a community ideal for raising children in.

“Mom, can I go play at Nico’s?” her oldest, Charlie, asked. At his side was Nico, his best friend, skinny and dripping wet.

“As long as his mother says it’s okay—”

“She says it’s fine, Mrs. Shaw!”

Rose laughed, but still looked for Nico’s mom, who was gathering her things on the opposite side of the pool. She waved at Rose and gave a nod.

“Fine, go ahead.”

“I want to go, too!” her youngest, Lucas, whined.

“And take your brother!” Rose shouted after Charlie and Nico. They were already at the pool’s gate, without bothering to put on shoes or shirt. Lucas raced to catch up with the older boys. “Thanks, Michelle!” she said to Nico’s mom.

“I’ll bring them home before dinner.”

Rose smiled. She liked Michelle, but despite their kids being so close, she didn’t know the woman all that well. Nico was Michelle’s youngest, as opposed to Charlie being her oldest. Like Jordan, they were in different places—acquaintances more than friends. She wondered if the older woman had secrets, too. She wondered if all was as perfect as they seemed on the outside.

No one’s perfect, she thought.

The gate to the pool swung open and a new man walked in. Rose watched him from behind her sunglasses, the way she always watched this particular man. She didn’t know his name. She didn’t know much about him other than that he appeared to be single, and he shared roughly the same commuting schedule with her.

Rose sighed. She was about to leave, but now that he was here, she was compelled to stay. Grabbing her Kindle, she tried her best to ignore him as he settled into a lounge just off to her left.

She’d first noticed him at her bus stop early in the winter. He wasn’t the only resident of Chesterbrook to ride the bus at 8 every morning, but with his broad shoulders and clear, blue eyes, he was definitely the most attractive. When she first saw him at the pool, she felt like a giddy school girl, seeing her celebrity crush shirtless for the first time.

Surreptitiously, she watched as he pulled his shirt off now and couldn’t stop her sigh. He had abs, for one, rippling and clearly delineated beneath his broad chest and the crop of light brown curls. She practically licked her lips as she traced the lines at his hips, lines that disappeared suggestively into his swim trunks. When he started to rub sunblock onto his thick arms, she forced herself to look away again.

He wasn’t always at her bus stop, but when he did show up, they only ever smiled at one another. She thought about this man’s life, too, and what possessed him to settle down in such a family-oriented neighborhood without the family. He never brought a child to the pool. He didn’t wear a ring. And she never ran into him at anyone’s barbecue.

He walked to the edge of the pool, first dipping his toe in. Then, fixing his goggles into place, he dove cleanly into the water, along an empty lane of the pool, and began to swim laps. Rose watched those arms slice in and out of the water, his shoulder blades powerful, his strokes graceful.

You need to get a grip, she thought. But she kept watching over the edge of her Kindle. She barely read a thing. And when he hoisted himself up out of the pool, water streaming down his muscled torso, he caught her staring.

She went bright red. He just nodded to her, his smile soft, and went back to his lounge.

That was how they always greeted one another—here, or at the bus stop, or those rare times she'd bumped into him at the grocery store. They acknowledged one another, smiled, but never said a word.

That didn't change that afternoon. She stayed for another fifteen minutes or so before gathering her things and leaving. Despite walking right by him, she made it a point not to look at him.

Even though every molecule in her body wanted to.

Even though she tingled all over as she imagined his eyes, hidden behind his own aviators, on her. What would he think if she wore a bikini? And why did that thought motivate her to go out and try them on, more than her own husband's?

She got out of there before she allowed herself to feel too guilty. It was just a silly crush. It was nothing, and would lead nowhere.

Only she now lived in a world where her neighbors were getting separated. Things had consequences. Even silly things, like a crush on a man she hardly knew. Why hadn't she told Andy about it? After all, she knew about Andy's own crush on Jordan.

Andy's text snapped her out of it.

[Andy]: Hey, I'm in the mood for Chinese. Should I pick some up on the way home?

[Rose]: Sounds great!

She heard her own perky voice in her response, although she didn't feel perky. Instead, she looked around, taking in the family pictures that

decorated the mantle over their gas fireplace. She took down her wedding photo, studied it.

There was that young couple, ready to set out on a new adventure together. Before kids. Before routine. Back when she wasn't just in love with Andy, but still *falling* in love. Would that woman in the white dress, too skinny for her own good, look twice at bus stop stranger? She sighed.

Andy looked the same, aside from the flecks of gray now at his temples and a little more weight around his face. He was still handsome in his professorial way, despite no longer being in academia. He even wore the same glasses, horn-rimmed and intellectual.

It wasn't hard for her to remember what it was like, back in those days. How drawn she was to him and his sophistication. He taught her how to enjoy wine and cheese. He invited her to plays, when all the guys her age took her to loud clubs and crowded concerts. He was more her speed. She could see a life with him where none of her other long-term experiments ever worked out.

And then there were "office hours," when neither of them behaved like those sophisticated, mature individuals they played at. When they let their passions get the better of them. When she'd want him so badly that she'd crawl beneath his desk and suck his cock, right there in the university office.

She set the photo back on the mantle. Grabbing the pool bag, she stepped out on their back porch and began spreading the towels over the railing to dry.

She could see Charlie, Nico, and Lucas on the playground out back. They were sitting on the top of the monkey bars, discussing something very serious. Lucas looked up, as though sensing her. She could see his smile, even from where she stood.

He waved. She waved back, and felt a smile tug at the corners of her mouth. They may not have office hours anymore, but they had a great life. She needed to remember that.

ANDY

“**T**hanks for suggesting this. It’s exactly what I needed.” Louis picked up his pilsner glass of Bud Light and drained half of it as Andy watched. It was odd, hanging out with this man, knowing what he knew.

“Of course, man. Sorry it wasn’t under better circumstances.”

“Jordan’s always telling me I should get out more.” It’s like he didn’t even hear Andy, which was fine.

“Rose, too.”

The silence stretched. The men drank their beers and watched a few pitches of the baseball game playing behind the bar. Louis ordered another. Andy was trying to pace himself.

“So you and Rose are good? Kids good?” Louis had a Jersey accent, although there was very little Jersey about him.

“Yeah.” This was weird—talking about his family when Louis’s was in shambles. “So you want to talk about anything? With, you know, you and Jordan?”

Louis didn’t immediately answer. So long that Andy almost let him off the hook. Instead, the man drained his beer, signaled for another, and turned to Andy.

“Let me be a precautionary tale, young Ebenezer. One hundred percent honesty in a marriage is total bullshit.”

“It’s funny, I was always told that communication is central to a happy marriage.”

Louis took the new beer from the bartender before it was even set down in front of him and gestured to Andy with it. "Communication does *not* mean telling each other everything. Do you tell Rose about the porn you look at?"

"I don't look at porn," Andy lied. When Louis looked at him sideways, he relented. "I don't look at that much, but no, I don't. But Louis, it's one thing to keep some porn to yourself. Another woman..." Andy lowered his voice. "Cheating, that's, like, another level. That'll fester."

He nodded, staring into his drink like he could read things in the bubbles rising through it. "That's what Jordan told you guys?"

"She..." Andy wondered if he'd misstepped. Was he not supposed to say anything? "She talked to Rose, not me. But Rose said something..." How was he going to bring this aspect up?

Louis helped out. Three drinks in and he'd seemed to have lost his inhibitions. "Jordan told her about my little fantasy."

"Yeah."

"And you guys collectively jumped to the conclusion that I must be cheating on her."

"Pretty much."

Louis laughed humorlessly. "See? Honesty fucks everything all up."

Andy watched his neighbor carefully, trying to puzzle him out. "You're not?"

"Dude, are you crazy? I know you check Jordan out. She's an eleven, you know? Why would I ever risk that?"

Andy shrugged. "People do all kinds of crazy, irrational things when they're not thinking clearly."

"Sure. Like tell their wife that it turns him on when he sees her flirting with other guys. Or that if she ever wanted to, she could go further."

"You told her that?"

Louis snorted. "One too many times, apparently."

Andy didn't know what to say. He tried to put himself in Louis's place, watching Rose flirt with other men. Watching her laugh at another man's jokes, tugging her ponytail as she sheepishly met his eyes before quickly looking away.

"Doesn't that make you..." Thoughts of Rose churned his guts. "Don't you get jealous?"

"Oh, yeah, man. That's part of it."

Andy shook his head. "I don't get it."

Louis paused, contemplating what to say next. This was the Louis that Andy thought he knew—introspective and profoundly intelligent because of it. Like he was always working through a problem. This silence wasn't the awkward one of before. This was more like a patient waiting for a doctor interpreting some test results.

"You ever do something really risky and gotten away with it? Shoplifted something as a kid or skied a black diamond when you weren't ready?" He looked away, embarrassed. "Had sex somewhere public? Under the bleachers or something?"

And because Rose brought it up the other night, Andy thought: *In my very public office with a student?*

"Yeah, sure."

"Okay, think about that feeling. All the fear, the danger. It was exciting, right?"

Andy remembered the first time she visited him in the office like it was yesterday. They'd actually already gone out on a couple dates—one far away from the university so they wouldn't be noticed, the other at his apartment, where he cooked them dinner. That night led to amazing, mind-blowing, illicit sex. Sex so good that Rose, smart, studious Rose, came to his office in a short skirt and no panties. She locked the door behind her without saying a word. He fucked her right on the desk that he graded her own papers.

"Yeah, really exciting."

"That's how I feel when I see Jordan flirting with some guy and think it could be more. It's wrong, it's risky and crazy and out-of-control, but all those things just make it hotter."

"Okay. I sort of get that." He got the sensation, anyway. "Have you always felt this way?"

"I honestly don't know. Not as strongly as I do now. Now, it's like all I can fucking think about. Lately, I'd see Jordan exchanging a smile with a guy at the checkout counter at the grocery and start imaging the two of them fucking."

"And rather than getting possessive and jealous, you...what?" Then, thinking better of the question, Andy quickly added, "Nevermind."

"No, that's just it. I do get jealous. Maybe not possessive—Jordan's not someone who can be owned—but I definitely feel all sick and insecure. I go

through these big cycles where I feel like I don't deserve her, but I want her to be happy, so—"

"So you've started coping by embracing the idea of her being happy with other guys."

Louis nodded. "So says my therapist."

"You know you're definitely good enough for her, right? You guys have a great life together. I always looked at the two of you and thought that you guys had it figured out. Great kid. Good jobs. You talk about intellectual things like a couple professors. Reminds me of when I was at the university."

"That's funny. That's kind of our impression of you and Rose." He drank. "No, before me, Jordan dated *guys* . Dudes. Arrogant men, you know?"

"I'm aware of the type," Andy said. He wondered if Rose liked guys like that. They never talked much about her life before him.

"I'm so not like that. In fact, I was the friend that she complained to when these guys inevitably fucked things up. When I first asked her out, it was mostly as a joke."

Andy studied Louis. It was so strange. Louis was a good looking guy. He had dark brown hair and striking dark eyes. His smile was easy and dimpled. He didn't seem like the type to be so insecure.

"Anyway, you get the idea. I never felt good enough. Was a paranoid wreck at first. Guess I've always been just waiting for the other shoe to drop."

"And then she kicked you out because you got too paranoid," Andy said.

"That would be fittingly ironic, wouldn't it? But actually, no." He could barely meet Andy's eyes. "You need to not tell anyone about this next thing, okay?"

"Umm... sure?"

"Like, not even Rose."

"I don't know, man—"

"She kicked me out because when she finally did slip, I didn't get angry and possessive and pissed off. I didn't kick her out immediately. I did the opposite. I wanted to hear the details. I wanted her to keep fucking the guy."

Andy was stunned. He stared at Louis, trying to figure out if he'd missed the punchline of a joke. "I'm sorry, what?"

Louis sighed. The momentary energy that had boosted him seemed to drain away. He pinched his nose and looked back into his drink. "About two months ago, Jordan had an affair. Or, I guess, it was a one-time thing. A mistake."

"Jesus, man, I'm sorry."

"See, that's just it. That's the appropriate reaction you should have, but I want to tell you not to be sorry. That it's hot as hell."

This man might as well have been talking in another language.

"I'd been gone on a trip. Couple days. Apparently it happened then. She'd gone to a parents' night thing for the end of school. You know the ones."

"I think we may have been there," Andy mumbled. He tried to remember the night, remember Jordan, but couldn't. It was so crowded, everyone packed into the small hallways of the elementary school. "It happened there?"

"No, no. She went out afterwards, since she had a babysitter. Out with some of the other free parents. She had a few too many, and when they were all leaving... I guess she didn't leave. Started talking to some guy there, and the next thing they knew, she was in the back of his Jeep, getting pounded by his apparently enormous cock."

"She told you it was enormous?"

"After some probing." Louis laughed bitterly. "She asked me why I cared so much about the size of his dick. Asked me if maybe I wanted to go sample it myself."

"Ouch," Andy said, although he was thinking the same thing.

"I don't, by the way. It's just part of the fantasy."

"Not really a fantasy anymore." Andy looked behind the bar, where the baseball game went on. He wished they were back to that awkward time when that game was the most interesting thing in the room. He ordered another beer for himself instead. "So how does this figure into your analogy of risk-taking? Sounds like you crashed and injured yourself skiing that black diamond."

"Except that that's not how it works. Or, I guess, not in this situation. I don't know. She felt awful about it. Told me as soon as I got home. She seemed ready for me to kick her out, despite all that she knew about me and my fantasy." He traced swirls in the condensation of his glass. "She went from remorseful to pissed off real fast, though."

“That’s... wow. I’m not sure what to say.”

Louis shrugged and patted Andy on the back. “Don’t say anything. Listening is enough. I’ve had this whole fantasy buried inside of me, wanting to get out. I mostly kept it to myself, even with Jordan. So talking at all with another human is a huge help.”

Andy wasn’t sure if he wanted to be this kind of confidante, but here he was.

“I still can’t believe that Jordan... would do something like that.”

“Our marriage counselor says it has a lot to do with me. Like I primed her to make that mistake. I say we all have it in us. You, me, Rose. Just need the right circumstances.”

“I don’t know, man. That’s pretty cynical.”

Louis shrugged. “We have hot wives. I’d say it’s more realistic.”

“I trust Rose.”

“And I’m not saying you shouldn’t. That’s your strategy to deal with all the attention she gets. Mine is less conventional.”

“I’d say so.” Andy called for the check. As he waited, he asked, “You going to be okay?”

“Yeah, we’ll work it out. Jordan and I have been together for a long time. We’ll get through this thing.”

“She can’t be the woman you want her to be, you know. You’re going to need to let that go.”

Louis nodded, although Andy wasn’t sure whether he was acknowledging what he’d said, or answering the bartender as he asked to put it all on one card.

“Thanks again for meeting up with me,” he said. “This was good.”

“Any time, man. Seriously, any time you need to talk.”

“I’ll take you up on that.” They rose. “Remember, keep all this to yourself, okay? Don’t tell your wife.”

“Got it.”

ROSE

Rose felt the house shudder all the way up in the bedroom as Andy closed the front door. Good thing their kids were such heavy sleepers, she thought, turning one last time to the mirror set into the closet door. She surveyed herself and her little surprise. The bikini was tasteful, she told herself as she swiveled around. Andy probably would have wanted her to pick up a string bikini, but he would have to do with the deep burgundy two-piece. The wrap-top felt fun and stylish, and she'd matched it with a full-coverage bottom with the same detail.

But that wasn't her only surprise. She fingered the silver belly bar that sat in the center of her navel—the navel that she'd repierced. She felt so silly doing it, like a teenager all over again. She'd even done it at the mall, where she'd gone to look for the bikini. It wasn't like it was a new thing, she told herself, and if she'd never had the kids, she'd still probably have the piercing.

She thought of the version of her in the white dress. She thought of office hours. She knew she had to make an effort. This was part of that effort.

"Rose," Andy said. He stumbled into the bedroom, out of breath. "Rose, you'll never..." His words died on his lips when he saw her standing there, posing in her bikini before the mirror.

"Oh, honey, you're home," she said, turning to him.

"Wow."

"You like it? I picked it up today." She ran her hand across her stomach. It was never going to get as flat as it had been, but she was still proud of it.

“I think... you look amaz—you got your belly pierced, too?”

Rose giggled. It had been so long since he'd really, truly stumbled over himself like this. She fingered the piercing, running her fingertips along the shimmering, red stone at its base. “I did. Isn't that what you wanted?”

Andy's mouth actually fell open as she approached him. The last time *that* had happened was when she first visited him during office hours. Time to get that feeling back.

“So tell me, Andy...” She reached around him, closing the door and locking it. “...what did you want to tell me?”

He didn't answer. She didn't expect him to. He kissed her, sliding his hand down the bare skin of her lower back. She pressed close, melting into the kiss. He tasted like beer and she could smell the feral sweat beneath his t-shirt.

“I want you,” he murmured between kisses. She pulled his shirt off, kissing his neck, her hands all over his chest. He felt good, but in a familiar way. She wanted to feel something different, something naughty.

“I want you, too,” she said, sinking to her knees. He stared down at her, eyes slightly out-of-focus in that aroused, drunk kind of way. He looked off balance, and she liked that he did. She liked that she put him there. Reaching into his shorts, she pulled out his cock. “I want *this*. ”

Blowjobs were not part of their regular routine. She used them to get him hard when he wasn't, before mounting him. They tired her jaw out, she didn't love the gagging sensation that came with a cock in the back of her throat, and she hated the taste and slimy feel of come.

But she did like the effect they had on her man—not just the physical effect, not just watching Andy rock his head back and groan as she slid her mouth along his hardening length. She also liked that it was special, that when he looked down at her, he wasn't seeing the woman who slept peacefully, night after night, beside him in bed.

This time, as she bobbed along his length, watching his reaction, she wasn't just prepping him for sex. “You like my bikini?” she asked, pressing his dick to his stomach as she ran her tongue down to his balls. “Is this what you had in mind?”

He stared down at her, first watching her lick his shaft, then down into the cleavage her bikini top made.

“It's really hot, honey.” He slid his fingers through her hair, and she went back to work on his shaft. Bracing herself, she let the soft head tickle

the back of her throat. She stifled her gag reflex, and when she glanced up at him and saw the lust swimming in his slack face, she almost laughed.

“Oh, Rose,” he groaned.

She lapped along the underside of his shaft as she slowly pulled back, until she held just the head in her mouth. She teased the crown, watching his eyes flutter shut. He was close. She would finish him.

Only as she bobbed back down, shutting her own eyes, a new man entered her imagination—the man from the pool with his soft pelt of manly chest hair over his broad chest, with his crystal blue eyes, with his quiet smile.

She fought back the guilty image. She pushed it down, the way she had when she’d gone shopping for her bikini. The way she’d judged each under the criteria not only of whether her husband would approve, but whether the bus stop stranger would, too. Would he watch her at the pool? Would he look at the jewel that adorned her belly button and see more than a mom with two crazy boys?

“Rose.” Andy’s voice was tight with warning. He tapped her shoulder in warning.

Here’s where she would normally pull away. Let him come on his chest, if he was lying down, or in a tissue, if she had one. But she didn’t. She wouldn’t.

She still remembered the first blowjob she’d given him, tucked beneath the desk in his office. It was so naughty then, so out of character.

She’d swallowed.

She would swallow now.

She flicked her tongue along the crown of his cock, and Andy jerked his hips forward, a moan ripped from his chest. Caught off guard, his shaft entered her throat, his balls striking her chin, just as he started to come.

Rose choked, pulling back instinctively. She felt a rope of come splash across the bridge of her nose, warm and fluid.

She shrieked, uncertain of what to do as another blast landed on her neck. This had never happened to her before. She’d never had someone come *on* her before. A facial, she thought it was called. She didn’t do things like that. It always seemed so gross. Turned out, it was pretty gross!

In hindsight, she could have handled all of this a lot cooler. She could have made a thing about it, played it up like a pornstar. After all, this was the kind of excitement she was trying to bring back.

Instead, her shriek turned into a laugh as she shielded herself with her hand, like they were splashing each other with water in a pool.

“Oh, my God!” she laughed.

It killed the mood. The bikini, the belly ring, the blowjob, all of it swept away by that hysterical laugh.

Andy’s face tightened. He put on a smile, tight and forced. As she began to sober up, he pointed to her breast, where some of his come had splattered on the bikini top. “Guess you can’t return it, so that’s good.”

His smile was a blessing. All was good between them.

“I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have laughed.”

He chuckled, ducking into the bathroom. For a second, she thought he was getting her a towel. Then the shower cut on. His head popped out.

“Come on. You can make it up to me by showing what you look like wet in that bikini.”

Rose giggled, pushing herself to her feet. A shower was just the thing she needed, anyway, to wash away the already cooling come.

Andy was already stripping down as she entered. She paused inside the door frame to regard her husband. It was so easy to see the father of her boys, the guy who told corny jokes and still actually cared enough about baseball to be engaged for all nine innings. To see the man who left the lights on throughout the house and would tease her habit of leaving coffee mugs everywhere.

She loved that man, but right now she wanted to see past him. She wanted to see the guy she’d crushed on. The guy that made her want to be naughtier than she was comfortable with.

He was certainly looking at her like she was a minx. It gave her the confidence to *saunter* by him, swinging her hips as his eyes crawled all over her deliciously, and walk right into the steaming shower. She stepped beneath the spray, letting it wash the spunk from her face and neck.

She felt him join her in the warm space, his hands walking up her ribcage. She pushed her wet hair out of her face and blinked away the water.

“So how does it look? Still approve?”

He stepped back, glancing along her body. “Even better wet.”

“Oh, I’m definitely wet,” she said. Then giggled and blushed at saying it, hiding once again behind her hair. “I didn’t just say that.”

“You did,” Andy said. There was a huskiness to his voice that caught her attention. “God, you’re sexy, honey.”

He kissed her. Then kissed her neck. Then kissed along her chest, where he pulled the cup of her bra down so he could kiss her nipples. She cooed under the sensation, running her fingers through his damp hair. When he sank lower, to his creaky knees, she swooned back against the wall, where the tiles were cool to the touch.

“I think that it’s my turn to repay the favor,” he said, looking up at her. He reached up, slowly pulling the bikini bottoms down. “But first...”

He held up a razor and her bottle of shaving gel, and at first she didn’t understand. Then he glanced at her landing strip and she went bright red.

“On a mission to fulfill all of your fantasies?” she said through her smile.

“Something’s got you feeling adventurous. Figure I’d give it a shot.” It was a question, even if it wasn’t said as one.

Something’s got you feeling adventurous. She pushed her guilt away with a nod.

Andy grinned and filled his palm with foam.

“OH, MY...” Her moan caught, built, then came rushing out. “Uhhh-oh, Andy!”

Rose grabbed the top of the bed’s headboard, gripping the reclaimed wood so hard she should have worried about splinters. Instead, she just focused on the sensation of Andy’s cock sliding in and out of her, and how good the press of his thumb felt on her clit.

“That’s so hot,” Andy whispered.

She looked down at him, but she knew what he was focused on. His thumb pressed higher, sweeping across the spot where he’d shaved off her landing strip. It did look hot, and it felt so—

“Ha, so sensitive!” she gasped. She drove down into him, wanting to feel him deeper, wishing he’d rub her clit harder. “Harder,” she groaned.

He grabbed her ass with his free hand, squeezing. Yes, like that. She’d never wanted it so rough before, but as she bounced over Andy, she felt the

need grow. *Squeeze me harder* , she thought, although couldn't quite say. *Fuck me!*

He didn't read her mind. He didn't suddenly become a man that he wasn't. But it was enough. It was still good. Still raw and slippery and passionate. He continued to work her clit, to remind her of what he'd done in the shower, to remind her of how naughty she could be. It all blurred together. It all became a streak of hot, sticky excitement behind her hard shut eyes.

She leaned into him, wanting to feel more of his skin on hers. Her breath caught when his mouth closed around her nipple. His tongue swirled and flicked. His teeth grazed. She lost it, imploding into herself as she shoved more of her tit between his lips.

"Come, baby. I need to feel your—*come!*"

She yelped at the intensity of Andy's own climax. Just as she hit her peak, he was there with her, liquid fire filling her, pushing her higher and higher. She squeezed the headboard until the wood creaked. She felt like she could rip chunks out of it. Like she could rip the whole damn thing off the bed and throw it against the wall. Thrashing, thrusting, moaning, she came harder than she'd come in so long.

When it was over and her breath came shallow and their sweat began cooling on their naked bodies, that wild woman who'd been stirred awake began to grow sleepy again. And so did Rose.

She rolled off of her husband. The glass of white wine that she'd been drinking when Andy came home was still on her nightstand, half of it gone. It was warm, but she finished it off anyway, then turned over and kissed her husband sloppily.

"So how's Louis doing?" She watched as Andy's nipple hardened as she tickled it with her fingernails. She suddenly felt very exhausted. Vaguely, she remembered that he was excited to tell her something when he walked in. "You learn anything?"

"Just..." If she'd been more awake, she would have picked up on his hesitation. As it was, she was already halfway in her dreams. She didn't even remember closing her eyes—just that it felt so good to have them closed. "Just that he's not cheating on Jordan."

"Mmm, that's good."

She felt him stroking her hair. "You're so sexy, Rose."

“You said that already,” she said, smiling. She couldn’t quite open her eyes. “A few times.”

“I mean it. I’m sorry if I sometimes take you for granted.”

She wondered if this was coming from whatever conversation he’d gotten up to with Louis, or from her little surprises. “I’ll just have to keep you on your toes then,” she murmured.

And if she’d been more awake, she definitely would have registered his quick intake of breath, or how his heart started to race.

“Going to be hard, though,” she added. “Now that I’ve fulfilled almost all of your fantasies.”

He pulled the covers over them, and she turned onto her side, away from him. He felt good, spooned up behind her, his skin warm. He pulled her hair away, kissing the back of her neck, then up just beneath her ear.

“Well, maybe you’ll have to start sleeping with other men,” he whispered. Or she thought he whispered. It sent a jolt through her, but not enough to wake her. She laughed drowsily. It was a joke.

“You’ve been hanging around Louis too much.”

Whatever he may have said next was lost to her. She was asleep.

ANDY

He didn't know why he didn't tell her about his revelation—that Jordan was the one who'd had the affair, not Louis. He told himself that it was because she was so sleepy, that it wasn't a good time to have such a heavy conversation.

But was that really it? As he watched her sleep, her breathing evening out, growing shallow, a strange thought crept over him.

Well, maybe you'll have to start sleeping with other men. Why had he said that? Why did the question send his blood pressure spiking?

He crept out of bed, careful not to wake his wife, to go into the bathroom and empty his bladder and brush his teeth. He poured himself a glass of water and drank it down, knowing that it wasn't enough to hold his hangover at bay, but he wasn't willing to drink more for fear of being up every half hour, pissing it out.

He hung up the bikini that they'd left on the shower floor. She'd actually bought a bikini, and now that he'd seen her wearing it, he wondered why she'd been resistant for so long. She not only looked fantastic, but also she wore it well. The bikini itself wasn't too skimpy. There was nothing trashy about it, and adult women wore them all the time. If anything, the way this one wrapped around her gave off a cool vibe.

Still, the thought of seeing her walk across the deck of the neighborhood pool wearing it and all the eyes that would inevitably turn her direction did something to him. Something that he couldn't fully pin on jealousy.

"Louis, you ass," he thought to himself as he brushed his teeth. This was the beer and his neighbor's crazy fantasy infecting him. What he needed

was sleep.

Only when he returned to bed, rolling onto his side, he just stared at Rose. She'd kicked most of the sheet away, and it now snaked between her legs and left her backside bare. Her profile was sinuous, a rolling curve of pale, unblemished flesh, from her shoulder, down through her waist and then back up at her hips. Her ass, naked and round and plush, was perfection—although he knew she complained about it being bigger now, after the kids. For Andy, he wanted to sink his teeth into it, just to hear her yelp.

Instead, he crawled in, grabbed the sheets on his side, and somehow managed to fall asleep, trying to fight back the idea of Rose and other men, and the attention she would get when they went to the pool next.

Unfortunately, it rained the rest of that weekend. They stayed cooped up indoors until all four of them were ready to scream, then went out to an indoor trampoline park that cost a fortune. It was a fun time, a good time. He enjoyed watching Rose jump around in a pair of jogging shorts and a racerbacked sports top. It was all good, wholesome, family fun, and by the end of the weekend, he'd almost forgotten about Louis and the secret he now knew.

ROSE

Monday morning, Rose got up early and took a nice, cleansing, hot shower. It was a new week. A fresh start. She'd had a great weekend and loved her time with the family, but she also loved her job. Unlike everyone else she seemed to know, she welcomed Mondays.

In the shower, she soaped and shampooed. She shaved her legs and armpits, and then, without overthinking it, shaved her pussy again, completely bare. It felt wicked, doing that, a way to act naughty that only she knew about.

Well, her and Andy, of course, and she knew he was always looking. Like when she came out of the shower and unwrapped the towel from her body, she knew he was stealing a look at her. Did he notice that she'd touched herself up? She hoped so.

With his sleepy eyes on her, she decided to wear a thong that day. She knew how much he liked the way they looked on her, and deep down, she knew it too. Why not have another little secret today?

After that, she went downstairs, brewed a pot of coffee and fixed lunches for the whole family. Charlie and Lucas emerged, sleepy-eyed but well-rested, foraging for their cereal breakfasts. Andy came down later, as he always did, dragging himself like he was hungover.

"Good morning, Andy," she said brightly. On mornings like this, she couldn't help but overplay how much more of a morning person she was than him. "I thought I saw you awake an hour ago."

He mumbled something about getting back to sleep as she set a mug of coffee before him. "Lunches are in their lunchboxes. Remember that this

week, the kids are in Adventure Camp, so they're going to need their sneakers."

"We remember, Mom," Charlie said, where he sat across from the table.

"Are you wearing perfume?" Andy asked, and she wondered if he even heard her. It was fine. Charlie would remember for them.

"I am, actually," she said. She didn't always, but it wasn't that unusual. Andy usually didn't notice, though, and while it pleased her that he did this morning, it also made her feel a twinge of guilt. Because she'd decided to put it on this morning for a very specific reason.

"It's nice," he said. Then promptly changed the subject. "I'm going to be home a little late. Heavy meeting day."

She hugged him from behind, then kissed his cheek. "Sorry to hear that. We may hit the pool this afternoon. Maybe if you get home in time, you can see my new digs."

That got his attention. She giggled, then was out the door.

To the bus stop, where she looked for her stranger—the man for whom she refused to acknowledge putting perfume on. When he wasn't there, she told herself that that wasn't disappointment she felt, and went about her day.

And when he *was* standing at the bus stop in the afternoon, waiting for the 2A to take them from the train station to their townhome community, she told herself that wasn't excitement she felt. When it really, really was.

Their eyes met and she felt giddy, all the way down to the base of her stomach. She was acutely aware that beneath her dark, pencil skirt, she wore a lacy pair of panties designed to minimize her panty lines. And beneath that, her pussy was completely bare.

She blushed as he smiled at her, like he knew her secret. Which was impossible and paranoid and completely irrational. She got into her Kindle, pretending to read as they waited for the bus and more people joined them at the stop.

When the bus arrived, she lingered, letting the crowd get on first. When she stepped on at last, the only seat available was beside...him. Even still, she half considered standing toward the back until she realized how weird that would be, and how silly she was behaving.

"Mind if I sit here?" she asked. Those were the first words she'd ever spoken to this guy, and she was happy that her voice didn't crack.

He had his phone out and a pair of headphones on. She hadn't noticed, and stumbled to apologize when he pulled them off and smiled up at her.

“Please,” he said, making room for her, even though there was already plenty of it. She stiffly took a seat, like the man next to her was an excitable dog, and the bus rumbled out of the station.

She didn’t know what to do. Should she say something to him? Should she get her book out and read, like she would any other person on the bus? And why did her indecision feel like a bout of schoolgirl nervousness?

The guy helped her out. “I’m Tyler,” he said. “I’m sorry, I see you around all the time.”

“Hey.” She heard the breathiness in her own voice, and smiled to cover it up. “I’m Rose.” Then she asked the more obvious: “You live in Chesterbrook?”

“Yeah. On Grove, near the pool.”

“It’s a great community.”

“Very family friendly,” he agreed.

She hated how banal this conversation was—their first ever. It wasn’t the fairytale moment she hadn’t realized she’d been imagining until it was here.

“My kids love it. So many kids. My oldest, Charlie...his best friend lives one street over.” *Stop it, Rose. He’s already bored of you!*

“I would have loved to grow up like that. In New York, we barely even recognize our neighbors, and they all lived in the same building as ours.”

Good. Better. This was better. “You grew up in New York City?”

“Brooklyn, yeah. And you?”

“Nothing quite as interesting. I grew up about fifteen minutes away. In the ‘burbs.” *Why did you say ‘burbs?!’* “My parents still live there.”

“That’s probably convenient, for the kids.”

“Yeah.” She neglected to add the thing she normally did, when talking about grandparents—that Andy’s parents lived even closer. For some reason, she didn’t want to bring her husband up with Tyler, like he wouldn’t know. “It’s nice.”

This close, he looked younger than she’d initially thought—maybe late twenties or so. He had the beginnings of a beard on his chin and upper lip, but where Andy would sport some grays throughout, Tyler’s whiskers were dark. He looked good like that.

They talked about growing up, and the neighborhood, and how hot this summer was. They talked about the erratic schedule of the bus and how it

rained all weekend and the upcoming block party at the Chesterbrook Commons in the center of their community.

All standard small talk, all delightful and innocent and fun. Yet through it all, Rose kept thinking about the naughty woman hiding beneath her professional exterior, and if Tyler had any idea. And even deeper than that, so dark and quieted away that she tried to not even acknowledge it—how exciting it would be if Tyler found out.

Well, maybe you'll have to start sleeping with other men.

Andy's words, meant as a joke. Yet she kept returning to it, and wondering what it would be like if it wasn't. She made a mental note to have that drink with Jordan, then promptly forgot to as she listened to Tyler talk and not stare too deeply into his beautiful blue eyes.

They came to their stop too soon. For the first time since she'd gone back to work, she wished that she lived farther away so this ride could have lasted even five more minutes.

"It was nice finally meeting you," Rose said as they stopped before her townhome. "This is me."

"I like what you did with your front yard," he said.

Rose laughed. Her front yard, like all the others in the neighborhood, was maintained by the same landscaping company.

"Thanks." She pushed her hair out of her face. "I put a lot of work into it."

"Very healthy grass."

Rose laughed out loud. "Anyone tell you that you're a real ladies' man?"

When she realized what she'd said, though, her face lit up like a flame.

Mercifully, Tyler didn't let her suffer. "Nah, I've just got a good eye when it comes to lawn care. I think it's one of those innately male things, like an attraction to power tools or building fires in fireplaces."

"Ooh, then these townhomes and their gas fireplaces must be torture."

He grinned. "Yeah. Such a tease."

The moment lingered—in a good way, yet in a really guilty way. For a moment, Rose actually considered inviting him in for coffee, of all things. The kids were at summer camp for another hour, and Andy was at work. But that was wrong on so many levels. Even if it was purely an innocent coffee.

Which of course it was.

“Anyway, I better get going,” Tyler said at last. “It was nice to put a name to a face, Rose. See you around?”

She pointed towards the bus stop with her index finger, thumb up. Like she was shooting it. Then immediately felt ridiculous doing it and blushed at that, too, and laughed nervously. “For sure.”

She almost said something about going to the pool that afternoon. Somehow she was able to reign that impulse in.

She did watch him go, though. Watched his cute little butt in his snug, blue slacks, and the way his blue shirt accentuated the muscles she knew he had beneath.

“Hey, Rose.” A familiar voice snapped her out of her daydream. When she traced its source, she saw Louis Crowley waving at her from his parked Outback.

“Oh, hey, Louis.”

She quickly catalogued how guilty she looked, and wondered how much he saw. Did he see her flirting with Tyler just now? Or had he just driven up? And why didn’t she know the answer to that?!

But now wasn’t the time to panic—not that she had reason to. Nothing she’d done was bad. It was all innocent and meant nothing and—

“You on kid duty today?” she asked just to get out of her own head.

“Yeah. Jordan needs to... she’s working late tonight. Big project.”

It occurred to Rose that she didn’t actually know what Jordan did for a living. Something to do with reports and numbers, although she wasn’t an accountant.

“Yeah, Andy’s in a similar situation.”

This was, she realized, the first time she’d spoken to Louis since the separation, and it felt really awkward.

“Well, I better get in there. Snacks and stuff.” The way he laughed made it clear the awkwardness was mutual.

“Good luck.”

Rose hurried into her house, but the pall of the encounter followed her in, wiping away any giddy notions of a neighborhood crush. These things had consequences, and no one exemplified that more than the broken man out there.

“You need to get your shit together,” she said to herself.

Later that day, when she took the kids to the pool, she wore her one-piece, and mercifully, Tyler wasn’t there.

ANDY

Work crawled along, and while there were moments when he could actually focus on what he was doing, mostly he was thinking about Rose. Rose and her bikini. Rose and belly button piercing. Rose and her newfound sense of adventure.

He'd been half-asleep when she got up and went into the shower, but he swore she'd taken a longer one than normal. Like she'd added a new step to her routine. Like shaving her pussy. When she came out, he was wide awake, but pretended not to be. He had to check, and sure enough, it appeared that she wasn't letting her landing strip grow back.

When she slipped on her thong, it was like she was trying to show off. *Look at what I'm wearing*, she seemed to tease. He wanted to rise from the bed and drag her back to it. Instead, he pretended to fall back asleep. And then, he *had* fallen back asleep.

At work, though, he could navel gaze. He could wonder where this was coming from. He could wonder why he was wondering at all. It probably didn't mean anything. It was probably just Rose trying to add some excitement into their marriage. That made the most sense.

But then there was Louis and Jordan and how Rose's adventurous spirit seemed to coincide with the news of their separation. Or how Louis's fantasy wasn't actually a fantasy at all, but a reality. Did Rose know the truth, too?

Really, though, it was the bikini that occupied most of his wandering thoughts, and how soon she'd wear it out for all to see. A month ago, before he knew about Louis's thing, the image of his athletic wife in a bikini would

have been exciting enough. But now, his world view has expanded. Other men's eyes on her had become part of the butterfly flutter in his gut, and the fact that he was stuck in meetings during the bikini's inaugural outing was blissful torture.

Which was weird, because it shouldn't have been blissful at all!

[Andy]: How'd it go?

He texted her around seven, when he was getting set to leave and he knew they were most likely home from the pool.

[Rose]: ?

[Andy]: The bikini

[Rose]: Oh. Haha. Didn't wear it after all.

Andy felt both relieved and disappointed.

[Andy]: Chickened out?

[Rose]: Waiting on you, dear husband.

He read sarcasm that probably wasn't there. That she didn't wear it was more in line with the woman he knew. This was still a big step, though. He couldn't complain.

At home, things were normal. The kids had already eaten dinner and were watching TV. Rose was puttering around straightening things up—although she did look good in that breezy, straight-from-the-pool sort of way. Her russet hair has dried in pieces, and the sun was already turning her once pale skin a nice shade of gold.

He ate dinner mostly by himself, half-reading news on his phone and half talking with Rose as she paid the bills across from him.

"You know what's unfair?" she said, looking up from her laptop. It's bluish screen reflected off of her glasses. "Credit card rewards."

“Oh?” Andy said absently.

“Yeah. If you have means, like we do, to pay off your credit card every month, then the rewards are just gravy. But if you can’t, and carry a balance, then the interest will far outweigh them.” She clicked a few times, hard, like she was registering her disgust at the injustice with the credit card’s website.

Rose got like this sometimes, and it’s one of many things that he loved about her. But after so many years of marriage, he was mostly focused on the latest news article to add much beyond a knee-jerk response. “Yeah, it’s just built into our whole social inequality.”

If she was upset that he wasn’t giving her his full attention, she didn’t show it. She just went back to the bills.

And that was all...normal. Nothing about the night stood out of the ordinary, other than that he’d started to frame things like that—“normal” and “not normal”—and some things from the last few days were “not normal.”

He put his dishes in the dishwasher and cleaned the last pots and plates on the counter as he tried to figure out whether he should broach all of this with Rose, and if he did, how he would do it, when a text came in. From their neighbor.

[Louis]: Hey, man. Want to come over for a beer? I’m on babysitting duty and the baby is sleeping.

Like they were friends.

“Rose, Louis is apparently home with the kid. Mind if I go over for a beer?”

He wasn’t sure, but he thought there was a moment’s hesitation before she nodded. “Sure, go for it.”

“What?”

“Nothing. Just...I think it’s good. The guy needs a friend.”

Andy still thought there was more to her pause, but didn’t press. Instead, he texted back that he was headed over.

“SO WHERE’S JORDAN?” It took Andy most of a beer to ask the question, despite it being the preeminent question on his mind.

“She says she’s at work.”

It was because of that answer, full of carefully considered suggestion, that it took him so long to ask it. Andy said, “And you don’t believe her?”

They were sitting at the table in their combined dining-living room, the same spot where Rose was probably still sorting their bills back home. It felt darker in here, though. The lights were all off, but it was more than just that.

“I do, but I don’t.” Louis chuckled to himself and finished off his beer. “Another?” he asked, getting up and puttering into the kitchen.

“Um, no, I’m good.”

Louis came back with two beers anyway, opened them both, and set one in front of Andy.

“I feel all...squirmy, man.” Louis dropped himself into his chair across from Andy, then almost immediately hopped back up. “It’s after nine on a Monday. She never works this late.”

It did seem unusual, but Andy also didn’t know what was normal for this man. He decided to keep quiet. What Louis needed was someone who listened.

“Have you noticed her going out at night? Getting babysitters?”

“I don’t—”

“Never mind. Of course you wouldn’t know. She probably isn’t, I’m just being paranoid. See, that’s all part of it. This fantasy, man, it’s all consuming. I’m renting a utility over in Cedars, and as I lie in bed, it’s all I can think about. Does she have a babysitter? Is she sneaking some guy over, you know?”

“I’m pretty sure she’s not doing that—”

“I know, I know. She wouldn’t do that. Not with Lillian around, but man...” He ran his hand vigorously through his hair. “Hey, I saw Rose talking to some young guy today. Like flirting with him. You know anything about that?”

Andy felt whiplash at the change in subject. “What?”

“Yeah, I didn’t recognize him, but they were walking back from the bus. Guy looks kind of like a soap star, if that makes sense. Brawny, a little scruffy, kind of a hipster-meets-the-office look. Ah, whatever. It’s nothing.”

Andy was stunned. Louis kept on talking.

“See, this is what I’m talking about. I’m seeing it everywhere, not just with Jordan, but with everyone.”

“What did this guy look like?” Andy ran through a catalog of all the guys they knew in the neighborhood, and none of them fit the ‘soap star’ description.

“I don’t know. I only saw him for a second, as I was getting out of the car. He was pretty tall. Light brown hair. I don’t know. Good looking guy.”

“And they were talking?” He couldn’t quite say flirting. “Like they knew each other?”

Louis went quiet, suddenly realizing that he’d kicked a beehive. “I don’t know. Maybe I just saw what I wanted to see.”

“Which was?”

Louis laughed nervously, took a swig of his beer, then shrugged, as if to say, *Fuck it*. “That there was an unspoken attraction between them. Like I was seeing the beginning of something. I mean, Rose is...” He hesitated, glancing at Andy.

“Go on.”

“Rose is attractive, okay? And she’s a woman, too, and I know that it’s hard to see that sometimes when you’ve been together forever and have kids that take up most of the focus, but man, your wife is hot. And guys notice that sort of thing.”

“Like this guy.”

Louis nodded, then held out his hand, as if conceding something. “But look, I’m sure it’s nothing. She probably gets that kind of attention all the time and—”

“She does?” The hackles on the back of his neck rose. His stomach began to flutter. His chest started to tighten. “You’ve seen that?”

“No, I haven’t.” Louis pulled up his seat and leaned into his elbows. “I’m sorry. Ignore me. I’m an idiot.”

Heat felt trapped beneath his hairline. He opened his mouth, wondering what more he could say, when the front door opened. Jordan was home. Louis glanced at his watch, then mouthed, “Almost ten,” to Andy before standing.

“How was work, honey?”

“Long.” She sounded tired. She shut the door quietly. “Kids go down okay?”

“Easily.”

Their townhomes were split level, so she didn't see Andy until she ascended the stairs into the living room. "Oh, Andy. I didn't realize you were here."

"Hey, Jordan. Just keeping your hus—" He caught himself. This was awkward. "Louis company."

She heard the flinch, but didn't acknowledge it any further. "Thanks."

Jordan was dressed for work, rather than for a date. She looked good, though, her black slacks and tan, knit-top snug enough to put her hourglass figure on display. Add to that a pair of tall, nude pumps and Louis's dirty mind started to infect Andy's.

"Louis said something about a big project starting up?" Andy asked the question, but really, he wanted to get the hell out of there. As she glanced at her husband, he could feel the tension pump into the room.

"Did he?"

Andy swallowed. He looked nervously at Louis, who started to approach his wife like he was going to take her into his arms, or kiss her, or share a moment of affection. Like ordinary, married people do. Only these two weren't ordinary—and only marginally married. She quickly held up a hand to stop him, shaking her head quickly, glancing nervously at Andy.

That stopped Louis. It also was a clear signal to Andy that it was time to go. "Well, I better head home. Thanks for the beers, Louis."

"Thanks for keeping me company, man." Andy half-wondered whether Louis was going to follow him out, but it seemed like those two had some unfinished business. As Andy passed by, he realized that at least some of the tension between them was sexual. Interesting.

"Nice to see you, Andy. Tell Rose hi for me."

"Will do."

At home, things were dark. Rose had left a single lamp on in the living room. He switched it off, but didn't go upstairs immediately. Instead, he wandered into the kitchen at the front of the house that overlooked the parking spots.

He felt the two beers in him, lubricating his thoughts. Rose was flirting with some guy? She hadn't mentioned anyone, but had she acted oddly? He couldn't remember. But did this guy have something to do with the bikini? The belly ring? If he lived in the neighborhood, did he go to their pool?

Andy poured himself a glass of water and floated over to the large, bay window. Louis's Subaru was still parked. He was still over there.

“It’s fine,” he said to himself. “Things are fine.”

He wasn’t talking about Jordan and Louis, though. Rose wasn’t doing anything she shouldn’t be. This was Louis, getting into his head.

And , a quiet little voice added, if she’s dressing a little more provocatively because she’s getting some attention from this soap star guy, no real harm there.

It was a woozy thought, one he didn’t think a sober mind could have crafted.

He stood there still, waiting to see when Louis would come out as all those confusing thoughts ricocheted through his head. The right thing to do here would be to talk to her, to ask her about this guy. To ask her about everything. But did he really want that? Did he want to upset the cart, if this was really nothing?

After ten minutes of getting nowhere, he muttered, “Go to bed.”

Louis still hadn’t left, and upstairs, Rose was asleep. So he’d have to push the big talk off another day.

In the morning, he decided to push it off indefinitely.

ROSE

T Tyler wasn't at the bus stop or the pool for the rest of that week. Not that Rose was really hoping to see him or anything. Or that she chose her clothes in the morning with Tyler in mind. If he did slip into her thoughts, it was no big deal. It was harmless. No different than seeing a cute guy at the gym.

Or crushing on a teacher.

Which she'd done.

And look where that ended up.

By Friday, though, she'd moved past it. Andy was paying more and more attention to her than ever, and she was enjoying the thrill of teasing him as she got dressed, or as they made love.

Jordan had invited her to go out for drinks in the city, and when she asked Andy if it was okay, he seemed conspicuously fine with it. Like extra accommodating. Like suspiciously so.

"What's up with you?"

"Nothing!" he said, too quickly. "I just think it's great. You never go out is all. Have fun."

The reason she never went out quickly became apparent as she stepped through the door of Society Lounge. It was loud and overwhelming and crude. A group of well-dressed young guys leaving paused and gave her a once-over. She felt like meat, and she hated that feeling.

"I don't know about this," she said to Jordan.

In college, she didn't do the fraternity scene. She wasn't part of a sorority. House parties and hanging out with friends were more her speed.

Not that she didn't get the appeal. Many people probably found it exciting to walk into a room full of strangers—like the night was a new adventure waiting to begin. Rose just wasn't one of those people. Jordan, however, was.

"Can't you feel that energy? This is so much better than dealing with a kid who doesn't stay in bed!"

"Well, I'll give you that much."

This certainly was different. Rose never came into the city anymore unless she was bringing her boys to a museum. Tonight, she didn't have them in tow. She didn't have to constantly worry about them getting lost in the crowd. She could be out as someone other than a mother.

The Society Lounge was pretty cool, too. With its windows thrown open and the exposed brick, steel, and distressed wood motifs, it felt contemporary and hip—and Rose felt hip herself walking in. The bar itself was long, a shiny block of wood that stretched the length of the lounge. Behind it, liquor bottles glowed with hidden light and bartenders dressed in crisp white shirts mixed complicated, artisanal cocktails from memory.

She was glad that Jordan had talked her into wearing heels, although she still felt frumpy in just jeans and her loose blouse. "I feel underdressed here."

"Oh, you're fine."

"Says you," Rose replied, giving Jordan a once over. In her tight white pants, black, cold-shoulder top, and cork heels, she blended right in. "I'm dressed for book club."

Jordan had a delightful laugh, covering her mouth without reducing any of the volume. "I don't see it. Get out of your head, Rose."

On their way to a table, they passed a couple of women in tiny dresses that did not help her state of mind. Rose looked pointedly at them, then back at Jordan, who rolled her eyes and nudged her with her hip. "Oh, don't mind those bitches. They're trying too hard."

"Is that what it's called? I can honestly say that I've never worn a dress like that."

"You should, sweetheart. With your body, you definitely should. I'm sure Andy would love it."

"That one would stay in the bedroom."

"Everyone needs a few of those dresses."

Thinking of Andy and the bikini, she added, "He'd probably want me to wear it out. To show me off like I'm a shiny new car."

"Men suck, don't they? I swear sometimes I want to swear the whole gender off."

A server came along as they settled into an open table. She wore a pale blue skort that showed almost all of her legs, and a gauzy white top. "Hi, I'm Britney. What'll you two have?"

"Two margaritas please," Jordan said, smiling up at the tall brunette.

Britney returned the smile. "I'll be right back with those, ladies."

"Thank you so much," Jordan said. As Britney left, Jordan lingered on the woman's butt, nearly exposed in the tiny shorts. She leaned in and whispered, "Maybe I'll try girls for a bit."

Rose couldn't tell if she was serious, but she also didn't want to come off as closed minded. "Umm, sure." And then, a second later, "You've done that?"

Jordan laughed. "Not since college. You?"

"Never." Rose laughed nervously. "Much to Andy's chagrin."

"See, men are all pigs."

Their drinks arrived. They settled in. Rose kicked off the inevitable conversation. "So how are things with you and Louis?"

With the question, Jordan grew a little more serious, a little more sober. "We're in kind of a holding pattern right now. He's a great father to the kids, you know? He provides."

There was a 'but' there. Rose held her tongue, letting Jordan get there on her own.

"But this obsession..." Jordan sighed. "For the past... I don't know, year or so, I knew something was going on with him. He started to retreat. I mean, he's always been reserved, but he began to really recede. When I finally got him to tell me what was wrong, I was floored."

"That's the thing with you and... um, other guys?" Heat touched Rose's face. She knew exactly what they were talking about. It had been on her mind since their first conversation, but she was ashamed enough to feign a little ignorance.

"Yeah, that." Jordan tucked a golden strand of hair behind her ear. Light caught in her diamond ring. "I've heard of that kind of thing before, just never figured my husband would be... you know..."

"Not really." Rose giggled nervously.

“Right now, he’s back in our home, and I’m willing to bet that he’s imagining the two of us getting hit on. Or maybe even going back to their place.”

Rose went full-on blush. “No,” she gasped. She’d never do that, yet the idea of it sent her squirming.

Jordan chuckled at her reaction. “Oh yes, it’s true. You’re now part of this by association, I’m afraid.”

She has no idea, Rose thought. Then wished she hadn’t, because she suddenly felt very guilty. Jordan saw it, too. “What?” she asked.

“Um, nothing.”

The blonde tilted her head, narrowing her eyes as she studied her friend. “You’ve got a secret.”

Nervously, Rose reached for her drink, only to find that it was empty. That’s when she realized how much tequila was suddenly rushing to her head, which is why she probably said the next thing. “Um... just...” Jordan wasn’t letting her off the hook, so she blurted, “Some women would love to be in your situation, you know.”

That caught both of them by surprise. Jordan’s eyes went wide, and Rose felt heat shoot through her.

“I mean, not me, but some women,” she added too late.

Jordan looked at her slyly, like she was seeing something in Rose that Rose wasn’t sure she wanted to be seen. “Secret, secret.”

“No, it’s not... there’s nothing.”

Jordan tipped an index finger at Rose, as if flicking a wand. “That means there’s *definitely* something.”

Tyler came to mind, then she quickly put him *out* of her mind. Jordan saw the struggle, was about to press when her attention shifted to something just behind Rose.

Britney had returned with a couple fresh margaritas. Jordan said, “Not that I’m complaining, but we didn’t order these.”

Britney leaned close, like they were three girlfriends, and whispered, “Compliments of those guys over there.”

Rose looked in the direction their server pointed, where a couple of decent looking guys smiled at her and nodded.

“Oh, my God,” she blurted.

Jordan kept her composure, but was also amused. “Tell them thanks, and that we’ll enjoy them by ourselves.”

Britney seemed to approve of this line. Smiling, she said, "With pleasure."

"I think she takes delight in shutting guys down," Jordan noted, her eyes once again lingering on Britney's ass.

"Did that really happen?"

"It's a bar, and we're two attractive women out alone on a Friday. Of course it happens."

"Never to me."

"Oh come on, Rose. Don't be modest."

"I'm serious! This isn't exactly my scene."

"Bars?"

"Being single at a bar."

"Ha! Serial monogamist?"

"No, not really. Just...more of a wallflower back in school," Rose said.

"I find that so hard to believe!"

"It's true. I was a nerd. I didn't have a ton of friends, and only a handful of boyfriends before I met Andy."

"How did you guys meet?"

This part always made her blush. Over the years, they'd developed a story to explain their beginning that didn't involve her sleeping with her college T.A. They met on campus, in the library. He was a grad student, she was an undergrad. He sheepishly asked her out after nearly a year of seeing each other and not actually talking.

It was a lot like what was currently going on with Tyler, she realized. It was also not exactly true.

"He was my T.A.," Rose confessed, much to her surprise. "And I thought he was so cute."

"Rose!" Jordan said. She actually sounded scandalized.

"I know. It was crazy." She told Jordan everything. She told her about 'office hours.' About how they snuck around. About how they'd have to play it cool during class, or the rare times they'd see one another at school functions, only to later tear their clothes off and fuck like teenagers.

"I've never done anything like that in my life. It felt crazy," Rose concluded.

"But so exciting," Jordan suggested. She stirred her drink. "You're full of surprises."

"How about you? I'm sure you've got some wild stories in you."

Jordan chuckled. "I guess I do." She looked into her margarita, which had all but melted. Rose could feel her own, warm and fuzzy. At first, she figured Jordan would leave it at that. Instead, she looked up at Rose with her crisp, blue eyes and took a breath. It was odd, seeing this vivacious blonde look so bashful, to see her eyes waver and shift away.

"What?" Rose asked, bracing instinctively.

Jordan glanced back at her, searched Rose's face, then smirked at her own reticence. "I'm sleeping with another man."

Rose's jaw dropped. *Sleeping*. Present progressive tense. An action that is happening right now. That is *still* happening.

"But I thought—"

Jordan covered her face with her hands. Rose could imagine her own face—stunned, wide-eyed, a bit horrified. "I know, I know," Jordan murmured between her fingers.

"Your husband—"

"I know!"

"I...I'm going to...um...I need more," Rose stammered. "More context, I mean. You're *sleeping* with another man?"

"Oh, the irony, right?"

Rose stared across the table at her neighbor, who she realized she knew even less about than she'd originally thought.

"Okay," Jordan began. "This was... maybe a month ago, just before summer break started. We'd gotten into a fight, Lou and I. He was traveling, I was going to this art show thing at the preschool, and he was going on about how I was free to hook up with one of the dads. Like I'd ever fucking do that. I was so pissed off at him, thinking that I'd show him, just to teach him a lesson. I was already planning on telling him that I'd hooked up with someone that night. Making it up, I mean. Like as a test."

"So you *didn't* hook up with anyone?" Rose asked, knowing the answer.

"There's more."

"Okay."

Jordan took a steadying breath. "After the show, I went out with some of the other moms. We all had babysitters or husbands at home, so figured we'd take advantage. I had too much to drink and suddenly I realized that everyone else I knew had gone home and I was alone with...this guy."

She looked up at Rose with her rich, brown eyes that seemed to beg her not to judge.

“He was good looking. Made me laugh. I was still thinking of just hanging around long enough to make Lou jealous—even though I know it’s absurd, since he wasn’t there or anything. But as the night progressed, I forgot about him. Well, not exactly, but I talked myself into thinking that he’d be fine with this, so I was fine.” Jordan had been lost in memory. She paused, glancing at Rose as though to remind herself that this was a confession. “When he asked me if I wanted to get out of there, I didn’t even hesitate. I knew what this was, but I was so caught up in it. I hadn’t felt that way in ages. Like I was being swept away.”

It was uncomfortable how close the feelings that Jordan was describing came to her own thoughts around Tyler.

“Have you ever had a one-night stand?” Jordan asked.

Rose shook her head.

“They’re usually disappointing. The kind of thing you think is a good idea at the time, then regret the next day.”

“Let me guess. You didn’t regret this one?”

“I did, but for an entirely different set of reasons.” She shook her head, like she was chiding herself for being a silly girl. “I’m a relationship kind of girl. Sure, I’ve had my fun, but the most exciting for me has always been when I was in a relationship. When I can connect with another man, that’s when it’s really good.

“When I met Lou, he really swept me off my feet. I remember thinking for the first time in my life that here was a man I could spend the rest of my days with. I didn’t marry him because he tricked me or trapped me. Taking his damn ring wasn’t a sacrifice, and this ‘freedom’ that he is ‘granting’ me so generously...” She shook her head. “I don’t want that. I married him because he was the one, and honestly, this whole thing with him sharing me cheapens that.

“I need a man. Like when I told Lou, I wanted him to hate me. To tell me what a slut I was. To scream at me and kick me out of the house, you know? But he just...” She took a deep breath to center herself. “He just wanted to know if this other guy’s dick was bigger than his.” She laughed bitterly. “That’s when I told him that I needed space.”

“You kicked him out because you cheated on him.”

“I kicked him out because I needed him to care that I did.”

It was a tricky thing. “I mean, he does care—”

“No. He cares about his fantasy. Not about our relationship. I told you, I’m a relationship girl, and honestly, I think an ‘open relationship’ is an oxymoron.”

This was all much more complicated than Rose was prepared for, especially with two margaritas coursing through her. The two women sat there quietly, neither of them certain where to go next. Maybe it was that tequila in her, but Rose spoke first, and as soon as she did, she wished she could have it back. “So did he have a—?”

“Have a...?” Jordan asked, then got what Rose wanted to know. The tension broke. Her smile lit up her face, and brought a heated blush to Rose’s.

“I’m sorry, I think I’m drunk—”

Jordan spoke right over her, delighted. “Did he have a bigger dick than Lou? I think I like this drunk Rose.”

“Oh, God.”

Jordan started to laugh—not at her, but more at the situation. And the tension. She covered her mouth, but she was already hysterical. Rose joined in, caught up in it until she didn’t even know why she was laughing. It felt good. Cleansing. Cathartic.

When Jordan calmed down, she blew out a heavy sigh and sat back. “You ever been with a black guy?”

“He was—” She caught herself. “He was African American?”

Jordan laughed. “I’d never been with an...African American, either, until that night.”

It felt like Rose’s rib cage was growing smaller. “And?”

“Yes, he was *much* bigger. Actually, bigger than any man I’ve ever been with.”

Rose squeezed her thighs together.

“And the sex was...” Jordan shut her eyes. She had long lashes that fanned out in dark curls. “It was *so* good, Rose. I haven’t felt that good—that wanted—since the early days with Louis. Maybe not *ever* with Louis.”

Rose bit the corner of her lower lip as a throb of excitement welled up through her.

“You know what my favorite thing about a relationship is? The beginning. There’s nothing quite like it, when everything’s new. You’re still exploring each other, and you haven’t discovered the annoying stuff yet. Everything’s exciting—his smell, the way he gasps when I touch him a

certain way, the way he kisses. All those feelings, those long-buried desires, came back with Jayden.

“He lived just a few blocks from the bar. Even stumbling back with him, my arm linked in his, the smell of the warm, summer night all around us, was electric. Like old times. Anything was possible.”

Rose hung onto every word, feeling the same tingles. Reliving the same, familiar sensations.

“And when we were in his apartment, and he was kissing me, taking my clothes off, going down on me...” Jordan seemed to remember that Rose was there. She took a deep breath and finally glanced up at her friend. “You must think I’m an awful person.”

Rose shook her head. “No. Not at all. I actually get it.” She did. She still remembered those intense feelings when she’d first started seeing Andy—when they had to do it in secret. When there was all that risk.

“Yeah, you probably still feel that every time you see Andy.”

“You really think that?” Rose asked, incredulous.

“You guys are always so cute together. Smiling and holding hands.”

“Huh.” She guessed that they did do those things. “Well, I know the feelings you mean, and I can tell you that while I love my husband, he rarely makes my palms sweaty when I see him. There’s nothing like a new beginning with a new guy. All that potential. I like relationships too, and I think that’s part of the reason why. We like relationships because they’re relationships, not just hookups.”

“Right. Which is probably why the next thing happened.”

“You saw this guy, Jayden, again.”

Jordan nodded sheepishly. “A few times. After Lou moved out, he kept asking about this guy. Whether I’d seen him again. I hadn’t. I didn’t intend to. But I kept thinking of that night and how good it felt. The things he was able to do...”

Rose shifted, wondering if the bar’s A/C was broken.

“So I texted him again, on the way back from work. Booty call.”

“Does Louis know?”

“I told him last Tuesday.”

“And?”

Jordan looked away. “Lou fucked my brains out.”

This must be what it felt like to be caught in a tornado. “I’m confused,” she said with an uncertain chuckle.

“I am, too.”

“So are you getting back together?”

Jordan gave the matter some real thought. “I honestly don’t know. Now that we’re where we are, I’m not sure that’s the kind of man I want as my partner. This may sound weak of me, but I want my man to own me. Or at least want to.”

“Does Jayden own you?”

Jordan laughed. “No. Oh, no. He’s just fun, but no. I’m not going to run away with him.”

Britney, their pretty server, came by at the tail end of their conversation. “Hi, I’m sorry to interrupt, but my shift just ended. Mind if I close out your tab? You can start another.”

The question was for both of them, but the younger woman seemed to have her eyes mostly on Jordan.

“Sure, that would be lovely,” Jordan said, meeting her gaze with a lingering one of her own.

“I’ll be right back.”

Rose waited until she was gone, then said, “I think she likes you.”

“I think she’d be a lot of fun.”

Rose had never been with another woman, had never even fantasized about it, but there was something about the sexual openness of this situation—and the tequila—that got her tingling. When Britney came back with their separate checks, she’d scribbled her number on Jordan’s, next to a loopy note: “Call me.”

Jordan tucked the number discreetly into her purse.

Rose yawned. Checking her watch, she was surprised at how late it was. “I think I’m going to head home.”

“Same.” Jordan shared a yawn of her own. “I remember a time when the night would just be starting now.”

They got up, collected their things. Rose felt wobbly in her heels, and had to lean a little on her friend as they made their way out. The bar was a lot more crowded now than it had been when they’d arrived.

“Thanks for tonight, Rose. You don’t know how good it is to talk to someone else about this.”

Rose squeezed her arm. “You’d do the same for me.”

They stepped out into the night air. It was still humid and hot. It smelled like cigarettes and perfume. Rose wished she’d worn a skirt, rather than

jeans.

“If you ever find yourself cheating on Andy and him being into it, I will gladly be there for you.”

Rose kept her face a supportive, friendly mask. She smiled. She nodded. She hoped that her friend didn't notice how stiff she suddenly became.

“I'll keep that in mind.”

ANDY

L*ouis]: Have you heard back from them yet?*
It was the fifth text that Andy had received since Jordan and Rose left for Society Lounge, asking the same thing.

[Andy]: Not yet.

It was 11:30. Late for Rose, but considering the ride into the city and the crowds to contend with to get drinks, it wasn't terribly unreasonable. So he told himself. That nervousness that he felt, the paranoia that nibbled just at the edges of his sanity? That was Louis's fault, and the persistence of the man's texts.

[Louis]: I'm going crazy over here, man. Pins and needles. You're not nervous?

[Andy]: Nope

But he was. Maybe not on pins and needles, but his breathing did come shorter and tighter, and everything felt more claustrophobic. Rose never went out. Even when she met up with friends—book club, PTA, MOMS club when the kids were younger—it was usually at someone else's house. On the rare occasions that they went out, it was to the local wine bar. This, this was different. She was in the city. Where she didn't know anyone.

Where there were guys around who'd see her not as a married mother of two, but as an opportunity.

Andy had given the situation with the soap star guy some thought all week. He'd watched her carefully, seeing if she did anything unusual. She'd caught him looking, and he played it off as just a new interest in her. Twice it had led to sex—good sex, healthy, heart-pumping sex.

She wasn't having an affair, and chances were Louis just saw what he saw because that's the filter through which he viewed the world. What really resonated with Andy was the other thing that Louis had said—Rose *was* sexy, and guys *did* look at her. Not only that, but it excited Andy that they did.

[Louis]: Can I tell you something?

Before Andy could even finish reading the short text, he saw the bouncing dots as Louis composed his follow-up. Andy didn't bother replying. Louis was going to tell him this "something" regardless.

[Louis]: On Tuesday, when you were over and Jordan was supposedly working late, she was actually having sex with another man.

Andy had to read that statement several times before it could sink in. He felt the same ambushed shock that he'd felt when he first learned of their separation. Louis went on, those dots bouncing, more details coming.

[Louis]: She did need to work late, and she did get a new project, just not that late. She got a text from the guy just as she was wrapping up, and went over there. As soon as she walked in, she said she was on her knees. She told me her jaw was sore from his size!

Andy's gut squirmed. He read the text over and over, his pants tightening. His thumbs hovered over the reply button, he just didn't know what to type. At last, he settled on, "She told you this?"

[Louis]: Yeah, man. I think she kind of liked rubbing it in my face a little. She made sure I understood how big he was. And how he manhandled her, picking her up and fucking her right up against the wall. She said she almost stayed the night, but knew that if she did, she wouldn't get any sleep and she had that big project in the morning.

[Andy]: Wow.

[Louis]: I told her that next time, she should.

Of course he did, Andy thought. But the mental eye roll was half hearted. He was thinking about the pretty blonde in bed, getting “manhandled.” He was thinking about Rose, in the same position. He was trying not to think about why it was getting him so excited.

[Andy]: She rubbed it in your face? That sucks.

Andy wrote it mostly as something to say to fill the empty space. This was crazy. This didn't actually happen in real life.

[Louis]: Honestly? I liked that she did that.

Andy stared at that bombshell, too. There was a term for that. Louis jogged his memory a second later.

[Louis]: I'm a cuckold. She told me to pick up some condoms on the way over. Said that she was running low. Told me she needed XLs! And I fucking got off on that.

Andy was already struggling with what to say. This left him with nothing. Louis didn't seem bothered. He was already typing, careening on to the next thought.

[Louis]: Hey, you think maybe they're meeting up with this guy tonight?

The question pushed Andy off balance. His thumbs actually quivered as he typed his answer.

[Andy]: No. She's with Rose. And Rose wouldn't.

Andy felt vaguely feverish, like he was coming down with something.

[Louis]: But how hot would that be, man. You know Jordan's told me she's attracted to Rose. Maybe this guy asked for a threesome, and Jordan thought of your wife.

It would be hot—insane and very unlikely, but also very hot. Also, weirdly, as sexy as it was to think about his wife fooling around with another woman, it's Jordan's big-dicked lover making Rose scream that got him all mixed up.

[Andy]: Sorry, man. You can keep dreaming.

[Andy]: Also, your wife really said that about Rose?

[Louis]: Heh, we've talked about you guys a few times. Like I said, Rose is hot and people notice. ;)

There it was, the thing that tickled something forbidden within him. That feverish sensation grew.

[Louis]: Oh, shit, sounds like they're back. Let's get together tomorrow or something to compare notes. Bye!

A moment later, Andy felt the air pressure shift in the house as Rose opened and closed the front door. He was in bed, with the lights off, like he

was sleeping, even though sleep felt far, far away. He stayed there, though, listening to his heart beat as he waited.

Rose didn't come upstairs immediately, however. He heard her puttering about in the kitchen—pulling a glass from the cabinet, pouring herself some water from the sink. He waited, and as he did, a tension that he didn't quite understand began to build. Why didn't she come upstairs immediately? Was she feeling guilty? Was she mentally preparing herself to face him?

By the time she did ascend the stairs, the carpeted steps squeaking the way they always did, Andy was erect enough that he had to shift it within his boxers. Fear of being caught soared through him. He tried to think of something else to soften his erection, but thoughts of Jordan leading Rose to her well-hung lover betrayed him.

It didn't help that Rose looked stunning as she entered. Her hair was down, loose auburn waves falling around her face and shoulders. Her blouse was modest, the flowy, turquoise material sweeping along her slender body and obscuring the top of her tight jeans. He saw her the way all the guys at the bar probably saw her—sexy in a girl-next-door kind of way. Corruptible. Was that what he wanted?

“How was it?” he asked.

She jumped. “Oh, you're still awake.”

“Sorry, I...heard you come in.” He wasn't sure why he lied. It just spilled out. “You have fun?”

“Yeah.” She giggled. She'd been heading for the dresser, but walked over to him now that she knew he was awake. She sat on the edge of the bed and kissed him. She tasted like liquor. “Tomorrow's going to be rough.”

He held her close, looking into her eyes. Her makeup glittered in the light of the moon. “You're so beautiful,” he said.

Rose giggled again. He loved her smile. “So I learned something new.”

Andy's chest tightened. “Yeah?”

Rose nodded, sitting up. She started to talk, then shook her head and laughed breathily, like she couldn't believe what she was about to say.

“Jordan, she... she's having an affair.”

The word bloomed through him. Affair. It came with so many connotations, so much judgment. Yet oddly, Rose didn't use it that way. She didn't sound derisive. She didn't condemn. It was the same tone as if she'd said, “*Jordan's training for a marathon.*”

“*I know,*” is what he should have said. This was his chance to come clean, like he should have as soon as he found out—the same way Rose was sharing it now. Instead, he pretended to be surprised. “Really?” And because that rang false in his ears, he added, “Isn’t that why she kicked Louis out?”

“Yeah.” She brushed her silky hair back. “It’s complicated.”

“So they’re back together?”

“Well, no. Not really.” He couldn’t tell if her blush was from what she was about to say, or that she’d been drinking. “But I think that they’re sleeping with each other.”

Well, at least with that revelation, Andy’s surprise was genuine.

“I know!” Rose laughed. “I told you, it’s all so complicated.”

“But they’re *not* back together?”

“She says she needs someone stronger.”

Louis’s text was burning on the nightstand beside him. “*I’m a cuckold.*”

“And I guess that this guy is stronger?”

That was a blush on her face, for sure, her cheeks looking rosy. She heard something else in that question—something sexual. Something that Jordan had told her about this guy. “Jordan seems to think so.”

Rose was thinking about it now, too. She was turned on by it, even if she didn’t admit it to him. Andy reached up, pulling her close. He couldn’t resist her anymore. He had to kiss her. Had to touch her. Had to breathe her in and feel her against his body.

Their lips came together, her soft touch parting as he pressed his tongue against her. He gripped her loose blouse, pulling her into the bed with him. She went, athletically swinging a leg across his body as she bowed into the kiss.

They didn’t talk, although all kinds of questions bubbled through him—*What did Jordan like about this guy? Do you ever think about that? Am I strong enough for you?*

The last slapped him like a challenge, and he enthusiastically accepted, working open just enough buttons of her blouse that he could pull the rest of it off. She wore a bra beneath, made of simple, white satin. He pushed it up, too impatient to search for the clasp, so that he could feast on her tits and her hard, pale nipples.

“Oh, Andy,” she groaned.

He swirled his tongue around her nipples. He knew how she liked to be touched, but he wanted to push it. He ran his teeth across her nipples, drawing a squeal, and resisted the urge to ask her if she was okay, or if she liked that. He did it again, and the cry was more excitement than pain.

Not that Rose wasn't active. She squirmed over him, plucking at his t-shirt until she could pull it off. "You're so hard," she said, her voice husky from the booze of the night. She cast her bra away.

Rolling onto her back, the two worked in sync. Side by side, she unsnapped her jeans as he shoved his boxers off. Thumbs in both jeans and panties, she shimmied the tight denim down her legs. Her pussy, still shaved completely bare, glistened, tempting him to go down on her.

But they were both beyond foreplay. They needed more. They both were boiling over. Climbing between her legs, Rose grabbed his cock and guided it into her pussy. They shared a moan as he sank into her wet and welcoming sheath.

"Yes..." Rose sighed. "You feel so huge."

Huge like Jordan's lover? he wondered.

Rose gasped, feeling his cock jump at his internal question. She wrapped a leg over his back, her heel pressing against his buttocks. Flexing beneath him, she pressed her tits into his chest and rocked her head back. It was all so sexual, so comfortable.

He didn't want comfortable. He wanted to push things. He grabbed her hands, lacing his fingers through hers, and pinned them to the mattress above her head. Rose pressed up against him, groaning at the unexpected aggression. He kissed her neck, feeling how fast her blood was pumping.

Her eyes were closed, and behind those shut lids, he wondered if she was thinking about Jordan and her confession—the illicit sex that she was having with another man, a stronger man, a more exciting man. His mind had been going there a lot lately, but in this moment, as he felt his wife's very real body against his—the heat of her skin, the subtle floral scent of her, the familiar cadence of her breathing during sex—it was *all* he could think about.

For a moment, he put her in Jordan's place. He saw *Rose* out alone, at a bar, as a good looking man approached her with a drink. He imagined the way she'd look up at him, her eyes bright and open to some new possibility. And then, they'd be here, in a bedroom, their bodies sweaty and entwined as they rutted and—

“Oh, Rose!” That’s all the warning he gave her. He couldn’t hold out. Couldn’t wait for her to join him. He squeezed her fingers, trapping her beneath him, and buried his face in her hair, just above her shoulder. He slid down one last time, his cock caressed by the silky smooth embrace of her shaved sex—one last tease of the woman she could be—and he was off.

Rose arched back, digging both heels into his back as she lifted her hips against his. She struggled to escape his grip, tried to pull her hands free above her. He didn’t let her, wanting her to feel helpless, wanting her to feel something new. It worked—that, or she faked it. She tried to stifle her orgasm, clenching her teeth, but it seethed out anyway, her nostrils flaring, her eyes shut even tighter.

Andy’s arms burned from the exertion, and as soon as the high of his orgasm faded, they gave out. He collapsed into her, freeing her hands and hitting her wet, hot skin like a dead weight.

Rose laughed, pushing on his shoulder as he squeezed the air out of her. “Get off me,” she said with a giggle. “I...can’t breathe.”

Andy rolled to her side, and they sighed as one as he slipped out of her. He kissed her shoulder as she just lay there, staring at the ceiling with a smile on her face.

“That was different,” she said.

Apprehension climbed up the back of Andy’s skull. “Different good?”

“Yeah, very good.”

“You think that’s what Jordan is drawn to? Something different?”

And like that, the tension was back.

“Yeah, maybe.” She wasn’t exactly hesitant, but she also wasn’t turning to look Andy in the eyes. “I’m still trying to process it all.”

Just as Andy was trying to process his own reaction to it.

“So you had fun tonight?”

She nodded.

“Anyone try to pick you two up?” The question just popped out, and he wondered if it was a mistake as she turned to study him.

“Actually, yes.” She watched for his reaction. Did she notice the slight intake of breath? Could she hear his heart beat skip? Whether she did or not, she moved on after a pregnant pause. “But Jordan shut it down before they even came to our table.”

“She wasn’t interested?”

Rose snorted. “Actually, I think she was more interested in our server than any random guys.” Rose leaned in. “And yes, the server was a pretty, young woman.”

Andy couldn’t hold in his surprise this time. “Did she...?”

“Ha. Did she have sex with another woman while we were at the bar? Man, you guys certainly have a one-track mind.”

“I mean, come on, can you blame me?”

“Actually, no, I can’t.” That was definitely suggestive. Rose continued to surprise him, so he decided to push back.

“You know, Louis told me that Jordan has the hots for you.” Maybe not those exact words, but it got the reaction he was hoping for.

“No way,” followed quickly by, “Really?”

“You know, if you ever wanted to explore that, you don’t have to ask for permission.” This wasn’t the first time they’d jokingly discussed this, but with the revelations between Jordan and Louis, it packed more punch than Andy had anticipated.

Rose seemed to feel it, too. She walked her fingers down his chest. “Louis rubbing off on you?”

“Maybe.” He slid a hand casually behind his head. “Jordan rubbing off on you?”

Despite himself, he started to stiffen at his question, and his wife’s touch wasn’t helping. She saw something in him that he wanted to hide, and pushed her hand beneath the sheets. “Don’t you want her rubbing off on me?”

As she said it, she wrapped her hand around his hardening cock. Shame washed through him. He shouldn’t feel this way about his wife. He worried what she’d think about him.

“I love the idea of her rubbing on you,” he stuttered. While it was true, it wasn’t the main reason for his embarrassing excitement.

She studied him again. He knew that look well enough. She was weighing a heavy decision, and he felt its mass sink onto his chest.

“There’s a guy...” she began.

One simple phrase, and Andy felt his whole world implode.

ROSE

““T here’s a guy...”

Rose didn’t intend to go here, to make this confession, but as the words emerged, she knew that it was the right thing to do. Shockingly, she felt Andy’s cock thicken in her hand. With a quick breath, she went on.

“It’s really nothing. Don’t worry.” Although she was beginning to suspect that “worry” wasn’t what he was feeling. “I only just learned his name last week—” which she couldn’t find the courage to actually use in front of her husband—“but we’ve seen each other a lot at the bus stop.”

“Okay.” Andy’s voice sounded tight, like he was holding up a great deal of weight. If she wasn’t holding the evidence that some part of him was excited by this, then she would have stopped. But she was, and he grew longer and thicker with each ratcheted heartbeat.

“It’s so funny. My commute is so regular, so routine. I see the same faces day after day, week after week, and I don’t even know their names. They seem so familiar to me, yet I know so little about them.”

She was thinking about Tyler as she spoke, her focus distant. As she finished, though, she glanced at her husband, who looked both terrified and turned on.

She continued. “Not that I’d ever do it, but there are some who I’d like to get to know better.”

“This guy...”

“Tyler,” she said, and saying his name felt so fantastically guilt-ridden.

“Tyler,” Andy repeated. “You’d like to get to know him better?”

He was fully erect now, and she couldn't resist it. She moved over him, straddling his body and sinking onto his rigid cock. "Would it turn you on if I said yes?"

She felt him throb inside of her, his excitement rippling along the walls of her pussy. She bit her lower lip and braced her hands on his shoulders.

"I'll take that as a yes."

"No, Rose, I'm not... this isn't..."

She raised a brow as she gyrated on him. He was so hard, and he wasn't getting any softer, despite all of this.

He released all the pent-up air he'd been holding in his lungs and shut his eyes. She understood the conflict. She felt it, too. It was exciting, but dangerous. It was wrong, but that's part of what made it so intoxicating.

"Okay," she said, letting it go.

In many ways, he was the opposite of Louis. Andy may have liked the idea of it, he didn't want to talk about it, unlike Louis, who seemed to want to talk about it all the time. Rose wondered what was healthier, but didn't get very far.

"When we were first together," Andy began—he was looking at her once again. "When you were in my class and we had to be secretive, did you ever... were there other guys then?"

Her stomach fluttered, even though the answer was an unequivocal no. "There were guys, but not like that," she said, because she didn't think he wanted the disappointing truth.

"Not even dates to keep up appearances?" he asked. "You were a pretty, young coed in your last year—"

"And all of us coeds are sex-starved nymphomaniacs, huh?" she cut him off, but she said it with a laugh. Andy's face grew darker.

"Well, you did give me a blowjob once in the faculty bathroom before I went out to lecture."

"So now you're wondering if my study dates sometimes led to wild sex in the library stacks." She was teasing, but his reaction was undeniable. He gasped. He throbbed inside of her. His eyes went wide as he stared up from the bed. "The smell of books has always been a turn on for me."

"Really?"

"No, not really, although I was a big old nerd back then. When guys asked me out, I just told them that I had a date with the library." She leaned

down kissed his forehead. “And I’m sorry to say, I usually did have a date with the library.”

But it was interesting that it turned Andy on thinking otherwise, and it was exciting to know she could still turn him on, could still surprise him. The way he stared at her now, like he was seeing her for the first time, was amazing.

It looked like he was building up the courage to ask something. Rose pressed down into him, riding him quietly, letting him work through his own confused emotions.

“So you and this guy from the bus stop...”

Her heart skipped. So they went back to him. “Yes?” she asked, her heart aflutter, her nerves on edge.

“You like him.”

“I mean, I don’t really know him...” She stopped, though, as she met her husband’s eyes. Unlike his question about their time together at school, the answer that Andy wanted and the truth were perfectly aligned. “It’s more of a crush.”

She wanted to look away. So did Andy. Neither of them did. He said, “So he’s good looking?”

Rose draped herself over him, brushing her hair over one shoulder to keep it out of his face as she nuzzled his nose with hers. She didn’t need to think hard to imagine Tyler at the pool without a shirt on, showing off his broad shoulders and well-formed pecs. “He’s cute.”

“And he thinks you’re cute.”

It was the kind of thing she never dared to think before. She was never that kind of girl, confident enough to assume others were into her. But Tyler, without a doubt, was. Even admitting it felt wrong. Like smoking a cigarette or driving too fast.

“He does,” she said.

Andy groaned. He pulled her into him, kissing her as he ran his free hand down her body. He grabbed her ass, pulling her close, urging her to ride him faster. She did, bouncing along his cock as she allowed herself to imagine it was Tyler inside of her.

The fantasy felt like electrocution. It was almost painful. It frayed her sense of right and wrong in such a delicious, jolting way.

Out of nowhere, she was coming. She broke the kiss, needing air, needing to moan, pressing her face into his neck as her orgasm racked her

body.

“Come, baby. Come,” she begged, grinding her hips into his. He’d already come once. He was hard, but knew he could last much longer after the first. Unless she short circuited it. “Quickly, baby, before my husband gets home.”

It was like pulling a trigger. Before she’d even finished it, he was bucking up off the bed and digging his fingers into his ass. His come seared through her, liquid heat that she imagined, just for a split second, was not her husband’s.

“Oh my—” Her breath caught. Held. Released all at once. “—oh my God!”

When it was over, when their bodies were finished shuddering and gasping and tingling, when Rose crumpled into Andy’s arms and she was finally aware of how sweaty they’d become, the weight of their confessions finally landed.

“You know that I’m only teasing, right?” Rose asked. She was surprised by how husky her voice was, and cleared her throat. “I barely know him, really.”

Andy smoothed his hand over her damp hair. “I actually like it.”

“Yeah?”

He didn’t answer immediately, and for a second, Rose wondered if he’d fallen asleep. She felt exhaustion tugging. It was so comfortable in his arms.

But he wasn’t asleep. He was thinking, and his next statement gave her a glimpse into his mind. “I’m not Louis, you know.”

“Of course not.” But in some ways, he was, she didn’t point out. “It’s just a fantasy.”

“That’s not exactly it,” he said. He sighed, collecting himself. “I like that... I like the idea of you being naughty. Or having this naughtier side. Of...” She felt him gulp beneath her head. “Of having secrets, honestly. Like Tyler.”

She blushed at the man’s name, and felt guilty that she did. She wanted to tell him that she was sorry that she didn’t tell him about Tyler right away, but held her tongue.

“You’re still full of surprises,” he said. “Sometimes I forget and take you for granted. I like that.” He shifted so he could look down at her. She glanced up through her lashes. “So it’s more than just a fantasy. It’s the possibility that it could be real that’s thrilling.”

He was telling the bald and honest truth. She saw it in the way he was staring at her, like he wanted to flinch and was doing everything he could not to. She saw it in the pinch of his brow and the shallowness of his breathing.

He wanted it, but didn't.

Rose liked that idea, too. She liked having secrets. It was why she was drawn to Andy in the first place—as much because of her attraction to him as it was the secret of it all. It was the thrill she got when she'd occasionally wear something racier beneath her clothes. Or why she kept shaving her bush. What would her coworkers think if they knew their Type A, soccer mom colleague kept herself bare down there?

Rose liked secrets, and liked that she could start developing a deeper one with Tyler...with her husband's unspoken approval.

Little did she know how deep that secret would grow.

ANDY

By all accounts, that night should have marked a sea change for Andy and Rose. Whether they agreed to it or not, Andy had confessed to his wife that the thought of her with another man not only turned him on, but he maybe, possibly didn't want it to just be a fantasy.

They didn't discuss it the next morning, as they probably should have. They didn't compare notes and work through their expectations. Instead, they got up, made breakfast for the kids, and lost themselves in the reality of raising two boys in the suburbs. Lucas had soccer. Charlie had taekwondo. They went strawberry picking on Sunday in the country and stopped by a vineyard to drink wine as the boys ran through the fields in the late summer afternoon.

It was idyllic, like the universe was conspiring to force them to forget what was insinuated and suggested but not spoken.

The following week, the whole family went to the beach with Rose's family—her mom and dad, her sister with her husband and kids, some family friends. Rose even broke out the bikini—at Andy's insistence—and seemed to even grow comfortable wearing it by the time they packed up and headed home at week's end.

Still, there were little things that reminded him that it all wasn't a dream. The bikini was the biggest of them, of course, and how good she looked lying about on the beach with all that skin exposed. Rose's sister's husband, a nice enough guy, tried so hard not to ogle her—he failed so miserably all weekend long.

There were other things, though. Like watching her get dressed in the morning for work. Her lingerie all seemed new, but maybe he'd just failed to pay attention these last few years. She owned more thongs than he remembered, and was more willing to wear them with more than just tight slacks or skirts.

But it wasn't just that, either. It was the way she carried herself. She moved like she expected others were looking, if that made sense. Or at least expected *him* to be looking. She'd catch him checking her out, give him a sly smile, and say nothing more.

A few times, he came home to find her still in her workout clothes, the tight, cropped pants and racerback tank seeming to say, "*Yes, I worked out, and you're probably wondering for who.*" Or maybe that was just in his head.

She'd gone to happy hour once, just after their beach week, when her face still glowed with a tan and her hair was streaked with natural, copper highlights. Andy had encouraged her, then spent the whole evening dwelling on the fantasy that she was meeting Tyler, not her coworkers.

It all was subtle stuff like that, all unspoken, all possibility—*probably*—in his head. Then, of course, there was Louis.

"Dude, you didn't tell me Jordan sent the kids to her Mom's."

Andy had just stepped out of his car after a five-hour round trip drive to drop the boys off at sleep-away camp. It was nine o'clock on a Saturday night, and all he wanted to do was go inside and snuggle with Rose in front of the TV. He glanced forlornly at his front door before turning to his neighbor.

"What?"

Louis was sitting on his front stoop, a long-neck bottle of beer in his hand. It didn't look like his first. He stood, dusted off his jeans, and crossed over to Andy.

"Jordan took the kids to her mom's, man. For the whole weekend. You should have told me."

Andy blinked. The long drive had made his mind slow, but he was having a hard time figuring out whether he'd done something wrong or not.

"Um, I'm sorry, Louis. I don't keep tabs on her—"

"What about Rose? You don't keep tabs on her, either?"

That plucked at Andy's gut. "What about Rose?"

"Just that I saw the two of them go out tonight is all."

Andy glanced at his townhome. The lights were off. He felt the blood drain from his face.

“You didn’t know?” Louis said.

“I was dropping the kids off at camp.” Andy barely heard his own words. His mind was racing. He’d actually made really good time. Last year, when he made this trip, it had been after eleven when he got home, and when he left earlier today, they both figured he’d return around the same time. “They went out?”

“Yeah, a couple hours ago.” Louis grinned. “Rose was looking pretty good in this short sundress. Those two will get a lot of attention, wherever they went.”

Andy was having a hard time processing it all. He wasn’t exactly sure what a sundress was, but understood “short” and imagined some of the dresses she used to wear, pre-kids. Rose was tall, so the short dresses with their thin shoulder straps always looked so small on her.

He checked his phone for a text that he might have missed on his drive home. There was nothing.

“Hey, I’m sorry to get you all worried,” Louis said. The man seemed to finally realize that Andy may not be okay with this. “It’s probably fine. Most likely, they’re just grabbing dinner.”

Andy nodded, needing to believe that—yet also, weirdly, not wanting to. “What are you doing here, anyway, Louis?”

Louis shuffled, staring down at his shoes, then back up at Andy shyly. Andy realized that his neighbor’s Subaru wasn’t parked in front of the townhomes.

“You stalking your wife?”

“No, not exactly,” Louis said.

Andy shook his head. This wasn’t cool. “How did you know they went out?”

Louis groaned, tilting his head back and cracking his neck. He fished his phone from his back pocket, navigated to something, and handed it to Andy. “I got this last night. I think that she expects me to...keep tabs on her. Like a game.”

Andy took the phone gingerly, like it was a live hand grenade. A series of text messages glared back up at him.

[Jordan]: Okay, they’re gone and I’m all alone. It’s so quiet.

[Jordan]: Let’s change that.

[Jordan]: And I know how you respond to incentives. So... here's your incentive. :P

The next text was an image, and Andy almost dropped the phone when he scrolled to it. It was of Jordan, with her wavy, golden hair and her sinuous, bikini body, naked. She was standing in profile, so her hip blocked a view of her pussy and an arm was covering most of her large breasts. In her other hand, poised against her ribs, was the phone taking the selfie. She looked like an Instagram model, all curves and sassy confidence.

[Jordan]: Oh shit. Wrong text thread. Sorry Lou, ignore this.

Followed by a devil emoji.

Followed by Louis asking who she meant to send it to. She never wrote him back.

"Maybe she's just messing with you." He handed the phone back.

"Maybe." Louis clearly didn't believe it. He took a swig of his beer, looking a little shifty. "I'll know after tonight."

Andy stared at him. "What's that mean?"

Louis shook his head. "Don't worry about it." Beer still in hand, he started to cross the parking lot, toward the street. "I'll see you around, man. Text me when your wife gets home."

Louis jogged the last ten feet, turned, and strolled down the sidewalk.

Andy grabbed his bags and went into his house, confused by what the hell just happened. The house was empty, and felt it. No boys. No Rose. He looked at his phone again, brought up the text thread with his wife, as if maybe she'd sent him something that he'd missed. Nothing.

He started to type out a message, telling her that he was home and asking where she was. Then deleted it. Instead, he went upstairs, switching on lights to fill the void.

On the bed were a couple dresses, laid out and discarded. He recognized them—long maxi dresses that Rose wore when she wanted to look dressier yet still casual. Between them was an empty spot, where the dress she'd chosen must have been. His pants tightened as he wondered what that must have been.

He re-hung the dresses in the closet, then wandered into the bathroom to get ready for bed. Sitting on the counter was a bottle of perfume. That gave him pause. He drifted to it, his stomach fluttering. Picking it up, he inhaled the floral that was so entwined with his wife's identity. Her makeup kit was out, too, sitting on the counter where she'd done up her face.

None of this meant anything. Rose would have done all of this whether he was there or not, and there was nothing too wild about the makeup she'd left. No red, hot lipstick. No bold mascara. Still, after his encounter with Louis, it left him unsettled.

He stripped, took a shower and rinsed away the grunge of the road trip. She still wasn't home when he got out, though, and while it was only 9:30, he brushed his teeth, grabbed his cotton pajama bottoms, and got ready for bed.

He climbed into bed and turned their television on—a baseball game that he didn't bother paying enough attention to even check the score. He was lost in the thoughts of Rose, out with a red hot Jordan, who'd invited a stranger into her bed last night. It could have been a cruel trick at Louis's expense, but Andy doubted it.

When Rose finally came home, he felt a sense of déjà vu. He felt the pressure in the house shift as she opened and closed the door. He heard her pour herself a glass of water in the kitchen. Felt his chest tighten as she climbed the stairs.

He tried to look casual as she entered, stretched an arm behind his head awkwardly before deciding that was silly. "Welcome back, honey," she said, breezing into the room. "How was the drive?"

"Pretty quick, actually." He shut the game off. "You look great. Date night?"

He watched her carefully as he made the joke, trying to discern any flicker of guilt or shame. She just smiled and raised her brows. "Thanks. I'm glad it still fits."

Andy recognized the dress, although it was definitely one of the ones from the back of her closet, from before the kids. With its loose skirt and thin shoulder straps, the yellow sundress really showed off how much sun she'd been getting lately.

"Looks even better now than before," he said. "How's Jordan doing?"

"How do you know I was out with Jordan?" Rose asked. She moved to the dresser and unfastened her cute, teardrop earrings. She'd had her nails done, he noted, a pale coral color that matched her toes.

"You weren't?" Even knowing that this was a tease, the sinful possibility that she was out with another man started to wind him up.

"Maybe I finally accepted Tyler's invitation to dinner."

Andy forced himself to take a deep breath. He wasn't getting enough oxygen. He got even less when she pushed the dress from her shoulders and let it pool around her ankles. Beneath, she wore nothing but a white thong that made her taut ass look even better.

Maybe I finally accepted Tyler's invitation. Finally. Implying that he'd been inviting her, and she'd been declining. He couldn't stop himself. "So he's asked you to dinner before?"

Rose glanced at him, seemingly happy that he'd taken the bait. "Hm?" she said. Like she hadn't heard, or understood his question, when clearly she had. Instead, she hooked her thumbs into the sides of her thong and skimmed them over her hips.

"So the kids are all settled into camp?" She walked to her closet, naked and flaunting it.

"They, um... yeah, you know how it is. They complained the whole way there, but as soon as they saw their friends, they forgot about Dad."

She disappeared into her closet, her voice muffled as she replied. "Thanks for doing the drive. I know it's long."

"It's no big deal."

"Two weeks of kid-free time. I know I'm going to miss them, but I figure, might as well take advantage of it, right?"

When she emerged, she'd changed into a pinkish red negligee that Andy didn't recognize. It was short, slinky, sexy—like the woman Rose was becoming. He stared at her legs, which seemed to go on forever. They were encased in pale stockings that ended in lacy bands that the negligee didn't come close to covering.

"Wow, that's..." Andy forced himself to lift his jaw up off the ground. "Wow."

Rose giggled, and he was comforted to see her blush. Beneath the racy lingerie was still his wife. "I did a little online shopping to prepare."

"I approve," he said with a laugh. "Got anything else back there?"

Rose sauntered up to the bed. "You'll just have to be patient and see," she said, crawling onto the bed. He couldn't keep from looking into her cleavage. "But I may have a few surprises. After all, I've got a couple men to tease now, don't I?"

More than the lingerie, more than even the subtle mention of dinner, this ignited Andy. He reached out, pulling her the rest of the way to the bed.

"That's fine, just make sure that I get the first preview."

She gasped as he pulled her close, kissing her hard. Running his hand along the back of her thigh, he could feel the seam of her stocking. If the situation wasn't hot enough, it was yet another dose of fuel.

"Mmm, deal." She shoved his boxers down between kisses. "We're going to have some fun."

ROSE

“So how was the rest of your night?” Rose asked Jordan the next day. Andy had gone to the hardware store to start a painting project they’d been putting off, so she’d met up with Jordan at the pool to enjoy the lunchtime lull before Jordan has to pick up her daughter.

Jordan sat on the edge of her lounge, rubbing sunblock along her toned legs. Bent over like that, her breasts spilled out of her string bikini, drawing plenty of attention from the guys around them. She stopped, glancing up at Rose with a smile before answering. “Oh, it was fun.”

Rose blushed, turning away from her friend. She wanted to probe, but suddenly felt embarrassed. Unlike last night, she didn’t have a few drinks in her. Jordan had no such reluctance.

“And yes, we did that thing I said.”

Rose’s heart palpitated. “Did it...” She felt like she was burning up.

“Fit?” Jordan laughed. “Yes. Did it hurt? Oh yeah, it did.” She finished her legs, then rolled onto her stomach and began to sun her back. “Or are you asking if it felt good?”

“I’m just...” Rose had never had a friend quite so forward with her sexual escapades. It sometimes felt like she was always running to catch up. When she was younger, she was never one of the cool kids, and this was one of the reasons. She hated the compulsion to keep up. She just wanted to be herself. But with Jordan, it was less about that. More like vicarious living, perhaps. “I’ve never done that. Sounds painful.”

“Mind getting my back? I can’t reach the middle,” Jordan said. Rose picked up the bottle and sat on the edge of Jordan’s lounge so she could slather sunblock on her friend. Jordan’s skin was soft beneath her fingers, and already hot from the sun.

With her face resting on the backs of her hands, she said, “I haven’t done it since college, but...” Her voice was quiet enough that no one could hear around them. “...there’s nothing like feeling a cock in your ass. You should try it. It’s so... full.” Jordan sighed. “Your hands feel good, Rose. You’ve got a nice touch.”

Like that, Rose wanted to snatch her hands away. She’d suspected the blonde of flirting with her a few times over the last couple weeks, but this felt like the most direct. Jordan never mentioned if she did anything with their server, Britney’s, number, but Rose had wondered a few times about it.

Not that she was curious. She wasn’t. Not sexually, anyway. But she did wonder.

As she ran her sunscreen slathered fingers beneath the dainty tie of Jordan’s bikini, she sought to change the subject, grasping at the first thing that came to mind beyond anal sex or Jordan’s smooth skin.

“So I think Louis may be rubbing off on Andy.” She ran her fingers one last time down Jordan’s spine and stepped away, returning to her own lounge. She wished she hadn’t actually said the thing that she did, though, especially when Jordan slid her sunglasses down the bridge of her nose and fixed her with a curious, blue-eyed stare.

“Go on,” she said.

“Um, just the...you know. Louis’s thing with you and other...others.”

Jordan raised a brow. “So you told him about that?”

“Well.” Rose was really bad at lying, so she went with the truth. “I’m sorry. I had to tell him. He’s my—”

“I’m just fucking with you. It’s fine. Even expected. That does explain the way he’s been looking at me lately.”

“He’s been looking at you?”

“Never mind that. So you told him and...what? He’s into the idea?”

“Not quite like Louis, but I think so, yeah. But honestly, I think he’s worried that I’ll have the same initial reaction that you did, and kick him out.” She thought about last night. “Well, maybe he used to worry.”

“Something happen?”

“No, not really—”

“Even more interesting!” Jordan lit up.

“I sort have been teasing him. Like...” Now she really didn’t want to talk, yet had come this far. Jordan wasn’t going to give her slack now. “Like last night, when we were having dinner, I knew he’d probably get back before I did, but I didn’t tell him I was going out. And when I did get home, I didn’t tell him I was out with you.”

“I’m impressed, Rose. You’re more devious than you let on.”

Rose felt the flush of pride, like a pupil getting an accolade from the teacher.

“And Andy was into it?”

Rose thought about their faux deal, where she’d buy things for another man, but have to show Andy first. “Yeah. He didn’t say it directly, but yeah. He’s into it.”

“And what about you, Rose? Are you?”

She’d been expecting the question, and yet it still arrived with a throb. “I’m just having fun.”

As if on queue, Tyler walked into the pool, a bag in hand, wearing a t-shirt that complimented his muscular frame. Even behind his sunglasses, she could feel his eyes on her. Another throb pulsed through her, centered deep between her legs.

“Right,” Jordan said, not believing her for a moment. Rose barely heard her. Tyler was crossing the pool deck, headed right for her!

Despite a few more flirty encounters at the bus stop, they’d not run into one another at the pool since. This was also the first time that she’d worn her bikini in front of him, and she suddenly worried that something was out of place, or the angle that she was lying at made her look fat, or that she had a smear of sunblock in some embarrassing and unfortunate spot.

None of this was lost on Jordan, who turned to follow her eyes just in time to see Tyler wave. She looked back at Rose, catching Rose returning the greeting. Mercifully, Jordan didn’t say anything.

“Hello, Rose,” Tyler said. “Hot day.”

“Very.” Somehow, she kept her voice even. “Tyler, this is my neighbor, Jordan. Jordan, this is Tyler, my bus mate, I guess?”

“It’s nice to meet you, Jordan.” He spent a moment too long lingering on the blonde’s body. Jealousy thickened in her chest before she could rationalize it away. “Mind if I join you two?”

“Please,” Jordan said, a wide smile beneath her sunglasses. “Actually, I need to run and pick up Lillian from my mom’s. Nice meeting you, Tyler. Call me later, Rose. I’d like to hear more about this whole situation.”

The situation being Tyler. Rose was thankful for the heat to cover her reddening cheeks. “Talk to you later.”

Rose expected Tyler’s eyes to be on the blonde as she packed her things and left. When she looked at him, though, he was staring at her own body, and once again she remembered the bikini.

“Haven’t seen you in a bit,” she said, trying to calm herself.

“Yeah. I’ve had a lot of travel lately.” He peeled his shirt off, and Rose practically sighed as she traced his pecs down to the ridges of his abs. She wondered if his chest hair was as soft as it looked. She wondered if his abs rippled as he fucked.

She cleared her throat, but it didn’t quite clear her thoughts.

“So where are the kids?” he asked, looking around.

“Camp. Where they’ll be for the first two weeks. My husband just dropped them off last night.” They never mentioned her husband, and it felt awkward here.

“So that mean you’re all alone right now?” There wasn’t anything lurid about the way he said it. The question was conversational to anyone listening in. To Rose, she heard the suggestion, and her pulse raced.

“Right now, yes.” She enjoyed this man’s company. He was dangerous, but in a fun way. “But not for long. Andy’s at Home Depot.”

“A man after my own tastes. Hope he’s looking into lawn care.”

She giggled at the inside joke. They had inside jokes, and she felt giddy that they did.

“So you live close to the pool?” she found herself asking. She heard her own flirty suggestion in the question, but didn’t stumble to clarify. Like last night, she let it linger.

Tyler pointed across the way, to a row of townhomes. “Third one down. No more than a minute’s walk.”

She could just about imagine him adding, “*Want to go?*” ’ and was happy when he didn’t. Sort of happy, anyway.

“Well, that’s convenient. With it so close, though, I would have thought you’d have a better tan.”

Tyler laughed. “I travel far too much to take advantage, but now that I know you’re here more, I’m going to make it a point.” He glanced along

her body, and she involuntarily sucked in her stomach, even though she didn't have to. "I see your tan's coming along nicely."

She felt dizzy, like she'd just downed a shot. In fact, a shot would have been nice right about then.

She pulled at the end of her ponytail, a thing that she did when she got nervous. "Thanks. We got to the beach the week before last." Which she'd already told him at the bus stop once, and felt dumb for repeating it. "You taking any vacations this summer?"

"Not really. I'm currently doing a lot of business in Germany, so plan on taking a few extra days here and there while I can."

"Oh? What is it that you do?"

"It's pretty boring, really. Energy consulting for big, international corporations. It does let me travel, though."

"Sounds like coming back here is the most boring part."

She didn't need to see his eyes, hidden behind his aviators, to know that he was checking her out. "There are certainly things here that get me excited."

Rose laughed incredulously. "You did not just say that."

Tyler grinned. He didn't look away from her, not for one moment. "What can I say? It's exciting, living this close to the pool."

She cleared her throat. "I like it, too, but I'm burning up."

"Want me to reapply your sunscreen?"

For one tempting moment, she let herself fantasize about his hands all over her. She wondered if they were callused, despite his consultant job.

"I'm actually going to head back home. We've got some rooms to paint up."

He nodded. "The pool just got a lot less exciting."

Rose laughed. She should have left things at that, but her body tingled as she imagined setting up another pool date with him. Then, because she was feeling good, she did it. "I'll be back tomorrow. I usually try to catch some sun in the late afternoon, if I can get home early."

Tyler brightened. "Incentive to leave early, then. Maybe I'll see you, Rose."

"Goodbye, Tyler."

Walking home, Rose felt like she was floating. It was a dangerous, guilty thing to feel, but she allowed herself to feel it anyway. Andy wouldn't know what hit him.

ANDY

This was the second summer in which the boys had gone to sleep-away camp, but it was still strange not to have them around. Last summer, when they did it, Andy had figured it would be like resetting their relationship to pre-children. Instead, they just did a ton of projects that they'd been putting off because of the kids. This summer was shaping up to be much the same.

Only not exactly. They still had a list of chores: repaint the bedrooms, wash all the windows, regrout the bathroom tubs, replace the busted blinds, etc, etc. But there was also this new energy with Rose. They ended up taking a paint-break to fuck right on the dropcloth after Rose playfully ran a wet brush along his neck. She was on fire.

Monday, when he got home, Rose practically attacked him. She always got home before he did, so it left him wondering what got her so worked up. His imagination did a good job coming up with very naughty, very sexy explanations, but by Tuesday, he had to know the truth.

He left work early, getting home before Rose. He told himself he came home to put the last coat of paint on the boys' rooms, but even he couldn't be so self-deceptive. He was there to look out the window every two minutes on the off-chance that he'd catch Rose walking by with her bus stop friend.

When that actually happened, shortly after four in the afternoon, he nearly vomited. He didn't. Instead, his cock sprang to life.

He was a good looking man, Andy had to give him. Closer to Rose's age than his own, he had the kind of svelte build that carried muscles well,

with little work. Andy touched his belly self-consciously as this younger man patted his own, flat stomach and asked Rose something. “Dinner?” Andy imagined, thinking back to the one night when they brought this man up.

“No,” Rose seemed to say, shaking her head. But then, a moment later, she nodded and, instead of walking into their house, the two continued down the street.

Andy’s heart dropped, and for a long, long moment, he figured that this was a dream. Had to be. But as he waited to wake up and watched his wife disappear around the corner with this guy, chatting the whole way, he came to realize that maybe he was awake after all.

The text from Louis dispelled the last of his doubts.

[Louis]: Hey man, I need to talk to you. Like, right now. What are you doing and can you meet me at Eddie’s?

Andy stared at the message. Was Louis spying again? Was he going to tell Andy what he already knew? Or maybe the man had even more information.

[Andy]: This about Rose? Because I know.

I know. Andy’s stomach swam at his own text. *I know about the other guy. I know they went back to his place.* Andy had to steady himself on the windowsill. The fumes of the paint had him dizzy.

[Louis]: WTF are you talking about? Rose?

Andy blinked.

[Louis]: Tell me about it in person. At Eddie’s. In, like ten minutes.

[Louis]: P.S. I’m already there.

Andy looked one last time down the street, in the direction that Rose went. If he left now, he might still be able to see where they went.

[Andy]: Fine. I'll be right there.

ANDY DID GET THERE PRETTY QUICKLY, but he wasn't all there. Not mentally. He was agonizing over what he'd witnessed, memorializing each detail like it was all he'd have left. Rose was wearing a green knit top, with quarter-length sleeves and a front that didn't reveal any cleavage, but conformed enough to her breasts that it was sexy enough.

It was her skirt that he fixated on, though, khaki and snug and shorter than what she normally wore. She'd teased him that morning with it—making sure that he saw the nude-colored thigh-highs she rolled up her long legs. The skirt wasn't so short that it would reveal the lacy edge of them, but he knew it was there, and he wondered if he was alone.

Then there was the guy. Rose had said his name once before, but Andy couldn't remember it. Trevor or Travis or something. He looked British, so Andy assigned him a sophistication that he probably didn't have. He imagined the man, his shirt-sleeves rolled up, pouring them both a glass of Chardonnay. He imagined the two laughing as they sat out back on the deck, Rose's feet resting in his lap. He imagined the other man casually run his hand up her leg, discovering the stocking, exploring more.

"There you are. Dude, what took so long?" Louis asked.

Eddie's was back in the city, closer to his work than his house. Andy didn't bother explaining it. Louis was sitting in a booth and had already ordered a pint of some light-looking beer for Andy.

"So what's so urgent?" Andy asked.

Louis fiddled with his phone, spun it around, and slid it before Andy. A video was playing.

"Jesus!" Andy blurted before he could help himself.

On the little screen was Jordan, lying on her back, getting plowed by a large, muscular, black man. He held one of her legs over her shoulder as he fucked her, each thrust causing her full tits to judder up and down her chest.

She arched back, her body forming a sinuous S, pressing her blond head into the pillows as she grabbed her breasts and squeezed.

"Ohmy...oh...my... oh fuck!" Louis had the volume turned down low, but even still, Jordan's moans sounded loud, distorting in the small speakers as they burned up Andy's ears.

Andy tore his eyes off the screen, glancing around and expecting half the bar to be staring at them. His cheeks were warm. "Dude, turn that off."

Louis shook his head. "Keep watching. It gets better."

Andy knew he shouldn't, but he couldn't stop himself. As he turned the volume down on the phone, his hand shaking, he stared in rapt amazement as his neighbor came down from her orgasm. Her body was dripping with perspiration, glistening off of what appeared to be the bright light of day just beyond the windows.

She said something that Andy could no longer hear, appeared to laugh to herself, and turned to look at something off camera. That something stepped into the frame a moment later—another black man, his body seemingly carved out of a block of lean, dark muscle.

The new guy crouched on the bed, leaned in, and kissed her passionately. They exchanged a few quiet words before the two men switched places.

"That second guy is Jayden," Louis explained. "The man she met at the bar last month. I don't know who his friend is."

Jayden takes control of her, clamping his large hands on her thighs to yank her towards him. She moans, reaching down to feed his large cock into her pussy. There was no protection, Andy realized, and there was no hesitation. They were familiar with one another. They knew how to make one another tick. He twisted her so that she was half on her side, her knees together as he took her from behind.

His friend didn't remain idle. He scooted into place, blocking the camera's view of her face as she craned forward and sucked on his cock.

"When was this?" Andy asked, mesmerized.

"Earlier today."

"Were you there?" The camera, he realized, was not jumpy, the way it would be if held. "Did you have a tripod set up or something?"

"No, not exactly."

Andy finally tore his eyes off the homemade porn to look at his neighbor. Louis was staring sheepishly into his half-drained beer.

“What did you do?”

Louis blew out a puff of air and hesitantly looked up at Andy. “I may have put a few, um, hidden cameras throughout the place.”

Andy just stared at him.

“I had to know, man. After that text last week, about him coming over and all, I had to fucking know.” He ran his fingers through his thinning hair. “Don’t judge. Don’t judge—”

“I’m judging!” Andy blurted. “What the hell, dude?”

“*Oh, fuck, Jay. That’s so... so fucking—*” Andy stopped the video, darkening the phone’s screen.

“You’d do the same if you were in my shoes.” Louis licked his lips. “I know you would.”

Andy considered the fact that he’d come home early for possibly that very reason. Was this the natural extension? Would he soon be bugging her car? Their bedroom? The thought was revolting. “No, man. I wouldn’t. If I wanted to know what she was doing, I’d just ask.”

But for Andy, he wasn’t sure if he actually wanted to know what she was doing.

Louis stared at him like he didn’t believe him, but seemed to let it go. “So you think I should tell her about this?”

That was a bad idea, Andy thought. But Louis went on before he could say it.

“Because Jordan invited me over tonight, to have a talk about us, and I’m thinking of telling her.”

“No. Bad idea.”

“But you just gave me shit about recording—”

“If she finds out you did that, you’re done.” Andy tapped the phone like he hoped it would break. “It’s wrong on so many levels, man. I shouldn’t even know. I wish I could erase my brain.”

“I don’t know, man.”

“Where did you even find cameras that small.” Andy shook his head. “You know? Never mind. I don’t want to know.”

Louis batted his phone between his hands. “You ever heard of reclamation sex?”

“Can’t say that I have.”

“It’s when a husband takes back his wife, after she was with another guy. And dude, that’s all I can think of tonight. I want to reclaim the shit out

of her.”

“Not sure that’ll be in the cards. She did kick you out.”

“And we’ve had some of the best sex ever since then. Ironical, huh?”

“Man, I honestly don’t understand you.”

Louis grinned, slapping the table. “Well, thanks for listening to my crazy rant.”

Andy moved to pull out his wallet to pay for his beer when Louis waved him off. “I’ve already got it.”

“Thanks.”

Andy figured they were done. He started to leave when Louis asked, “So tell me, what is it that you know about Rose?”

Andy froze. “Hm?”

“Your text. You said you already know. Know what?”

Busted. Andy would finally have to talk.

ROSE

Rose had been in other townhomes, of course, but it still surprised her how different they were from unit to unit, despite having the exact same floor plan. Stepping into Tyler's home was like entering bizarro world. He'd stripped the main wall of his living room down to the brick, leaving it exposed like they were in a hipster's coffee shop. Complementing it, the furniture was like a mashup of reclaimed rustic and mid century modern. He had red pendant lights hanging over a kitchen bar where Rose had a wall in her own unit.

"I haven't seen that before. I thought that was load-bearing," she said.

Tyler pointed to the beam that the lights hung from. "Took some work, but I redirected it."

"It's nice. Feels very open in here."

"I screened the back deck in, too." He went to the fridge and removed a bottle of chilled white wine. Rose felt that twinge of illicit excitement that came with every interaction with Tyler. True to his word, he'd been at the pool yesterday. Things were building between them, and even Rose didn't live so deep in naïveté that she could convince herself that he was just being friendly. It wasn't like her own intentions were so pure, either.

Rose wandered to the mantle over his gas fireplace. In her home, she had it lined with photos of her boys and their family. Tyler had landscapes of the places he'd presumably traveled—the skyline of Paris, the forests of Germany, a desert view with camels in the distance.

"You travel much?" Tyler asked, suddenly at her side.

“Some. Mostly within the country though.” This close, he smelled good. Not like cologne or deodorant, but musky and natural and different than her husband. She pointed to the desert photo as she took her glass of wine. “Where’s that?”

“Morocco.” He took it down from the mantle. “Beautiful, isn’t it? How the sand dunes rise and fall in such graceful curves.”

Like a woman’s, he didn’t have to say for it to be heard. She half expected to feel his touch on her arm, or his lips on her neck. It didn’t come. Tyler had been playing the gentleman for too long to throw it all away like that.

She could turn, right now, and he’d be there. She could put a hand on his shoulder, feel the hard muscle that she’d admired at the pool. He’d lean in and—

“So show me this screened in deck,” she said, clearing her throat and turning away from him, toward the back. She felt his eyes on her ass and legs, and was very conscious of the short slit up the back, and the possibility that he might catch a glimpse of her stocking tops.

She hadn’t dressed for Tyler, exactly, but when she had dressed, she had him in mind. And now here she was, in his house, alone, a glass of wine in hand at four o’clock on a Tuesday afternoon.

She hoped that being outside, where the neighborhood could see them, would force them to behave. Stepping outside, into the humid summer heat, she realized how wrong she was. Rather than looking deeper into the housing complex, Tyler’s unit faced the woods that bordered it. He’d pulled the long shades on either side of the deck, so that not even his immediate neighbors could see them.

“Wow, it’s so hot,” Tyler said. He flipped on a ceiling fan, offering a bit of breeze. “That’s the one problem with it back here. Despite the screens, it traps heat.”

Rose stared out at the forest. It was so peaceful. She could almost pretend that they were far away from the warren of families and playgrounds and suburbs, in a cabin removed from the world. Alone with this exciting, new man.

“I love it,” she said.

Dark, squares off wicker furniture with bright orange pillows lined the outside of the deck. A peace lily dominated one corner. More planes hung

from the rafters, along with Christmas lights that were currently switched off. Being here in the evening would have been magical.

Tyler stepped up beside her and held out his glass. "This is why I bought this place, more than anything. I like the city, but when I'm home, I value peace and quiet."

Rose nodded, barely hearing him. She was wound up, her gut tied up in knots that tightened and tightened until she could barely breathe. She should not be here. She should definitely not be here!

"To peace and quiet?"

It took Rose a moment to realize that he was toasting. Despite all the space in the room, he was right there, beside her, just inside her comfort zone. She had to lift her glass of wine close to her body just to clink return the toast.

She focused on the crisp, buttery taste of the Chardonnay rather than the scent of this other man. "This is good." She took another sip. "Let me guess, you brought it back from France after personally meeting the owners of the vineyard."

Tyler's laugh was different than her husband's. He was more open, more confident. Rose wondered if he was like that in bed, too, then cursed herself for thinking it. "Close." He swirled the white wine in his glass, sniffing it. "Napa, actually."

Of course.

"Brought here via Harris Teeter Groceries. I did have a nice conversation with the checkout lady, though. I suppose that counts as personally meeting her."

Rose almost hated this man for how easily he made her smile.

"I'm not as exciting a guy as you think I am, Rose. I travel, almost exclusively for work, and it means that I don't have much of a life of my own." He waved about his deck. "You're the first neighbor that I've met here, and I've lived in Chesterbrook for over a year."

"It's because the only view you've got is the woods." She moved away from him, brushing her shoulder along his chest as she found a seat by the screened windows. "You should come to one of the block parties. You'll meet so many people you'll want to move away."

"I've tried, but have been traveling for most of them."

He took a seat on the same sofa as hers, resting an elbow on the back as they faced one another. Their feet were close enough to touch without

actually touching. Rose was glad she'd chosen to wear her high-heeled pumps today, and did her best to ignore the feeling of her skirt as it rode up her thighs.

"There's one in a few weeks, actually. Will you be in town then?"

"Will you be there?"

His question sent a shiver through Rose. "I was planning on it, yeah. I always go to these things. Oh, and you'll be happy to know, this one's at the pool."

"I'll make sure to block that day off, then. But on one condition."

Rose braced herself, the way she might if he were about to lean in and kiss her. Not that she's ever imagined that.

He never took his eyes off her, and she felt herself melt under the attention. "You wear that bikini."

Her explosive laugh surprised her. "Of course that's your condition. Men."

"So that's a no?" He grinned. The man was too charming for his own good.

"Maybe, maybe not. Or maybe I'll get a new bikini for this occasion."

She didn't miss the quick intake of breath, like someone had just touched the inside of his thigh. She wanted to giggle, but didn't want to destroy the leverage she suddenly had. She added, "Now you'll just have to come and see."

"Done. I'll be there." He finished off his glass of wine. Hers was empty. "Another?"

He stood, headed back for the bottle in the kitchen before she could answer.

"I really should probably get home," she said, but didn't move from the wicker patio sofa. Outside, birds chirped and the world kept on going. She checked her watch, surprised to see that she'd been here a half hour already.

Checking her skirt, she realized that it had ridden up enough that a bit of lace was peeking out on the bottom side of her thigh. Did Tyler notice? Embarrassment fueled the heat in her face, but also...excitement. She did adjust the skirt before he returned, but remained seated, and when he offered to pour her more wine, she held her glass up for him.

"So no girlfriend?" It was the wine asking.

"Like I said, I travel too much for anything like that." This time, when he sat, he was much closer to her, and when he put his elbow on the back of

the sofa, it felt more intimate. “Can’t do much long-term.”

“So is that why you’ve invited a married woman back to your place for a drink?”

“Ha. I thought this was just platonic.”

“Did you?” The air between them was thick.

He studied her before speaking. “Well, maybe I was hoping that I was wrong.”

This would have been the perfect time to kiss him. She could practically feel his lips—hot and moist, more pliant than his personality.

Instead, her smile took over—as did her blush. She looked down and away, her face bright.

“Why are you here, Rose?”

“Because I saw my husband watching us from the upstairs window and wanted to wind him up.” It was an honest answer. She didn’t know why Andy was home so early, but as soon as she saw his car parked out front, she looked for him. Saw him out of the corner of her eye before he ducked out of sight. When Tyler asked her for a drink a moment later, she went for it.

That was why. That’s what she told herself at the time. Now, a glass and a half of wine loosening her thinking, she admitted that it was more than that.

“It’s just the two of us, Rose. You can tell me anything.”

She glanced up, to see him leaning in, the hand sliding towards her along the back of the sofa. When he touched her knee with his other hand, that’s when things got real.

Until this moment, Tyler and what he stood for—a new man that she could use to tease Andy—was abstract. She had fantasies featuring Tyler, sure, but they were hazy and theoretical. Now, they became real. She knew what came next—he’d kiss her, he’d touch her, they’d get naked. This time, when she thought about sex with Tyler, she could practically feel the soft pillows on her bare butt and hear the creak of the wicker as Tyler added his weight to hers. He’d spread her legs and enter her and it would feel so hard and new and full.

“Rose, tell me what you really want.”

His hand slid up the outside of her thigh, slowly, deliberately, until it rested at the band of lace of her thigh-high. He didn’t seem surprised to discover it.

He had such beautiful eyes, and his own desire was real. “Tell me, Rose. Why are you really here?”

ANDY

Rose was home when he finally got back. Two hours had passed since he'd watched her walk off with that other man, so it made sense that she was home. Still, there was a cool and tingling part of him that was hoping she'd still be out.

With *him* .

He shook his head. No, don't go there, man.

"Hey, honey," Rose said, coming down the stairs. She wore a pair of cutoff jeans and a t-shirt, had a basket of laundry in her hands, and looked completely domestic. Except that her hair was wet, and when he kissed her, he could smell the soap of her very recent shower. "You smell like beer."

"I met up with Louis." And suddenly *that* conversation came flooding back. He felt like a pinball stuck between some bumpers. "You go to the pool?"

"No. Why do you ask?"

"You took a shower."

"Oh, right." She touched her damp hair. "I had to." She let the suggestion linger a moment before adding, "I was all covered in paint." She took another step down the stairs. "How's Louis doing?"

Andy considered changing the subject back again, asking her about her afternoon, about Tyler, about where she went. But the situation with Louis was so insane, he also wanted to talk about that.

"Louis is, uh..." Why did he feel so guilty, even though he had no part of their neighbor's scheme.

"Yes?"

“I think Louis may have gone too far this time.”

“Hm? How so?”

“He’s... um...”

“Obsessed?” Rose helped.

Andy’s laugh came out as mostly an incredulous sigh. “That’s a word for it.” Might as well just come out with it. “He’s spying on Jordan.”

Rose tilted her head to the side, her brows pinching together in confusion.

“He’s planted hidden cameras throughout their house.”

Now she got it. “That’s so...” Then, she got mad. “That asshole. This was his idea, and now he’s going to hold this over her to what? To get the kids? To call her out as a cheater.”

Andy reached out, tried to hug her, to soothe her. “Well, he’s an asshole, for sure. Anyone who’d do something like that without letting her know or something is pretty messed up. But I don’t think he’s doing it to get leverage on her. It’s more that he’s just... turned on by it.”

“Jesus.” She ran her hand through her damp hair. “We’ve got to tell her.”

Andy knew that they should, but also was in a bind. “He’ll know that I told you, and that you told her. I don’t think he’s shared this with anyone else.”

“So what, Andy? So he finds out you ratted him out. It’s better than him stalking her like that.” She glanced around, like Andy had planted cameras, too, and shivered. He could almost see her mind turn. Would he do that? He was, after all, exhibiting some of the same fantasies.

And he had come home to spy on her. Or catch her.

Shame overcame him. “You know I’d never, *ever* do that, right?” Things still felt tense, so he added, “I’d definitely ask for permission, first.”

Her eyes narrowed before she laughed. “How considerate of you.”

He put his arms around her, and this time she relaxed. “And it would only be so that I could watch you dress and undress when I’m not around.”

“Pervert.”

“Definitely not to watch you with some strange man.” He looked right at her. “Because I know you’d just go to his place anyway.”

“So that was you upstairs.”

He hadn’t intended to confess, but it just felt right. “I was home to finish up the paint project.” It was the lie he’d convinced himself was true. “So

where did you go, Rose?”

She batted her lashes. “I went over to Tyler’s. We were talking about wine, and he invited me over for a taste.”

A taste. That kind of sexual innuendo didn’t sound like Rose, and because it didn’t, it was even more exhilarating.

“And was it good?” Andy could hear the shakiness in his voice. It seemed to fuel Rose’s uncharacteristic confidence.

“I had fun,” she said, then pretended to catch herself. “Or were you talking about the wine?”

“So something more than wine happened?” But of course she wouldn’t do that.

“Are you asking if I did anything naughty?” She stepped closer, a hand on his heart. She could feel it race, and as she did, something seemed to occur to her. “You came home early hoping you’d see something going on.” Andy hesitated, and her eyes went wide. “You did!”

“No... I... I mean that’s silly. I trust you. I know you wouldn’t—”

She cut him off. “Mmm, it appears that we’ve both done something naughty.”

Both.

“What did you...?” It was hard to even ask it. “I never really thought you’d... with someone... else.” He felt like such a doofus, talking like this.

“But you like thinking that maybe, just maybe, I did.” She trailed the hand on his heart lower, over his stomach, down across his pants.

“Rose...” This wasn’t a game. If she’d done something, he wanted to know. But then again, maybe not.

“Andy...” she mimicked, then giggled. Her hand found his cock hard. “If you want to know the truth, I’ll tell you. You don’t need to plant secret cameras around our house, or come home early to catch me. All you have to do is ask.”

She stared at him, waiting on him, her hand stroking him through his jeans. Gone was the guilt she’d seemed to have earlier. It was now completely replaced by confidence. She was in total control.

Andy couldn’t ask. He didn’t want to know—not one way or another. Chances were, nothing happened. That came with its own disappointment. If something did, though, how would he handle that, either?

”And if you want to stop this game, I’ll do that, too.” She sank to her knees. “But you’re going to have to ask for that, too.”

Andy's breathe caught as she opened his zipper. He was so hard that Rose had to pull his pants down his thighs just to get access to it. When she did, she immediately took it into her mouth.

She'd always been so up for it when they were first together, and recently, she was up for it more and more. Was she like that this afternoon? They were two consenting adults who wanted it, even though it was against the rules. Rose had done it once. It was easy to imagine she could do it again.

That thought, along with Rose's wet mouth along his length, was nearly enough to make him lose it. After less than thirty seconds. Somehow, he managed to avoid that embarrassment.

Not that he'd be able to hold off much longer. Not with his wife on her knees, her mysteriously wet hair bouncing with each gulp of his cock.

Her eyes were closed, seemingly lost in the feeling of his erection. Or maybe comparing it to their neighbor's. Or maybe wishing he *were* her neighbor right then.

"Rose," he warned, pushing her away before he lost it. She let go with her mouth, but continued to pump with her hand.

"You're so hard." Now she was looking at him. Now she was seeing into him. She wasn't judging, but suddenly Andy was judging himself. What kind of man was he, to want that? What kind of husband?

He pulled her to her feet, grabbing her, pulling her close. Her kiss was warm and briny from her blowjob. Her skin burned beneath her shirt as he lifted it off. She wore a bra beneath, white and sensible. He pulled the cups down, kissing her nipples as she gasped and grasped his cock again, pumping it.

"I need this," she hissed. He heard the desperation in her statement, felt it in the way she squeezed him. They were beyond teasing. They were acting on pure, animal instinct.

Andy pulled her cutoffs down, taking her panties with it. She was slick, her pussy easily accepting his fingers as he ran them across those smooth, plump lips. They were still in the entrance of their townhome, still on the split level landing. He sat her back on the step, leading up to the main level, as he got in between her legs.

He sank into her with one, easy thrust. She was so wet. So ready. He wondered if that was Tyler. As she moaned and cupped the back of his neck,

he wondered if Tyler had already been there, fucking her, sampling her married pussy.

“Yes, fuck me, honey,” she begged. Her grip on the nape of his neck tightened. She’d used the F-word, and it barely registered for Andy. “That’s it. That’s it. Give it to me.”

He grabbed her ass, squeezing her cheeks as he thrust into her. Burying his face in her hair, the images came, the fantasy overwhelmed. Rose was with Tyler, in this same spot, only in *his* townhome, on *his* landing. They’d done it before, in his fantasy. They’d been fucking for weeks, and even still, they couldn’t get enough of one another. They couldn’t even wait to get somewhere more comfortable before getting it on. Maybe she’d teased him with her stockings on the bus. Maybe she’d told him how she couldn’t wait to feel his cock inside her again.

“That’s it, baby,” Rose cried. “Give it to me. Come, honey. Oh, please, please, come!”

Andy grunted, burying his face into the crook of her neck. He wanted to sink his teeth into her. Instead, he squeezed her ass cheek, lifting her to him as he ground his hips into her pussy and yielded to her.

As he did, as his balls tightened and his shaft throbbed inside of his wife, he imagined Tyler’s doing the same. He imagined Rose’s fingernails biting into Tyler’s neck the way they did now, or Rose’s thighs closing around Tyler’s back. He imagined Rose crying out as another man filled her with his come.

Spent, he pushed off of her, realizing that somewhere along the way, he’d developed rug burn on his knees from their carpeted stairs. When Rose stood and gathered her things, he noticed the striped burns on her back.

She gathered her things, pausing to smile at him. Here’s where he expected some reassurance that it was all a tease—that she really hadn’t gone to Tyler’s house, and there was some other explanation as to why she walked off. But it didn’t come. Instead, on her way up the steps, she just said, “So come on, let me show you the rooms I finished while you were out drinking.”

When she looked behind her, the mischievous look on her face told him that she knew exactly what she was doing. She wasn’t going to tell him a thing unless he asked, and she knew that he wasn’t going to ask.

ROSE

Despite the wine headache the next morning, Rose forced herself to get up early. She needed some alone time so she could unpack some of the craziness that had built up in the corners of her mind over the past twenty-four hours.

First, there was Louis and his amateur video surveillance. Despite the seriousness of the transgression, it was the easiest for her to think about because it was removed enough from her own situation. She needed to tell Jordan about that, somehow, and soon. It was so messed up. Even the thought of Andy doing something like that turned her body cold—and not in the good way that some other recent events had.

She skirted away from *that* momentarily to consider her friend, Jordan, who was now apparently fucking this other man, Jayden, in her own home. She'd certainly come a long way from the woman who'd "never do such a thing" to hookups during the day and booty calls on the way home. Could that be her own trajectory?

Rose got in under the water, turning it up until it scalded. That led her to Andy, and their own home situation. She'd dropped a trail of breadcrumbs that led to a very obvious conclusion, then asked him if he wanted to know the truth. It turned him on, without a doubt. He was thinking about it, no question. Be he never asked.

Because he didn't want to know.

Because for Andy, the ignorance was part of the excitement.

It just so happened to line up with her own wants and desires. Every part of this felt wrong, the way shoplifting or smoking a cigarette—or

fucking your TA during office hours—felt wrong. Walking off with Tyler was a bad idea. Taking that second glass of wine was definitely a bad idea. Leading a man like him on was the *worst* idea.

She picked up her razor and shaved her legs, delighting in the sensation of her hands working over her thighs. She thought of Tyler yesterday, and how he'd found her thigh-highs. How she hadn't pushed him away.

It was thrilling. All of it. She couldn't deny it. Not with her pussy quivering at the memory. This was fun, and could be a *lot* more fun if she wanted it to be. Tyler was definitely game. Andy seemed to be, as well.

She lathered her pussy before swapping out the razor heads. She wanted to be nice and smooth. She shaved away her nearly non-existent stubble, making sure she was completely, wickedly, secretively smooth.

Because today could be the day that Tyler discovered that she was. He almost had yesterday. Somehow she'd found the will to resist.

'Why are you really here?' he'd asked.

She'd stared at his lips, at his mouth, at the way his nostrils flared with each deep breath. She remembered thinking, *He's nervous, too.* And then, *I make him nervous!*

It had helped her find the confidence to hold up the wine glass and say, *'For the wine, which is now empty.'*

She'd put a hand on his shoulder, squeezing it as she stood. He didn't try and stop her. He didn't grow sullen. If anything, the man was patient. He'd just said, *'There's plenty more where that came from. Aisle 4, about two thirds of the way down on the left.'*

Rose got dressed in the dark, but knew that Andy had woken up at some point and was pretending to sleep. She'd intended to wear something modest—slacks and a short-sleeved blouse. Feeling her husband's attention on her, though, she couldn't help herself.

She dropped her towel on the floor, her naked back to him, as she fished a few items from her lingerie drawer—new items she'd recently purchased to tease her poor husband. In the dark, it was tricky to figure out whether she was stepping into the garter belt correctly, but when she heard the stifled gasp from the bed, she persevered.

Rose liked lingerie, but garter belts and stockings always struck her as more trouble than they were worth. There was a reason why they'd been replaced by pantyhose, which left no lines or bumps, offered more support, and were not so fiddly. But even Rose could agree that pantyhose were not

sexy in the way that a lacy, black garter belt, clipped into a pair of black, silk stockings, was. She turned, making sure that her “sleeping” husband saw how the garters framed her bare pussy, before stepping into a matching thong. Her bra matched as well, a demi-bra constructed mostly of black lace that lifted her breasts and gave her more cleavage than usual.

Not that the dress she’d picked would show any of it off. It was modest—sleeveless, dark green, snug without being tight. That wasn’t the point of her choice. Like their marriage, it was the hidden, unspoken secrets beneath the dress that were exhilarating.

She didn’t kiss him goodbye, pretending, like he was, that he was asleep. Instead, she tiptoed out of the room, out of their quiet house, and out to the bus stop. It was early enough that Tyler wasn’t there.

Which wasn’t why she’d left so early.

So she told herself.

That wasn’t the reason at all.

ANDY

Thursday, around lunchtime Rose texted him.
[Rose]: I'll be home a little late. Happy hour.

Andy read the text again and again, and each time, it prickled, like that nauseating feeling that came at the very beginning of the flu. Things weren't quite right. This text was...off.

Or maybe that was just where his head was at. It had been there all day, dwelling on whether something was really going on or not. He'd certainly seen her leave with Tyler, but for all he knew, she was checking on something just down the street and came right back. He'd watched her get dressed, watched her put on a garter belt that he'd never dreamed of seeing her wear before. Was that a tease? She'd left so early, there was no guarantee that he'd even see her, so maybe it wasn't for him. Gah!

[Andy]: Sounds great, honey. Have fun!

[Rose]: Don't worry. I plan on it. ;-)

That's the thing. With a suggestive response like that, she had to know what she was doing. Thus she had to be messing with him. It was awesome. It was also maddening.

'I'll tell you the truth. All you have to do is ask.' She'd said that. He didn't ask, so all this angst was on him.

He got home, and sure enough, Rose was out, with no sign that she'd been there. The mail was still sitting on the floor beside the mail slot. Her bag wasn't on the credenza just inside the living room. It even smelled empty. The kids gone at camp didn't help.

Wandering into the kitchen, he opened the fridge in search of leftovers, then promptly forgot all about why he'd opened it at all. Rose was out there. He should be, too.

[Andy]: Where are you? Maybe I'll join you.

Remarkably, he hesitated before pressing it. Even that came with baggage. If she was keen on it and sent him an address, then his wild imagination would be shut down. If she made up some excuse as to why he couldn't join them, well that was not good, either, for a whole other set of reasons.

Instead, she just didn't respond. Seconds turned into minutes turned into an hour.

[Andy]: Guess your phone's in your purse. I'm going to grab some Chipotle.

Her phone was in her purse alright, which was strewn on the floor of Tyler's bedroom as he held her by the garter straps and fucked her from behind.

He waited another five minutes before grabbing his keys and heading for the door. Rose's Uber was just pulling up when he stepped out into the summer evening.

"Oh, you headed out somewhere?" she asked.

Andy stopped at the top of their stoop, staring down at her. "I texted you."

"Oh?" She retrieved her phone from her purse, as if she didn't believe him. "Oh, looks like my phone's dead."

He watched her carefully. She didn't seem unsteady or glassy-eyed, despite being at a happy hour that lasted until nearly nine o'clock. She did

have a sway in her step, but it was more a spunky one, a sexual gait that went along with her crooked smile.

“I was wondering...” Now it sounded lame, telling her that he wanted to meet up. “I’m going to grab a burrito. Want to join me?”

“I’m good. We had one of those insanely huge plates of nachos along with a bunch of other junk food that I know I’m going to regret in the morning.” They met on the short walk up to their front door, and when she kissed him, it was chaste and familiar. “And I don’t think I can stand another minute in these heels.”

He looked down to see that the heels she wore were tall and very un-Rose-like. Being a tall woman already, Rose tended to stay away from anything more than a kitten heel, but these were full on stilettos.

“Those are new?”

“These old things?” She kicked her feet up. “Actually, I’m borrowing them from Jordan. Turns out, we wear the same size. Funny, isn’t it?”

They were sharing shoes now?

“See you when you get back. Love you, Andy!” With that, she was inside.

Andy didn’t immediately get into his own car. He stood there, rooted to the spot, staring at his own closed front door. He almost followed her in. Even in that brief kiss, he could sense that there was so much more.

But he was hungry, and because it was late and he was confused, that hunger was turning to “hanger,” as Rose called it—usually in relation to the kids. So he got in his car, went to Chipotle, and ate his ill-considered burrito as fast as he could.

By the time he got home, not only did his stomach hate him, but Rose was passed out, dead to the world.

[Louis]: OMG. OMG!

IT WAS FRIDAY AFTERNOON. Andy was at work, but as usual, was busy thinking—fantasizing—about what Rose could be up to. It was Casual Friday, but even still, Rose had squeezed into the tightest jeans that she

owned, and paired it with a sleeveless black t-shirt that he knew had the habit of flashing her bra strap. Which was a flirty, bright turquoise.

Andy looked at his phone again, where Louis's wild OMGs glared up at him.

[Louis]: You alone? Because this next thing is very NSFW.

The man didn't even wait for a reply. The image came in right after, and with it, a spike of adrenaline into Andy's bloodstream. He *wasn't* alone. He was, in fact, in the middle of a meeting where he should not be checking his phone at all.

Thankfully, the photo that slid into view in the message screen was innocent enough—a picture of a bed that Andy now knew was Louis and Jordan's. It was the opaque, white play button smack in the middle of the image that got to Andy. This was a video, and it wasn't likely that the bed would remain empty for long.

Andy set the phone down on its face, thought better of it a moment later, and shoved it into his pocket, where it remained, taunting him with each buzzing alert for the rest of the meeting.

Only when he got back to his office and could close the door did he look.

[Louis]: This was yesterday, during the day again.

[Louis]: I don't know who the other woman.

[Louis]: You watch it yet?

Andy should not watch that video. Not at work. Probably not at all. Louis shouldn't be recording his wife, and watching the video made him complicit in the crime. Yet when he set foot in his office, Andy found himself locking the door and fishing out his headphones. His heart rattled in his chest. He was overheated.

He hit play.

First thing he heard was Jordan's laughter, husky and womanly. She stepped into the frame, leading a woman by the hand. "*You want a show, do*

you?” Jordan turned to the woman, a skinny brunette in her twenties. *“Shall we give them a show, Britney?”*

Britney reminded him of a younger Rose, before kids. She was tall and slender, her long, coltish legs on full display in her cheerleader shorts, but she lacked the curves that his wife had developed over the years. She also had this look that she was up to no good—a mischief that didn’t come naturally to Rose.

Not until lately, anyway.

Britney turned up to Jordan, setting a hand on the blonde’s hip as she tilted her head and leaned in. Like she was going to kiss the other woman. *“I love giving shows,”* she said. Her smile was dangerous. *“But your boyfriend has to get naked first.”*

Jordan looked off-camera. *“You heard her. Show her what you’ve got, Jay.”*

Andy recognized the black man who stepped on to the screen from the video before, dark and lean and too handsome for his own good—Jayden, Jordan’s lover. He set a knee on the bed, on the opposite side that the women were on, and peeled his tight t-shirt off.

They turned to watch as he unbuckled his pants. Andy couldn’t stop himself from looking, too. Jayden had muscles in places that Andy didn’t realize you could have muscles. His abs rippled like a breeze across dark water, and his chest glistened, swelling thick and broad and hairless.

His cock, like the rest of him, seemed too large to be real. It hung, dark and thick, between his thighs, stiffening up as he grinned at the two women. Britney slid her hand into Jordan’s jean cut-offs and whispered something into the blonde’s ear. Jordan nodded with a giggle.

“There it is, ladies,” Jayden said. *“Now for my show.”*

The women turned toward one another, returning to that close, intimate embrace. This time, as their lips inched closer to one another, they didn’t stop. Jordan rested a hand on Britney’s hip, dragging her tight shorts down enough to uncover the narrow strap of her thong.

Their lips touched, parting. Even on the small screen of Andy’s phone, he caught the flash of their tongues as they passed one another. The kiss deepened. Their hands began tugging at their clothes.

Britney was sexy in her youthfulness—tall, slim, with small, high breasts and narrow hips—but Jordan was sexier in Andy’s eyes. She possessed the glow of maturity that couldn’t be matched. He loved her

wider hips, her fuller breasts. Andy was always impressed by her confidence, and even standing next to a woman in her prime, she owned it.

"Down you go, girl," she told Britney, her hands on the taller woman's shoulders.

Britney kissed her one more time before sinking down to her knees. Jordan sat on the edge of the bed, hooked her thumbs in her thong, and slipped it off. Andy caught a flash of Jordan's landing strip, a narrow band of light brown hair, before she pulled Britney's head into her lap. She glanced back at Jayden as if to ask, *"This what you wanted to see?"*

"Mmm, that feels so good, baby," Jordan said instead. *"She eats pussy so well."*

Jayden climbed up onto the bed, walking on his knees. His cock was hard, fully erect and impossibly large. Andy had seen it before, dipping in and out of Jordan. It looked even larger now, fully unsheathed.

"So this isn't your first time she's done this to you?" Jayden asked, *grabbing his cock in his hand.*

"What can I say? I'm a hot-blooded bisexual woman with a husband who can't satisfy me." Andy flinched at Jordan's words. *"You should see what we can do with Britney's double-headed dildo."*

"You ladies don't need a dildo when you've got the real deal."

Jayden sat up onto his knees and fed Jordan his big, black cock. She twisted to take it as Britney lapped faster between her legs. Despite having never seen two women actually play around like that, Andy found himself watching Jordan suck her lover's cock more than anything on that screen.

She gagged on all that meat, her face turning red as he passed back into her throat. He shoved deeper, tormenting her before pulling back to let her catch her breath. But only just enough. He shoved back into her again, holding her by her blond hair so he could look down at her.

"Fuck, I'm so close," Jordan said after Jayden let her gasp and sputter.

"You wanted to know what it felt like to be totally overwhelmed?" He pinned her down to the bed, straddled her face, and forced his cock down her throat. *"To be totally strung out on sex, I think you said?"* He gripped her blond hair. *"Well, there's no time like the present."*

She gagged and choked as he fucked her throat. Her face was red. Her brow a furrowed, sweaty mess. Her nostrils flared. And she was totally, 100% into it.

“Next time, we invite Lenny over and we fill you up. I’ll fuck your ass. You suck his cock. And Britney, babe, you ever use a strap on?”

“Mmm, it’s one of my favorite toys.”

“Atta girl. Now let’s make this whore scream.”

Britney smiled wickedly up at the black man before lowering her face back to Jordan’s pussy. Together, they practically suffocated Jordan on the sex and the orgasm. She came hard, groaning around the meat shoved into her face. Only when she started to turn purple did Jayden pull out.

He didn’t give her much time to relax, though. He dragged her onto the bed, flipped her over, and lifted her hips. Pointing to the head of the bed, he directed Britney there. “Time to thank your friend for such a happy orgasm,” he said. “I know how good that mouth is on a cock. Let’s see what it can do to a pussy.”

Bridget stripped out of her panties, spreading her completely bare pussy for the blonde.

Andy had just about forgotten that this was a video on his phone when the alert slid into view. A new text message.

[Louis]: Holy shit. Holy shit! I watched some more stuff and there’s a REALLY interesting conversation on there between Jordan and your wife.

[Louis]: You’ll want to watch this.

[Louis]: And...

[Louis]: I’m sorry. Or maybe congratulations?

It was like getting pummeled, one blow after the other. Andy’s abdomen tightened and he started to see stars before realizing that he was holding his breath.

A new video came through, the still frame showing Rose sitting in Jordan’s kitchen, staring nervously at her neighbor.

It all felt like whiplash.

He clicked play.

“I need to tell you something.”

Rose looked terrified, and watching that, Andy felt terrified right along with her.

“What is it?” When Rose didn’t answer immediately, Jordan reached out and put a hand on hers. After so recently watching this same blonde going down on another woman, Andy wondered if that’s where this conversation was going. “You can tell me, Rose. Lord knows how much I’ve confided in you.”

“*Okay.*” Rose took a deep breath, and Andy did right along with her.
“*You can’t tell anyone about this.*”

“*Of course.*”

“*Not even Louis, okay?*”

Jordan snorted. “*Not a problem there.*”

“*Okay.*” One more breath. Andy still hadn’t released the last one.
“*Okay, so... I’m... I’m having an affair.*”

ROSE

“I’m having an affair.” The word settled into her like a ball of ice, sinking, sinking, then melted away in the heat that inevitably followed.

“You?!” Jordan looked bewildered, as if she hadn’t been doing it all along. The blonde covered her mouth and stared at her wide-eyed. “Really?”

“Yes, really. And will you keep it down?”

“Lillian is watching her afternoon shows. We’re fine.” She stood and crossed over to the fridge. “But I’m going to need a drink here.”

She pulled out a bottle of white wine and poured them both a glass.

“No, I can’t,” Rose said. “This is part of what got me into trouble.”

Jordan raised a brow. “Okay, so spill it. You’ve heard all about my situation.”

Back when Rose was sneaking around with Andy, she’d been too terrified to tell anyone. She didn’t want to get him fired, but more than that, she was worried what others would think of her, and she certainly didn’t have any friends who’d understand.

Having Jordan to talk to about this was like a huge weight lifted from her shoulders. She’d been bottling up so much since the summer began—not just Tyler, but whatever was going on between her and Andy and how she kept leading him on.

“So there’s a guy—”

“The guy from the pool?”

“Tyler. Yeah.” Just saying his name made her feel giddy. “We’ve been flirty for a while. He lives on Grove, and, um, Tuesday, I guess, he invited me over there for an, um, a drink.”

The temperature rose and rose with each uttered word.

“A drink,” Jordan stated with a knowing smile. “You don’t really think that’s all he had in mind, do you? I’ve seen how he looks at you.” She drank from her wine, even if Rose wasn’t. “Or how you look at him.”

“Jordan, I never intended for anything to happen—”

“Please. That’s bullshit and you know it. You can try and fool yourself, but remember who you’re talking to. I’m your slutty neighbor.” She flashed a saccharine smile. “You went over there to fuck him.”

Rose almost laughed. Jordan’s straight-forwardness was refreshing.

“You did fuck him, right?”

Rose’s face started to light up. “Give me that wine.”

Jordan scooted the wine toward her, but didn’t look away. She wanted an answer, and wouldn’t be satisfied until she got one.

“Not right away.”

Jordan released a frustrated harrumph. “I’m not Andy. You don’t need to be all opaque. Just tell me.”

“Yes, I fucked him.” She felt woozy, like she’d downed back to back tequila shots and they were hitting her all at once. “Once on Tuesday, and then again last night.”

“Two days in a row?! Now you’re sounding like me.”

“Shh.” It was crazy how flustered she felt. “He wanted to get a drink. So I told Andy I had a happy hour, and we ended up in a hotel room.” She covered her face. “Oh, my God, I don’t know what I’m doing.”

“Sounds like you have a pretty good idea!”

“Jordan!”

“I’m sorry, I’m sorry.”

“I love Andy. I love our family.”

“But Tyler is new and exciting, and you’ve got a wild side hidden under there, Rose.”

A wild side that enjoys teasing Andy, she didn’t say—she *couldn’t say*, under these circumstances.

“He have a big cock?” Jordan asked. It was half a joke.

“Oh yeah. It’s big.”

“Mmm. Let me know if and when you’re done with him.”

“I should be done after last night. I should have been done before any of this ever started.”

“But you’re not, are you?” Jordan asked with a twinkle in her eye. “You’re seeing him again.”

She couldn’t look Jordan in the eyes when she said this next part. So she didn’t. “Tomorrow. We’re meeting at lunchtime at the Onyx.”

“That’s a—”

“Boutique hotel. I know.” She finally stole a look at her friend. The smile was infectious.

“Well, your secret’s safe with me.”

ANDY

It was half past one when he shut the video down. His stomach growled at him. He'd graduated beyond the vague feeling of being sick, to actually feeling sick.

Disoriented, he realized that the video was from yesterday. Meaning the lunchtime tryst was today. Was happening at that very moment.

He didn't have a plan. He didn't even tell anyone that he was leaving. He just left the building, hailed a cab, and instructed it to head to the Onyx. It was a miracle that he remembered his wallet.

The Onyx was a small hotel in a trendy spot downtown. True to its name, glossy black stone featured a prominent role in the interior decoration of the hotel. There was a bar on the ground floor with a view of the lobby—and the elevators beyond. He parked himself at the bar, ordered a beer, and waited.

All of his focus was on the lobby. He couldn't tell you how many people were in the bar, or even whether the bartender was a man or a woman. He worried that if he took his eyes off the lobby for a moment, he'd miss his wife—and possibly her lover. He worried that he'd missed them already.

It never should have gotten this far. This was all meant to be a fantasy. That's what he wanted, right? Not this? Not an actual affair.

Even thinking the word felt acidic. He recoiled. He felt bile in the back of his throat and anger at his wife that she could do this. That she *would* do this.

You bear some of this blame yourself, Buddy. The voice was there, spoken in the same tone that he used when talking to Louis. He'd remained quiet for too long, and he'd implied that this was fine. It wasn't fine. Right?

Just as the doubt really hit him, she was there—Rose, wearing the same tight jeans and cold-shouldered top. She wore boots with those jeans, ankle high and tall. Sexy. She walked with carefree confidence, oblivious to her surroundings, a distant, satisfied look on her face.

He leaned in harder, his heart hammering in his chest as his eyes studied her, searching for more evidence of her affair.

Searching and *finding* it in the sheen covering her skin and the way her hair looked slightly damp, mussed, like she'd spent her lunch break on a treadmill and run out of time to shower.

As if to emphasize that, she checked her watch just as she reached the door, cursed under her breath, and was gone.

Andy left the hotel in a daze. He didn't remember much. Didn't remember settling the bill. Didn't remember going out and catching a cab back to work. He didn't even remember leaving work, although there was no way he would have done much had he stayed.

One moment, he was staring at the doors and seeing the hazy impression of his just-fucked wife burn on his brain like a sun spot. The next, he was home, his mind splintering between horror and...arousal. Extreme, visceral, boundless arousal. The two wound him up like a paradox. They could not both be true.

The next few hours passed in a blur. Andy had no idea what he did, but the next thing he knew, he was watching Rose walk down the sidewalk with Tyler at her side. She was laughing at something he was telling her, and it drove an icicle through him.

He raged. He grinded his teeth. His gums hurt.

And he got so instantly hard that he had to adjust himself.

"This is fucked up," he muttered, fists clenched like he was ready to hit something.

Rose and Tyler paused in front of their home. She glanced at Andy's car, parked there, then up at the bedroom windows. This time, he didn't duck away—refused to look away. Their eyes met.

Knowing she was being watched, she put a hand on Tyler's shoulder and squeezed before saying goodbye and springing up the steps to their front door.

He waited for her in their bedroom, listened to her climbing the steps. He situated himself at the windowsill, arms crossed, looking stern, only to end up feeling stupid and abandoning it. By the time she walked in, he was just standing there awkwardly.

Still, the vitriol was still there. “I’m surprised you didn’t go to Tyler’s. For wine.”

Rose didn’t flinch, and she certainly didn’t back down. She approached him with the kind of command that she didn’t have a right to. “Somebody sounds jealous.”

“Not jealous.” Even to his own ears, he sounded like a child.

Rose floated close, an eyebrow lifted. “Then what, Andy? Curious?”

She didn’t seem upset. More curious herself. This close, he studied her. She didn’t look any different than any other day. She wasn’t wearing any extra amount of makeup, like she’d touched it up before coming home. Her hair, similarly, had seen a day’s worth of muss—although maybe it was a little more out of place after her encounter at the Onyx.

He could smell her sweat beneath her natural scent. It was a hot day, but he knew that wasn’t the only reason she smelled that way. Was that another man’s musk, too? An unfamiliar cologne?

She watched as he processed it, her smile seemingly growing wider and wider. When he didn’t say anything, she said, “Okay, I’m going to take a shower. Hot out there.”

Andy stopped her before she could turn away. “Did he ask you over?”

She paused, taking her sweet time before answering. “Not today, no.”

‘Because he already fucked me all afternoon.’ She didn’t need to say it. He heard it anyway.

He kissed her, more on animal instinct than anything thoughtful. The order hadn’t come from a thoughtful place. This wasn’t an *‘I love you’* kind of kiss. It was pure. Raw. Inflamed. And not just on Andy’s end. When he kissed her, Rose kissed back, hard and ready and almost combative.

She was having an affair. She’d met a guy in a hotel room that very afternoon and done God knew what with him. Blown him, certainly. Fucked him, without a doubt. But how did he fuck her? How did it look? How did she sound, screaming his name as she came?

He reached for the bottom of her blouse when she put up some resistance. “I need to take a shower. I’m all dirty.”

She didn't want him to discover the evidence against her, which made Andy want to explore her more.

"I don't care," he practically growled. Tugging her shirt free, he dropped to his knees and worked on her tight jeans.

"Andy..."

He yanked them down. Beneath, he could smell her excitement. Her thong was already wet. He pushed her back onto the credenza by the window. The picture frames rattled.

"Something's got you excited," he said, because talking like he was some kind of horny narrator felt safer than acknowledging what he might find—another man's come in his wife's pussy. And if he did find that, what would he do? Even with his fantasy, going down on her like that—a cream pie—was too far. For him.

With his stomach crawling up his throat, he peeled her thong down her thighs. There wasn't any immediate signs of her infidelity, although she was engorged, her pussy blossoming.

He dipped forward, running his tongue along her slit. She tasted like herself, tangy, slightly musky, slightly spicy. But for one, small and very out-of-place flavor—the astringent, latex taste of a condom.

He should he recoiled. A part of him did. The rest of him, the part in control, went wild. He shoved her thighs open wider so he could get greater access to her shaved, cheating pussy. He ran his thumb across her clit as he pushed his tongue deep, searching—and finding—more of that incriminating taste.

"Oh, my—" Rose was lost above him. She grabbed his hair, clenched, then quickly released. "Oh... oh—YES!"

Had Tyler done this earlier that afternoon? Had he buried his face between his wife's taut thighs, grabbed her firm buttocks, and feasted on her juicy sex like a ripe peach? Or was there no foreplay between them anymore? Did she just drop her jeans, open her legs, and take his latex-sheathed cock.

'He have a big cock?'

'Oh yeah. It's big.'

"Andy, it's too much! Too... ha... too much!"

He was so out of it that he didn't even realize he'd made her come. He didn't hear the full extent of her cries. He couldn't distinguish what was in

his head versus right in front of him. Her pleas didn't do anything to shake him out of it, either.

'Yes, I fucked him... Once on Tuesday, and then again last night.' And one more time, today. Or maybe more times today. How many? Had she fucked him, then blown him, then fucked him again?

"Oh, Andy!" Rose gasped. He didn't remember standing. He couldn't remember lifting her ass onto the edge of the credenza, grabbing her ass, and ramming his steely hard cock into her. The world was a haze of red, with shadows playing across the lens like figures too close to his face to come into focus.

'He wanted to get a drink. So I told Andy I had a happy hour, and we ended up in a hotel room.'

Two hotel rooms. How many more would there be? How long would her affair last?

"That's it, that's it," Rose said. "Oh, you're so... so hard!"

In his head, in his ear, he didn't know. He kept pounding. Pictures crashed to the floor. The credenza hammered the wall, creaking, groaning. He slapped the wall behind them, smearing a sweaty imprint of his hand along the beige paint. He was close. So close.

He should have been disgusted. His first reaction should have been to yell and scream. Instead, all he wanted to do was fuck her until she clawed his back and screamed his name.

Rose didn't disappoint. She didn't dig her nails in, but she held onto his neck and grabbed the lip of the table, lifting her hips up to meet each thrust. Her body felt fantastic, soft and smooth in all the right ways, but powerful as well, coiled and tense and active. His cock dipped in and out of her tight embrace that maybe wasn't as tight as it had been.

'I'm having an affair,' she'd confessed. An affair. An *affair!*

"Come for me, baby" Rose gasped. "I need to feel it. I need to feel your come inside of me."

I need you to reclaim me, he heard.

He practically lifted her off the table. His abs burned. His arms screamed and strained. A picture frame crashed to the ground, the glass shattering. Neither of them noticed. Both were lost in the sex, in the passion.

"Yes, Rose. Take it. Take. It!"

He rammed forward, his balls clapping her ass. Sweat dripped down his neck. He sank in, as deep as he could go, and exploded in a flash. Rose was there, too, her nails sinking at last into the nape of his neck as she buried her face into his chest and groaned.

It was intense and hardcore and beautiful. He didn't want it to end. He didn't want to face the reality of what came next. Did he tell her that he knew? Would she confess what she'd done?

"Wow, that was something," Rose said, out of breath.

Andy crouched down, picking up the broken frame. He half expected that it was their wedding photo, its broken glass a sign of the state of their marriage. Instead, it was his favorite photo of Rose, back before they were a couple. It was a close up, taken during the winter, with snow dappling her auburn hair. She was squinting at the camera, like she has a secret that she was still contemplating sharing. That photo felt equally poignant in the moment.

"I can fix this," he said. Rather than, you know, say anything meaningful about the moment at hand. He'd just fucked her harder than they'd ever fucked in the last half decade, and now he didn't want to talk about it.

She studied him sharply, the look on her face nearly identical to the one in the broken photo. This was his moment. "*I know*," is all that he needed to say to stop this deadly spiral.

But the orgasm had cooled the passion that had boiled his blood a moment before. The edge was gone and he felt the moment pass. He pieced the broken picture frame together and stood.

Rose had hopped up onto the credenza, her hands curled around the edge of it. She looked casual, relaxed, like she was just hanging out—if she had clothes on. He forced a smile and turned to go when she stopped him.

"So we're not going to talk about it?"

He froze. If a man could become a block of ice in an instant, Andy was that man. He didn't even want to look up at her, and he couldn't ask the single word question that screamed through his mind—"what?"

Rose spoke first. "I think we need to talk about it." When he did look at her, it wasn't shame there. It was a queer curiosity. Like she barely dared to believe her own words. "I know you were in the lobby today, at the Onyx."

"You...know?" He thawed under the rush of blood, hot and guilty and shameful. But why should he feel shame? He wasn't the one cheating—

“I do. But what I can’t quite figure out is you.” She tilted her head at Andy. “You think I’m cheating on you, but you don’t say anything about it. You haven’t tried to stop me. Why not?”

“Would it have mattered?” Anger was easy to muster, although as he spat the question out, it sounded disingenuous, even to his own ears. Still, stubbornly, he pressed on. “You’ve already fucked him like what? Three times?”

Three times in another man’s arms.

Three times with another man’s cock sliding in and out of her.

Three times screaming as another man made her scream.

“You’re getting hard again.” Rose didn’t say it cruelly or incredulously. It wasn’t a question, but there was curiosity there.

Andy ran his fingers through his hair. They came away damp. “Look, yes, fine. It turns me on. But—”

“What does?”

“Hm?”

“What, specifically, turns you on? The fact that you think I’m cheating? Or just the idea of me being with another man in general.”

They were beyond the denials that he wasn’t turned on. This question, though, was at the heart of Andy’s confusion. He stared at her, wanting to give her a good answer. A strong answer. But the truth was, he didn’t have one.

“Forget it,” he said, turning away. “What difference does it make now —”

She was there, behind him, wrapping a hand around his waist before he could take a step towards... towards wherever he was going. With her lips right against his ear, she said, “I haven’t had sex with him.”

Andy stiffened. “What?”

“Nothing’s happened between us.” She turned him to look into her warm, brown eyes. “Well, other than some flirting.”

“But I saw you...”

“Leave the hotel? And yet you didn’t see Jordan there at the bar, watching you. She said you were so focused on the elevators that she worried security would kick you out.”

“Louis shared a video, where you admitted... to...” Now he wasn’t so sure. “You knew that you were being recorded.”

Rose smiled, happy to see he was finally following along. “Why would I confess my sins in a room where I knew there were cameras?”

Andy felt dizzy. He sat down on the edge of the bed. Rose sat beside him. “But how did you know that Louis would tell me about it?”

“Because Jordan told him that if he didn’t, she wouldn’t share any more videos of her fucking Jayden.”

So Jordan not only knew about the video camera, but was now using them against her husband? “That’s, um... this is a lot.”

“Nevermind about those two. What we need to talk about is us. And Andy, I’m not cheating on you. I would *never* cheat on you...”

Andy heard the ellipses in that statement. There was more. “Unless?”

Her smile was devious. “Unless we talked about it, and we were okay with it. So tell me, Andy, what part turns you on? The idea of an affair? Or the idea of me being with another man in general?”

Andy felt naked and exposed as the honest answer began to form. Would she think he was pathetic? Would she think he wasn’t the man she needed in his life, if he told her? She squeezed his knee, and he realized that if he couldn’t be honest with Rose, his partner, his love, his heart, then he couldn’t be honest with himself.

“Honestly? I think a little of both.” Blood brightened and bloomed in his face, growing hotter under Rose’s intense gaze. “I liked that you had secrets. It turned me on that you could be this naughty.”

“Still full of surprises?” Rose asked.

“Something like that.” He sorted through the mess of his thoughts. “But I also didn’t want to know, because deep down, I don’t think I really wanted you to be...” His heart constricted. He looked away, then back again. “...the kind of person who... could...”

“Have an affair with another man behind your back.” Her eyes didn’t waver, and they had to have picked up on his own flaring reaction. “Oh, Andy. I’m not that kind of person.”

“I know,” he started to say when he saw his wife’s eyes shift. His gut shifted right along with it. “But?”

She swallowed, then nodded as if working through her own inner dialog. “Since we’re being honest here...” She took a deep breath. “While I would never, *ever* cheat on you, I have to admit that all the... flirting and teasing... Well, it was pretty exciting.”

“Flirting with Tyler?”

She hesitated for only a moment. “Yeah.”

“Did anything happen between you two?” He wasn’t sure what answer he wanted, but he realized as he asked it was that he wanted an honest, straight one.

“Nothing too bad.”

Thud.

“Tuesday, when I went over to his place, while we were talking and flirting, he touched my leg.”

“Your leg?”

She put a hand on Andy’s knee, then slowly moved it up the inside of his thigh. “Like this.”

Andy’s turn to gulp. “How high?”

“I stopped him when he reached the top of my stockings.”

“Whoa, that’s high.”

“Too high. I’m sorry.”

“So you stopped him?” thinking about another man’s hand on his wife, so close to the center of her legs.

Rose nodded. Her own hand drifted up, circling his once-again erect cock. “If I didn’t, it would have been bad.”

“Yeah?”

They were beyond the game. Beyond teasing. “I think so, yeah.”

“You want him?”

She studied him, making sure he could handle the raw truth. “Yeah, I do.”

“You shouldn’t have stopped him.” But he was glad that she had. “Next time, don’t stop him.”

She saw the truth in his words. “You sure?” He took a deep breath, his nostrils flaring. She started stroking his cock before he could answer. “Next time, when he leans in to kiss me, I should let him?”

Andy groaned, his cock thickening in her fingers. “Yes,” he said tightly.

“I bet he’s a good kisser. He’s got nice, soft looking lips.”

“Rose...”

She licked her own lips. “I’ve imagined kissing him, you know. I’ve fantasized about what it would be like to kiss another man. It’s been so long.”

He thought about what Jordan had said about her in the staged video — *“Tyler is new and exciting, and you’ve got a wild side hidden under*

there.” He thought about their own past, and how so much of it felt like that first year of their relationship.

“You like having secrets, too,” he said.

She seemed to sense where this was going. “I do, but you know what I’ve learned? I like having secrets *with you.*” She leaned in, pulling his erection against her thigh. “It starts in the mornings, when you watch me as I get dressed. I love that moment.”

“I love watching you,” he said breathlessly.

“I know you wonder if I’m putting that new thong on for another man.” He throbbed in her grip, coaxing a pleased smile from her. “Truth is, a part of me was.”

“Makes you feel naughty.”

“Because of the secret...”

“...that we share,” he finished.

“Now you’re getting it.” She climbed up into his lap, guiding him back into her. “Oh, Andy, you’re so hard.” Her groan was part sigh, part laugh. “It’s still crazy to me that this is actually real.” She put her hands on his shoulders as she began to bounce on him. “That it really does turn you on thinking of me with another man.”

Her pussy tightened around his shaft. “Turns you on, too.” He almost held this next thing. “And not just because of me and my fantasy.”

It felt like a weight off his shoulders, to say that to her, to give her an avenue to be truthful. She looked down at him, meeting his eyes. What came next would be truth. What came next wasn’t simply a way to tease him. “It’s nice to be noticed by someone like Tyler.”

“Go on.”

“He’s young, handsome, confident.” She seemed to flutter over him. She liked that confidence. “I’m sure he could have his pick of girls.”

“Yet he invited you to his place,” Andy said.

“Yeah.”

“He ran his hand up your leg,” he went on. Her breath caught. “He probably thinks about you when he’s all alone at night. Wondering how you kiss.”

“Oh, Andy...”

“How you taste.”

“Mmm...”

“How tight you are around his big cock.”

Rose sucked in air, but didn't release it. She shut her eyes, thinking about him as she undulated in his lap.

"Think about riding him. Think about how good he'll feel, baby."

"Oh, oh..."

"I want you to feel it. I want you to try it."

Her brow creased. She rested her forehead on his and nodded, eyes still clamped shut.

"I want you to be my naughty hotwife, and come back and share our little secret."

She whimpered.

"Will you do it?"

"Mm, yes."

"Will you fuck him?"

She nodded curtly.

"Do it, Rose. Be bad. Be bad and come back to me and share everything."

"Oh, Andy. Andy..."

Their lips found one another, kissing deep and hard until she couldn't maintain it anymore. Until her orgasm swelled up through her and she had to pull back and release her rising cry.

Andy put Tyler in his place, imagining it was that younger man making her scream. Where it frightened him before—and still frightened him on some level—it triggered his own release.

He could do this.

They could do this.

And it would be sublime.

ROSE

“He was all over me when I got home,” Rose told Jordan. They were out to brunch, Saturday morning. Louis was watching Lilian and Andy was running some errands.

“I told you he would be.”

At Jordan’s suggestion, they were drinking mimosas, and Rose was feeling particularly open. “I know.”

“You didn’t believe it though.” Jordan’s smugness rubbed Rose the wrong way. “Men think with their dicks. They can’t help it.”

Rose ignored Jordan’s derision. “It was nice to get it all off my chest and be honest. I still can’t believe he’s actually into this.”

“Still have doubts?”

“No, not doubts. Just... I mean, it’s pretty insane, right? That he’s okay with me... doing *that*. ”

“Honey, wait til you actually start playing. They’ll do anything to get some details. I don’t think I’m ever going to have to fold the laundry again. Lou is, like, better than a housekeeper. He’ll do *any* -thing.”

Rose didn’t think that kind of power play would work with Andy. She kind of hoped that it wouldn’t.

“Lou’s so whipped. You know what he asked to do after Jayden and Britney left the other day?”

“I don’t think I want to know.”

“He wanted to lick Jayden’s—”

“Okay.”

“—out of my—”

“I get it.”

Jordan cracked up, covering her mouth as she drew looks from the tables around them. “I’m sorry, I’m sorry. Honestly, as fucked up as it is, it was so hot when he did it.”

“So what’s the deal between you two? Last time I checked, you guys were on the outs. You ‘needed a real man’ or something like that.”

Jordan calmed down enough to give a semi-thoughtful reply. “I did say that. But I guess nothing’s simple, is it? You definitely are aware of that.” She winked. “I think we’re going to be fine. Different, but fine. Like I said, he’s a good man and a great father. And I’ve found the, um, upside of his weird fantasy, too.”

“And that’s what scares me. I don’t want to find that upside.”

“Judgmental bitch!”

“No, I’m sorry. I didn’t mean it like that.”

Jordan laughed, waving it off. “I’m just joking. Look, I get it. Believe me. This isn’t for everyone. But it also doesn’t need to be a make-or-break thing, either. Nothing’s black or white in marriage, or sexuality, or really anything, I guess. Your husband’s into the idea of you having an affair, and as much as you deny it, you’re into it, too.”

She was right. That still didn’t make it an easy thing to accept or agree with.

“So what’s your plan?” Jordan asked. “And how can I help?”

“Well, since you’re offering...”

ANDY

Louis]: *Need to talk. Can you grab a beer after work?*
Andy groaned as he read the text. As much as he liked Louis and owed so much of recent events to the man's fetish, the man was exhausting as a friend.

[Andy]: Sure thing. I love drinking on a Monday.

[Louis]: Now you're getting into the spirit of life without kids.

[Andy]: Just in time for them to get back next weekend.

[Louis]: Hey, there's still plenty of time to have fun. I was thinking we grab that drink at Dominion Brew Pub downtown, but maybe the Orchid Lounge is a better venue?

The Orchid Lounge was a strip club that Andy could proudly say he'd never set foot in.

[Andy]: See you at Dominion around 5?

After the exchange, Andy almost completely forgot about it. He had a lot more on his mind, between work and the wild new turn that his marriage

seemed to have taken. The rest of the weekend had been fun and full of sex on a level that surpassed even the last few weeks.

They hadn't actually brought up his name since Friday, but Tyler was there, already a presence inside of their bedroom, even if nothing was official. Yet.

Yet. That short little word, just three letters that somehow felt as infinitely heavy and infinitely light, as strong and as energizing as an espresso after a long night.

His insecurities were with him, of course, threatening to overtake him if he let them. He had doubts. Maybe this wasn't a game for her. Maybe she really was sleeping with Tyler. After all, Rose, his sweet soccer mom wife played this "game" all too well. Hadn't she been the one scandalized in the first place after learning about why Louis and Jordan split up?

The questions riled him up. The doubt was real. But she knew that as well. She used it, fed it, nurtured it.

She didn't say a word Monday morning as she emerged from the steam-filled bathroom wearing a lacy black bra, a matching thong, and a pair of sheer, black thigh highs. A rose-shaped jewel dangled from her navel, a new piercing that she hadn't mentioned getting. When she saw him looking, she fingered the jewel and said to him, "Think Tyler will like it?"

And that was the end of it. She finished dressing in a short—yet work appropriate—dress. She added makeup and brushed out her hair until it shined, and wished him a good day.

It was electrifying. Whatever was going on, whatever might happen, he trusted Rose—not just with Tyler and what she could get away with behind his back, but he trusted her not to turn their relationship into whatever Louis and Jordan now had.

"So you two are back together?" Andy asked Louis, trying to puzzle out the man's wishes-washy declarations.

"I mean, I'm living in the house again," he said. It was like he wanted to look at Andy, but couldn't manage more than a couple seconds of eye contact. "It's complicated."

"Help me understand. Isn't that why you asked me to meet you?"

"Right." He drained his beer. "My only ask here is that you don't judge me. 'Kay?"

Andy nodded.

“Jordan and I have worked out an arrangement.” He leaned in. “We’ve gone full on cuck.”

“What does that even mean?”

“Well, first of all, it means I do whatever she tells me to do.”

“Like when you sent me that recording.”

At least the man looked guilty. “Sorry about that.” He held his hands up, like it was completely out of his control. Which it was. “She’s still seeing Jayden. And Britney. She’s free to date.”

“She’s dating them?”

“Yeah. I guess. Although from what I gather, they don’t do much talking.”

Andy thought of the cameras. “You still watching them?”

“Nah. She took all that down.” He chuckled to himself. “She shares what she wants to share with me, which isn’t a whole lot. Like last Saturday, she went over to his house. She didn’t even tell me until after Lillian was down, and when she came back in the morning—freshly fucked—she didn’t share anything. She just made me...” He licked his lips nervously. “...made me clean her up.”

Andy’s eyes went wide.

Louis answered the question that Andy wasn’t sure he had. “She didn’t shower, no. He was still in her—”

“Okay. Got it.” He wasn’t going to judge, but he also knew that this wasn’t for him. If this is what Jordan was feeding Rose about, he suddenly got very nervous. “You okay with all of this?”

“Man, that’s a complicated question.” He looked forlornly at his empty pint of beer. “I always had this...proclivity, you know? A submissive kink. And Jordan, she’s so beautiful and sexy and way out of my league, I think that’s part of what gave me the courage to approach her, to ask her out, was my complete confidence that she’d laugh at me and shut me down. So I guess that even from the beginning, I was looking for some kind of humiliation.” He laughed at himself, running his hands through his hair compulsively. “When she didn’t, and actually turned out to be this amazing person, I guess I just was always waiting for that other shoe to drop.”

Andy stared at him, trying to empathize and coming up short. “So you’re okay with all of this.”

“Ha. Yeah, I’m so okay with it. It’s...fuck dude, I know it’s not everyone, and I can see how you’re looking at me now, but I don’t care. My

wife's dating, and I get to be a part of that."

Andy paused, to try and work out how he'd feel if Rose started *dating* . It wasn't a complete buzzkill, although he wasn't at all comfortable with the rest of Louis's arrangement.

"So she doesn't tell you about stuff? What do you get out of it?"

"I know that my Mistress is happy. And when she's happy, so am I."

Andy released a pent up breath, his gaze wandering around the room as if looking for some kind of sanity. Were any of these other couples having insane conversations like this one? Were the two women sitting in the booth on the far side of the bar talking about affairs they were getting away with? Was the trio, two men and a woman, working out the logistics of a threesome?

Then he saw them. His heart froze. Louis said something, but Andy didn't hear. He was swimming underwater, sound coming to him low and long and distorted.

At the bar sat Rose, her legs crossed, her dress short enough that if it rode up any higher, anyone looking would soon discover her thigh highs—and Tyler, sitting right next to her, was definitely looking.

What had seemed like a fairly conservative office dress now took on a provocative look. While it buttoned all the way up to her neck, it was sleeveless, allowing Tyler to run a hand up and down her bare arm.

Rose touched her neck as she tossed her head back and laughed at something he said. He removed his arm, but remained standing close enough that their hips touched. Signaling a bartender, Andy watched this other man order his wife a drink.

Andy felt like he was being sucked into a vortex of betrayal and lust. The contradicting emotions whipped him about, tugging and tugging until he felt rended into two. She was seeing Tyler after all? When she went over to his place, did she really just talk? Just flirt?

Tyler turned back from the bar, a pint of amber beer for him, a margarita for Rose. Andy watched as his wife licked salt from the rim of her drink, her eyes flitting up to Tyler, who stared right back. He leaned in, said something else as his hand came to rest on her knee.

Rose shook her head, but was laughing. *I can't believe I'm doing this* , Andy thought she mouthed. *Do it* , Tyler seemed to say. Rose laughed again, rolling her eyes as she reached into her purse and retrieved her phone. A moment later, Andy's phone rumbled to life.

*[Rose]: Impromptu happy hour to celebrate Mazzy's big promotion.
I think we may grab dinner, too. Not sure when I'll be home.*

Andy's stomach bottomed out. The rest of him fell into the gaping abyss. He stared at the text, the lie both incomprehensible yet frighteningly clear. Sweat built beneath his shirt. Panic waited in the wings, ready to pounce. Somehow, he held it off.

He glanced up from his phone, from the words. Tyler was leaning in, whispering something into Rose's ear. She hadn't removed his hand, which had climbed a little higher along her thigh. They were going to fuck. This was all prelude. He could feel the pent-up energy from all the way across the room, growing and growing like a pressure cooker.

The rose piercing. *Think Tyler will like it?*

How long had they been fucking?

He was so angry. He was paralyzed with lust.

Why was he hard, sitting there, watching another man sweet talk his wife?

Just as that vortex was about to swallow him whole, just as all seemed lost, dark and out of control and forever changed, Rose looked up at him, finding Andy's eyes from across the bar. *I see you*, she said without saying.

"I'm sorry, man," Louis said. Andy looked at the man, remembering him for the first time in what felt like ages. When he looked back at Rose, she was focused on Tyler with those soft, brown eyes of hers. Had he imagined the look? Is that what his psyche craved? For this not to be real, but just another game?

"Yes." He answered his own question aloud.

"Hm?" Louis asked.

"We're not really here to talk about your marriage, are we?"

"Well..." Louis dithered.

"Jordan told you to bring me here, didn't she?"

Louis looked down at the table. "She did."

The relief was so pure, so sweet. A million pounds off his shoulders. He picked up his phone again, feeling like he was rising and rising up into the clouds.

[Andy]: No worries. I won't wait up for you. Have fun.

He watched her read his reply. She didn't look in his direction for confirmation, but he saw her smile like she wanted to.

[Rose]: Thanks, honey. I love you so much. <3

By the time he looked back up, her phone was back in her purse. More startlingly, she was leaning close to Tyler, whispering something into his ear. A moment later, he grinned, nodded, and took a big gulp of his beer.

"So what happens next?" Andy asked Louis.

"You go home and wait for your wife to return." He looked at Andy and heaved a deep breath. "I know you and I aren't exactly the same, but these next few hours are going to be *intense*."

Andy nodded. He could already feel it, like a maelstrom beating hard against the storm doors just outside.

Across the room, Rose and Tyler finished their drinks in a hurry. Tyler closed out his tab. Andy watched in freefall.

"*Ready?*" Tyler seemed to ask.

Rose slipped off the stool, her hair tumbling forward. She brushed it back with her left hand, and her ring caught in the light. She held up a finger, asking him to wait. He made himself busy on his phone as she dug out her own. A moment later, a text came through.

[Rose]: Looks like I'll be getting home late after all. That going to be a problem?

She was giving him one final out. This was it. Did he want this?

[Andy]: Not a problem at all. See you at home!

He hadn't been sure of anything until he received that text. As crazy as it sounded, they were in this together. This was a choice, ultimately, that they were both making—a thing that they both wanted.

Rose smiled as she read his response and chanced a glance in his direction. Andy's heartbeat skipped. He smiled back at her as Tyler put his phone away and said something.

They didn't leave hand-in-hand. No one looking would think that they were a couple. They were coworkers, maybe, friendly but that was all. That was, until they reached the door, and Tyler set his hand on Rose's lower back as she pushed open the doors. Andy's chest tightened. Louis, almost to himself, said, "That's so hot."

And then they were out into the warm, summer dusk.

"Do you know where they're going?"

Louis shrugged. "I don't know anything else."

"Should I follow?"

"I... I don't know, man. I'll pick up the check if you want to."

Andy hesitated. He wished he knew Rose's plan, and thought about texting her. But Tyler would be right there, his arm around her, perhaps. What if he saw the text? All of hers before had been coded for that reason.

When he finally did leave the bar, it was too late. They were gone. Things were in motion and now completely out of his control.

He shouldered his bag and headed for home.

ROSE

The Uber driver filled the whole ride out of the city with a conversation about how the internet edged out the printing industry—an industry that he had apparently devoted his whole career to until he was laid off. Tyler good-naturedly nodded and listened, asking pointed questions as he winked and smiled at her.

“Uh huh. You don’t say? Yeah, I think most people read things on their phones now.”

Rose barely heard any of it. She was already thinking of what came next—Tyler’s house, the feeling of his hands on her again, and, maybe most exhilarating of all, returning to Andy at the end of the night.

“I want you to take me back to your place,” Rose had said. She’d initiated it. She’d initiated all of this. Now that she knew everyone was on board, she was done playing this game. In her head, she’d put an internal countdown on it: it was over once the kids got home from camp. There were just some risks that were beyond the excitement.

The ride ended. Tyler helped Rose out, and she swore he caught a glimpse of her stocking tops. It was fine. It was, after all, why she wore them.

“Well that was different than a bus ride home,” he said.

“And here I was, thinking we’d get more privacy.”

Tyler led her towards his front door. No one else was on the street. “Come on, plenty of privacy in there.”

Rose’s chest thrummed with her pulse, made even quicker by the tequila that coursed through her. She floated up his short walk and into his house.

She shut the door herself, turning the lock by feel as she looked up at Tyler.

“You’ve got me alone,” she said. “And this time, I promise, I’m not going anywhere.”

She could see the hunger grow in him. She resisted the urge to shy away from it. That wasn’t her. Not anymore. This was how she felt during that first visit to Andy’s office. Back then, she’d locked the door behind her. She’d strolled into the room, her desire to seduce overtaking the instinct to run.

“I didn’t think you were.” He crossed his arms and leaned against the door. “Want something else to drink?”

Rose could feel the lace at the tops of her thigh-highs rub as she crossed the room to him. She was so wet. So ready for this. “No. That won’t be necessary.”

Standing before him was already different than Andy. Tyler was tall, and even in her heels, she had to look up at him. She liked that. Liked the difference.

Walking her fingers up his chest, she felt his heart racing as quickly as hers. That helped. He was as nervous as she was. Sliding her hand around his neck, she pulled him down to her. It was so natural, so fluid. Gone was the shame and guilt. In its place, Andy’s calm voice whispering, “*Do it. Kiss him.*”

Tyler’s lips felt different. Tyler’s body against her felt different. She reveled in it, in the naughty, delicious sensation of Tyler’s tongue tangling with hers.

While she clung to his neck, his hands strayed down her body. Down her dress. Down across her ass, where his fingers traced the plunge of her thong. It thrilled her for him to discover that. It thrilled her to think about how much more he’d discover.

Pulling back, she spoke clearly, confidently. “Take me to your bedroom.”

Rose saw the boy beneath the man, giddy and excited. It fueled her confidence. She was in his home. She was the married one. But she was also in control, and that control felt glorious.

His master bedroom was the same as hers, of course—at least in layout. His bed was bigger, the room less cluttered with things. “Someone didn’t make their bed this morning,” Rose said, folding the comforter up and tugging it into place out of habit.

“You don’t have to do that,” Tyler said. The man was back. “Just going to mess it all up again anyway.”

“I like a tidy package...” she said, stepping up to him and setting her fingers on the buttons of his shirt. “...before I strip it all away.”

She unbuttoned his shirt, revealing the broad chest she’d been eyeing all summer long. The light brown curls were as soft as she’d imagined, his skin warm, his flesh real.

“I can see the merits in that,” Tyler said. A moment later, he tugged the zipper of her dress down the center of her back.

Panic flashed through her. This wasn’t Andy. This wasn’t right...and because of that, it was exhilarating. Frustrated at how slow it was to undo each button, she grabbed his shirt and yanked it open, sending the last of the buttons flying.

“You’re going to pay for that,” he growled, shrugging out of his shirt.

Rose ran her fingers down his body, tracing the ripples of his abdominal muscles. “Don’t worry. I plan to.”

His cock was hard, a bulge too large to be real. Her breath came short as she touched it, feeling him pulse beneath her fingertips. Tyler pushed her dress from her shoulders, and she let him go reluctantly. The dress pooled on the floor, and Tyler’s eyes were all over her.

“You are so sexy,” he said, brushing a lock of hair over her shoulder. The bra was new, constructed entirely out of lace, and she knew he could see her nipples through it. He cupped her face in his hands. She could feel his desire beating through him. Their eyes locked as he consumed her.

They kissed hard and hungrily, like they couldn’t get enough of one another. Rose needed more. She grabbed Tyler by the belt and forcibly turned him, shoving him back onto the bed. He grinned, propping himself up onto his elbows as she went to her knees and began to work open his belt.

Tyler watched, his chest rising and falling rapidly, as she unzipped his fly and pulled out his erection. He was big, thicker than she’d expected—so thick she couldn’t wrap her fingers all the way around it.

She met his eyes, daring herself to confront the fact that this wasn’t Andy. His electric blue irises cut through her, urging her on. Urging her to duck forward and run the flat of her tongue up along the unfamiliar contours of his thick cock.

Tyler groaned. She swirled her tongue upwards, teasing the underside of his crown before wrapping her lips fully around the tip and sucking. She was doing it. She was actually doing it.

He felt monstrously large in her mouth, the skin supple and warm against her tongue. Sucking hard enough to draw out her cheeks, she managed about half his length before he hit the back of her throat. She drew back, repeating the motion as she watched his face tighten with pleasure.

Like *deja vu*, this felt so much like that moment years ago, when she'd crawled under Andy's desk and sucked him off in his office. The same excitement was there. The same wonder and disbelief.

Only unlike Andy, Tyler wasn't a passive recipient. After a few bobs to get used to his size, Tyler ran his fingers through her hair, urging her to move faster, take him deeper. "Just relax that throat, baby. I know you can take more."

She choked, gagging, and began to pull back when she saw the challenge in Tyler's face. She took a deep breath, relaxed her throat muscles, and swallowed more of him. This time, after gagging, she was able to take him deeper than she'd ever taken anyone. She felt him clog up her throat, felt it go deep, and was rewarded as he rocked his head back, his eyelids heavy.

Again, Rose pulled back and gasped for air. Again, she went back to him, this time on her own. This time, deeper than ever. She held him by the base, where a small crop of tightly trimmed curls became her goal. If she could touch her lips to that, she could claim victory.

Tyler didn't let her get used to it. He didn't want deep, it seemed. He wanted fast. With his hands in complete control, he guided her up and down his length, faster and faster. She pinched the base of him with her fingers, jerking him in time with each stroke.

"That looks so hot." Tyler groaned, his fist tightening in her hair. Pain skipped along her scalp. "Do you swallow?"

She didn't answer. Not verbally. But she redoubled her efforts, slithering her tongue along his veiny underside as she tugged at his balls. She didn't pull back. She didn't slow, even as he drew closer and closer.

Tyler wanted a woman who swallowed his come, and Rose wanted to be that kind of woman. She watched him, making sure that he saw her looking. "*Do it,*" she tried to convey. "*Give me your come.*"

"Oh, Rose... oh... gah!"

She pulled back just as he began to pulse, drinking his come, the naughtiness coursing through her. While she wasn't crazy about the taste, she loved how devious this felt. Particularly as she rose onto the bed and mashed her mouth onto Tyler's, forcing him to taste himself.

He didn't seem to mind. He kissed her back, hard, grabbing her ass and squeezing it. He was still hard, she realized, as he pulled her into him, only the thin gusset of her thong separating her from his bare cock.

"How are you still hard?" she blurted out.

"Don't get all offended. That's totally your fault."

"Then I should take some responsibility." Momentum brought her here. Momentum helped her slide her thong down her thighs. She pressed his cock against her body and slid the smooth, wet lips of her shaved pussy along that thick ridge. They groaned together.

She wanted it. She wanted it so badly. But responsibility won out in the end. "You have a condom?"

"I'm clean," he said through his teeth.

"I believe you. But we still need a condom."

He didn't push again. He simply nodded to his nightstand. Reluctantly, she slipped out of his lap and opened the drawer. Inside was the box—Trojan XLs—along with a bottle of lubricant that they were not going to need.

Tyler shifted behind her, reaching out to unclasp her bra. "There, now you're as naked as I want you," he said, kissing her shoulder.

Rose smiled at him through the curtain of her hair. "You like stockings."

"I like the kind of woman who wears stockings."

"And what kind of woman is that?"

He kissed into the crook of her neck. "The kind of woman who knows exactly what she wants."

She kissed him over her shoulder as he palmed her tits and tweaked her nipples. She reached behind her, wrapping her hand around his cock and stroking.

"The kind of woman who satisfies her curiosity." He slipped a hand down her body and across her bald mound. "And right now, she's curious about how my cock will feel buried deep in her pussy."

He slid two fingers into that pussy, thumbing her clit like she was an instrument to be played. Almost instantly, she was close to the edge. He kissed her neck. He worked her tits. He had her so close, so fast, but he was

right. The curiosity grew, and she needed to satisfy it. She needed to feel him inside of her.

Taking her hand off his shaft, she handed the foil wrapper to him. "Put it on. I can't wait anymore."

"That's what I like to hear." He tore it open, the foreign scent of spermicide underscoring just how illicit this was. He rolled it on as she turned, leaning back into his pillows, and spread her legs.

He was such an amazing specimen of a man, she thought as he mounted her. She had no complaints about Andy, but he just couldn't compete with Tyler, who was at least ten years younger, six inches taller, and judging from his muscled shoulders, chest, and arms, must have spent many hours longer in the gym than her husband.

And that wasn't even taking into account the size of his cock, which he brandished with pride, thick and long and, Rose guiltily admitted, exciting.

As he edged closer, she reached out, taking it from him, guiding it against her. He loomed, other-worldly and all man, as she pressed the tip against her sex. Just that much and he felt gargantuan.

"Do it," she hissed.

Tyler grinned.

"Make me scream."

Tyler dropped into her, thrusting forward, filling her like she'd never been filled before. Rose rocked back, unable to keep that orgasm at bay any longer. When she felt his balls slap against her ass, she unleashed herself.

The moment stretched and stretched, a fiery blur of pleasure and bliss and something brand new. The man inside her wasn't Andy. Nothing about him was familiar. Not his size. Not his smell. Not the way he fucked her. When she recovered enough to open her eyes, he was there, his brows knitted, his nostrils flaring.

He didn't slow down. He didn't ask her if he was hurting her. He took her, because she needed taking. He kissed her, because she needed kissing. He *fucked* her, because she desperately needed fucking.

"God, you feel huge."

"You feel just right, Rose." He slowed his hips, letting her feel every inch of his girth as he pushed deep, hitting spots that had never been hit before. "Just right."

Rose gasped, shutting her eyes and concentrating on every, pampered sensation. He kissed her neck. He ran his hands across her breasts. He

brushed back her hair. Their fingers interlaced, his left into her right, then right into left. Opening her eyes, he was right there, filling her whole world.

"I feel like I'm dreaming," she said.

His smile was so disarming. A hidden part of her melted every time she saw it. "Me too." He pushed forward again. "But I promise you, we're not."

He turned his head, looking at something beside them. "Look."

In the corner, facing them, stood a full-length mirror, reflecting the two of them. Tyler, over her, looked so good, his skin glistening, his biceps thick and corded along his arms, where they held hands.

"Did you put that there to watch yourself have sex?" she asked.

Tyler laughed. He spoke to her reflection. "Believe it or not, no. It's just a sexy bonus." Squeezing their entwined fingers, he pulled her up to him like she weighed nothing. His muscles rippled. She kissed his shoulder, watching her reflection like this was some kind of wild sex dream.

She watched as he shifted his hands down to her ass. She felt his hands. She felt his chest against her breasts as she watched them compress into him.

"Watch yourself. Watch how sexy you are," he said. She watched him kiss her neck again. Against her ear, he whispered, "Watch yourself come."

Tyler lifted her guiding her along his cock as she watched. It was as an out-of-body experience as she'd ever had. She swore she could feel the sensations before seeing them in that reflection. She could feel him slide up into her a split second before watching his body do it. Sensation before sight, like sexual *deja vu*.

She rested her head on his shoulder, the lids of her eyes growing heavy as her orgasm built yet again. There she was. Riding another man's lap. Feeling his hands all over her. Rose with her auburn hair clinging to her forehead. Rose, wife of a man who was just as excited that she was here as she was.

"Oh, fuck I'm..." She moaned. "I'm so close," she said in a rush.

Tyler sank onto his haunches, but kept his hands on her hips. She arched out and away from him, supporting herself on her arms. She knew she looked good, and she knew he was looking. She watched him in the mirror, drinking in her bouncing tits.

"Do it, Rose. Come. Watch yourself come."

She looked down between them, where her legs opened around his torso. Where his thick cock glistened as he pulled it out of her pussy, shaved

bare just that morning for this man. He thrust forward, his abs tightening as he pulled her back into him. Stars formed in her vision. She shut her eyes, tossed her head back, and wailed.

ANDY

Sleep was out of the question. Andy got back to his place about a half hour after watching Rose leave with Tyler. That last moment played out again and again—the two of them laughing, Tyler such a good match to his wife, broad and fit and athletic next to her tall, lean, yoga-yewn body.

He'd watched that before, though, just last week as they strolled down the street together. Nothing happened then. A part of him was convinced that nothing would happen now.

Then the hours began to tick by. Seven led to eight led to nine. The sun set. Andy forgot to turn on any lights until he stood to pee and realized that his home was completely dark.

She'd been with him for more than two hours. Even if they spent some of that time eating, more had to have happened, and his imagination filled in the blanks with vague glimpses of sweating bodies, his wife's moans, another man's cock sliding in and out of her.

At ten, a text came in.

[Rose]: Sorry, completely lost track of time.

Reading that text felt like a lifeline. He clung to it, reading it over and over and unable to stop himself from smiling.

[Andy]: It's okay. You having fun?

Her response was almost instantaneous.

[Rose]: So much fun. Can't wait to tell you all about it.

He swam in those words, adrift and finally, at last, carefree.

[Andy]: Stay out as late as you want. I'll be here when you get back.

[Rose]: Thanks, honey. I love you so much.

[Andy]: I love you, too. Enjoy.

[Rose]: Oh, hey...

The line was followed by an image that lanced right through his gut. At first, all he could see was a naked man from the neck down, built with the kind of body that Andy could never have, no matter how hard he worked out. He stood akimbo, proud of what he had to offer—and what he had to offer was the kind of cock that belonged in porn. And wrapped around that cock, as if to give a measure of scale, was a woman's hand, coming from just out of the frame.

Andy saw the ring. He knew. It was Rose.

They were in a bathroom, and it took Andy a moment to realize that this must have been a reflection. A towel hung neatly from the rack behind them. Toiletries lined the foreground.

[Rose]: Don't jerk off and I promise I'll let you come all over my face.

Andy blinked at the text, his heart bouncing as he watched her type out something else.

[Rose]: Just like Tyler did to me earlier.

Andy sat down, his knees weak, his chest caving.

[Rose]: One more. Love you!

The next photo was also taken in the bathroom, and like the first, it strategically cut out any faces. This one, though, featured his wife prominently—naked and on her knees, her ass to the camera, her auburn hair tumbling in loose, springy coils down her back. Tyler held the phone out with one hand, pointed at the reflection. His other was in Rose's hair, where it was easy for Andy to imagine the man directing her mouth up and down his cock.

That was it. No more bouncing indicators. No more texts. Just those two images and the directive not to jerk off.

That was easier said than done. The temptation was real—especially with those two photos. This was no longer academic. His wife, Rose, was a hotwife. Another man had sampled her, and was currently sampling her.

Twice, he caught himself subconsciously touching his cock through his pajama bottoms and had to actively stop. He considered going to the gym, just to burn off some of this energy. He tapped out a message to Louis, twice, just to talk, but ended up deleting them.

Rose finally came home just shy of eleven, almost two hours since she'd texted the photos. She looked tired, but everything was in place—her hair was brushed, her makeup must have been reapplied, her dress wasn't disheveled.

She did, however, look sheepish as she shut the door gently behind her. She looked up at him as she ascended the short flight of stairs of the split level, where he waited, his heart going crazy in his chest.

"Hey," she said. "Sorry I'm late."

Andy nodded. "You have fun?"

Rose bit her lip, nodding. In the same, demure tone, she asked, "Have you been good?"

"It's been hard, but yes."

She started to walk right past him when she caught his arm and laced her fingers into his. "Good. At least someone has."

Andy sucked in air. It didn't help. He wasn't getting enough oxygen to the brain.

"Come on, I need to take a shower. And you need to join me."

Andy studied her as she led him upstairs. While everything seemed in place, he started to pick up on things. Like how she was no longer wearing

stockings, or that her knees were red. Or when he got close, he caught an unfamiliar, musky smell of another man's deodorant.

He was so hard that he had to stop to adjust himself. Rose continued on ahead, glancing back at him with a playful smile. "We'll take care of that in a moment. Don't worry."

In the bathroom, she unzipped her dress, shimmying out of it with her back to him. She wore nothing beneath. No bra. No thong. Nothing at all.

"Oh, Rose..."

She switched on the shower, teasing him with the flash of nipple before stepping in. "You coming?"

Andy quickly stripped as she pulled the curtain shut, the water splashing around her. He was comically erect, and a little embarrassed because of it, but joined her anyway.

"Tell me," he said, proud that he didn't sound too desperate. He cleared his throat and tried again. "Tell me how bad you were."

Rose turned, water rushing through her cleavage. "I will. I promise. But first, I need you inside of me."

She stepped close, putting her arms around him. Her nose brushed his. Her lips hovered. They basked in one another beneath the spray, her body against his, warm and soft and familiar. They let all that potential energy build just a moment longer, breathing shallow, heartbeats matching at a breakneck pace.

"I've been so bad, Andy. So bad...for you."

Their mouths finally met, energy unleashed. He could taste him in her spit, the salty tang of another man. He didn't recoil. Instead, he sank his fingers into the flesh of her hips, drawing her closer. His cock glanced along her bare mound.

Rose grabbed it, pulling them back to the wall. She lifted her leg, balanced it on the soap tray, and positioned his cock against her pussy.

"Give it to me, Andy. Take me back."

Andy thrust forward. Was she looser than before? Did she feel different?

"Yes!" she cried. Her fist tightened in his hair, the pain chasing away those questions before they could find answers. "You're so hard. Sooo... hard!"

Andy splayed his fingers on the wall and clutched her hip and ass as he plunged into her. He *was* hard. He could feel the difference, could feel the

way he expanded and stretched her. He took her with power, his lust picking up strength and speed as he slid in and out and thought about how another man had done the same before she came home.

“Did you like it?” The question seethed through his clenched teeth.

“Yes!”

“Tell me.”

“I loved it.” Her voice was strained, stretched taut over something vast and yawning. “I loved that I got to be so naughty with him.”

“You blew him?”

“I felt that!” she exhaled. “I did. I sucked his cock so many times.”

“Oh, Rose.”

“My jaw’s sore from all the cock I swallowed. Is that what you want to hear?” She pulled him close, her heavy pants right against his ear. “Because it’s true. You know that photo I sent you? I think I must have been down there for at least ten minutes.”

Andy groaned.

“I took him in my throat.” She met his thrusts with her own. “I sucked on his balls.” She nipped at his ears. “I let him ride my face until he was so close.” The pitch of her voice rose as she grew close, too. She was there, reliving it. “I couldn’t breathe. I was choking, gagging on it.” He could almost hear it. “It must have sounded so raunchy.”

Andy couldn’t take much more. He drove into her, their slapping bodies amplified by the water. His balls rose. He felt everything gather just at the base of his cock.

“And just as he was about to come, he asked me where I wanted it.”

“Oh, fuck, Rose.”

She pulled back, so she could look him right in the eye—just as he imagined she must have done with Tyler. “‘All over my face,’ I told him. ‘I want you to come all over my face.’”

Andy groaned. He couldn’t hold it at bay any longer. The come was rising through him like molten fire.

Still with her eyes locked on his, her hand clamped behind his head, she fixed him with a fiery gaze. “That’s what you want to hear. Isn’t it. Andy?”

“Yes,” he growled. Then, “Yes!” he shouted as he came.

Rose gnashed her teeth, her jaw tight, tossing her head back and pulling him close as her orgasm boiled forth from somewhere deep and primal. Her

scream was husky, hard—as hard as the grip on him, like she was trying to pull him physically through her.

He pinned her there, against the wall, his cock as deep as it could go, pressing her to the tile. They clung together, two beings at last reunited and forever unrestrained.

HOURS LATER, Andy held Rose to him. They'd talked and made love. She'd filled him in on every little detail, answered every question he had.

"Were you safe?"

"Of course."

"What would you have done if I wasn't at the bar?"

"I would have had a drink, flirted with him, and kept him wanting more."

"How did you take the photo?"

"I told him I wanted a souvenir to remember it by. Flattery goes a long way with that man."

But there was one big question he wanted to ask, but was worried to say it. He put it off and off until sleep beckoned. He could have put it off until morning, but they were done with those games.

Rose asked it for him. "So what happens next?"

Caught off guard, he didn't have an answer. "Um..."

"Because I was thinking about this whole thing. And while all of the teasing was fun, all the sneaking around, making you think I was up to something was definitely...fun..." She snuggled close. "This, right here, being open with you about it is so, so much better."

"I couldn't agree more."

"But I also realize, if I'm honest, that I'm not Jordan. And I hope she's not who you're expecting me to be—"

"I'm not. And I'm not Louis, either."

"Not that there's anything wrong with them," Rose added, apologetic to the end.

"Of course not," Andy agreed.

"I'm not Jordan, and I don't want this to be a regular thing. In fact, I think that when the boys come back, we put this adventure on the shelf."

Incredibly, he felt his cock stirring, painful as it was after all the sex.
“They don’t get back until Saturday.”

“Next Saturday evening,” she corrected. “And if you wanted to take the scenic route there, maybe get some dinner with the boys...”

“Yeah?”

“Maybe I can see about borrowing some of those cameras in Jordan’s place.”

“Very naughty, Mrs. Shaw.”

“Too much?”

“Let’s judge that Sunday, when I get home and we can review the videos.”

She looked past him. “I think the sun’s coming up,” she said with a laugh.

“I think you’re going to miss Tyler at the bus stop today.”

She kissed him. “That’s okay, there’s always this afternoon, at the pool.” She looked right at him, her hair catching in the early dawn light like a flame. “Oh, and he wants me to get a string bikini. What do you think?”

Andy chuckled. “Sounds like my kind of guy.”

They snuggled close, at last falling asleep just as a new day began.

EPILOGUE

The door opened, and Rose ran inside, her pull-over soaked. She was laughing hysterically.

“Come on, come on!” she shouted out the door, where the rain fell in sheets.

Tyler ducked in, his linen shirt just as drenched, clinging to his upper torso. “Wow, didn’t expect that,” he said, raking his fingers through his short hair.

Rose reached around him to shut the door, throwing the deadbolt, but she didn’t step away. She paused, one arm wrapped around his waist, and smiled. “Hey, there.”

“Hey back.” He glanced deeper into the house. “He here?”

“He’s not. He won’t be for hours.”

“I see. How lonely.”

Rose giggled. “That’s why you’re here.” She tilted her head. “So we can watch some college football, or whatever you single guys do on rainy Saturday afternoons.”

“College football hasn’t started,” he said. “But I can think of a few alternatives.”

“Mmm, I’m glad I found such a creative problem solver to have a fling with.”

“I knew you were in it just for my brains.”

She slid her hand down his chest and beneath the elastic of his swimming trunks. “Well, your brains and your cock, let’s be honest.”

Rose laughed, carefree and playful. She released him, heading for the stairs before pausing to unbutton her wet coverup. Shrugging out of it, Tyler's eyes were glued to her body, encased in a pale pink string bikini.

"All the guys were staring at you in that suit, you know. Hope you keep wearing it."

She glanced over her shoulder as she fingered the loopy tie at her hip. "You know what we talked about. This is the last time you'll be able to take it off."

Tyler peeled his own wet shirt off without bothering to unbutton it, and Rose eyed him with her own once over. "I know, and I'm a big boy." He approached. "But that doesn't mean you should take away the view."

"Oh, did I call you creative? I take that back."

"Come here, I'll show you creative." Tyler reached for her, but she dodged away, skipping up the stairs with a shrieking laugh.

The two disappeared out of the frame of the camera.

"GIVE ME THAT COCK!" Rose clutched at the sheets beneath her as Tyler fucked her from behind, yanking her hips back with each thrust. "Give it to me hard!"

Their bodies glistened, sweat slithering across their golden, sun-warmed skin. Tyler didn't hold back. He fucked her just the way she was begging him to—hard and deep and powerful.

"You want it harder?" he growled.

Rose moaned something that was neither a yes nor a no.

"Harder than this?" He slapped her ass cheek, and a cry ripped through Rose. "You like getting spanked?"

Rose said something that neither the camera mics nor Tyler could hear.

"What's that?" Spank! "What's that, Rose?"

"Spank me," she whispered.

"Louder. Speak louder."

"Spank me!" she screamed. "I've been so naughty. Spank—" Slap! "—me!"

"You've got such a spankable ass, Rose. Such a naughty, spankable ass." He grabbed her hair, conveniently gathered in a ponytail, and pulled

hard enough to rock her head back.

“Oh, God!” Her moan was throaty and raw.

“Come, Rose. Come all over my cock.” With her head bowed back and her shoulders low, he sank his hand into her reddened ass and rammed his point home. “Do it. Right. Now!”

Rose screamed, her eyes clamped shut, her nostrils flaring. It wasn’t a sound she’d ever made in the bedroom—until Tyler. Now she seemed to let go like this every time.

“THAT LOOKED PAINFUL,” Andy said.

“It was.”

“But you liked it.”

Rose thought about it. “Mmm, I did. But I couldn’t do it all the time.”

“Want me to try?”

“Maybe, yeah. But honestly, I like what we have going so much more.”

“And if you need that,” Andy said, pointing to the monitor, where their homemade sex tape was paused, “Tyler is just down the road.”

Rose laughed. “Not something you need to worry about, honey. I don’t need it. What I need, right now, is for you to get your cock back in me so we can finish this viewing.”

“My pleasure.”

THE ANGLE of the camera in their guest bedroom was high enough to offer a perfect view of Tyler’s cock pushing into Rose’s pussy. She was on her back now, and he held her thighs against his chest as he screwed her from a kneeling position. Each thrust struck her g-spot before sinking into her depths. Each withdrawal felt like a tragic loss.

Rose reached down and ran her fingers across her bare mound. She played with her clit, swollen and overused after an afternoon of nonstop sex.

“That’s it, baby. I love it when a woman takes things into her own hands.”

Rose rubbed faster, circling her clit with the tips of her index and ring finger until it was a blur. Tyler leaned back so that each time he entered her, he'd press even harder against her g-spot. It was enough to ignite yet another climax, her voice already hoarse from the countless ones before.

"You're like some kind of sex machine," Rose said with a laugh once she'd come down.

"You're not the first to call me that." He didn't even bother to sound wounded. "I could say the same about you. You've got a body built for fucking."

"I don't know about that. I'm already so sore."

"Yet you don't want me to stop, do you?" he asked. He hadn't stopped, although he'd slowed his thrusts and leaned forward to take some pressure off. "You see, being a verified sex machine is more of a mindset."

"Very zen."

"Then I think I've found my nirvana."

Rose laughed, this time at him rather than with. "You should have stopped at the mindset."

He smiled, but didn't come back with a witty riposte. Instead, he just fucked her, quietly, tenderly. When he did speak, there was thought behind it. "You know, this week has been amazing."

"Don't, Tyler."

He smiled weakly. "I won't. I respect your boundaries. That doesn't mean that I won't miss such easy access to good sex."

Rose snorted. "So my best feature is that I live within walking distance of you?"

"You've got a pretty good ass, too."

Rose giggled. "Gee, thanks."

Then the most mischievous thought lit through her like a bright, sinful red light.

"Say, Tyler, have you met my neighbor, Jordan?" She couldn't keep the smile from her face. "Remind me to introduce her to you. I think you two will get along very nicely."

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

I'm just a guy who writes what I like to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. I write romantic erotica. I write about characters that I like, and endings that feel natural. I write stories where husbands watch their wives get naughty. I write about MILFs and erotic games and loss of innocence. I believe in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

Find me online at www.kennywriter.com, or follow me on Twitter at [@kennywriter](https://twitter.com/kennywriter). I also operate eroticaformen.com, which may or may not look like crap right now.



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Smart, successful, yet a little conservative, he never thought Katie would entertain such an idea... until she does. This suburban couple is about to take a wild ride as they turn fantasy into reality. Don't miss this marital adventure as Katie and Max try something forbidden.

Kenny Wright also regularly contributes to the Best Hotwife Books anthology:

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